

Phil 306 The Primacy of Beauty

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 306 • Dr. John Vervaeke

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Lecture 1: The Decline of Beauty

At a glance — Vervaeke opens on the decline of beauty and why beauty deserves primacy.

- 1.1 Welcome. This is a course entitled The Primacy of Beauty. It's going to be all about beauty. It's deeply influenced, and you won't see that for quite a while, but it's deeply influenced by an important essay by a friend of mine, D.C. Schindler, called "The Primacy of Beauty, the Centrality of Goodness, and the Ultimacy of Truth." I hope someday to do a course on all three, but today we're working on beauty.
- 1.2 Now, that's a very odd thing to say, the primacy of beauty. How is beauty primary? I want to talk about the status of beauty for us now, today. I want to talk about what I call the fall of beauty. I want to make use of some ideas from Byung-Chul Han, philosopher, in a recent book from 2018 called Saving Beauty. Listen to the title. Saving Beauty. We're at a risk of losing beauty. That's an odd thing to say.
- 1.3 Now, what Han points out is that beauty used to be considered sacred. It used to be considered an occurrence of truth. These are odd things. Occurrence of truth. How does the truth occur? How can beauty be sacred? Augustine, who wrote maybe the first autobiography in the history of the West, very famous, important thinker, philosopher, theologian, called God "beauty, ever ancient and ever new." God isn't just beautiful. God is beauty.
- 1.4 Now, before you get worried, this isn't going to be a religious thing I'm doing, but I'm not going to avoid the fact that beauty used to be associated with sacredness. And what does that mean? If you take a look, both Dionysius, a founding figure for Eastern theology and philosophy, and Thomas Aquinas, an important figure for Catholicism and Protestantism, the West in general, argue that beauty is an important name of God. It's one of the primary ways in which God manifests himself or herself in the world. In fact, there's a living tradition from Plato all the way through to Aquinas of treating beauty in this really exalted fashion.
- 1.5 Now, we've got this ancient association, therefore, with sacredness and the occurrence of truth. Now, I'm trying to say these things to you, but I hope it looks like it, these are strange things. We don't think of beauty that way. What is meant by sacredness? For many of us, that's not a clear idea anymore. The occurrence of truth, what does that mean? Is truth an event? That doesn't sound like the way we think of truth. How could God be beauty? What the heck does that mean? See, all of these questions sound very strange to modern ears. And yet they used to be the most prominent ways people spoke of and experienced beauty.
- 1.6 Now, what happened? Well, I think one of the things that happened is modernity is dominated by what Paul Ricoeur, famous philosopher, called a hermeneutics of suspicion. First of all, what's hermeneutics? Hermeneutics is a framework, a set of practices for how you interpret, how you make sense of and interpret something. A

hermeneutic suspicion, what does he mean by that? Well, he points to the really influential work of people like Nietzsche, Freud, Marx, and others, who have taught us to be very suspicious of appearances.

- 1.7** Appearances are deceptive. They're distractive. They hide or mask a secret agenda. We're very suspicious of everything these days. We're very suspicious. Well, what about that? I don't know. Everybody is, in that sense, very cynical, we're very cynical, this hermeneutics of suspicion. It's very pervasive. Let's pause here and let's think. If I'm going to say that something is an illusion or a delusion, what's actually going on there? What's actually going on?
- 1.8** This is a point that's been made repeatedly by philosophers, and the fact that they repeatedly made it means we need to constantly remember it. Plato has made it, Merleau-Ponty has made it. This is the idea that you can only point to something as an illusion by comparing it to something else you treat as real. Real and illusion are comparative terms. When I say something is illusory, I say in comparison to this, it's not real. So the shadow is only the illusion or appearance of a stick; the stick is actually the real thing. The reflection in the water of my face is not really a face. My face is the real thing. Is that making sense?
- 1.9** OK. So real is a comparative. It's like tall. You can say that's tall, and you should ask, well, in comparison to what? OK, now, what does that mean then? If we slow down and we zero in on this. The hermeneutics of suspicion, the accusing of appearances as being deceptive and distractive, is actually dependent on another relationship to appearances. Not where appearances are distractive or deceptive, that's the hermeneutics of suspicion, but where appearances disclose what's real.
- 1.10** Remember, the hermeneutics of suspicion depends on the judgment, the interpretation of something else as real. So although appearances can be distractive and be misleading, the hermeneutics of suspicion, they can't all be that. That'd be like saying everything is tall. It doesn't make any sense—everything is tall—it doesn't make any sense. There has to be, what is it in comparison to? There has to be a hermeneutics whereby appearances disclose what is real.
- 1.11** Now, what would that mean? Well, notice that this is a different sense of truth. See, in a modern way, we think of truth as, here's a concept or a claim, and it corresponds to reality, and that's just the relationship. What's going on here is a perceptual experience of realness being disclosed through how things are appearing to us. Another way of saying this is, we realize—I want you to remember that word, realize, because it's a great word. It means you make sense of, but it also becomes real. We realize through, and I'm using both senses of the word through, by means of beyond, like the way I'm looking through my glasses. We realize through appearances, perceptual experience, something that is real.

- 1.12** Now, notice we're already starting to get a little bit about what the moment of truth would be. That's that moment of realization. That's truth as an occurrence. We have that phrase, the moment of truth, where, oh, right. Oh, now I know what all this means and what's really going on. Now, this notion about when perceptual experience, appearance, discloses reality, that is the ancient notion of beauty. That's what beauty primarily is. Beauty is when we have a perceptual experience through which we realize how something is real. We realize a deeper reality. That's very far from our notion today of what beauty is.
- 1.13** The hermeneutics of suspicion depends on a hermeneutics of beauty, which is bound up with the occurrence of truth, bound up with realization, bound up with that moment of insight when you go, aha, right. I get it now. One reason why beauty has fallen is because we have eviscerated it with the knives of our suspicion. But the problem is, and this is an irony, because behind the hermeneutics of suspicion is actually a hidden hermeneutics of beauty that we have forgotten to some significant degree.
- 1.14** So Han says, well, what have we replaced it with? What have we replaced it with? What have we replaced this ancient notion of beauty with? From the framework of hermeneutic suspicion, what is the surrogate of beauty? How do we see beauty? He talks about what he calls the aesthetic. Aesthetics is the study of art, which is sometimes the study of beauty. He talks about the aesthetics of the smooth. We like things that—look at this, look at this lectern. It's so smooth. Look at the floor. It's so smooth. Everything is smooth. Your cell phones are smooth. Your watch surfaces are smooth. Everything is smooth and clean. You look around, it's all this smooth. We want things to go smoothly. What a weird thing to say, actually.
- 1.15** What is it about the smooth? Well, let's point to some features of it. The smooth is not challenging. It's like, yeah, I get it. It's readily available. It's easily consumable by me. It's easily usable. It's in no way shocking. It doesn't require any insight. No, it's just like, yes, the smooth. There's no obstacle to our consumption or use. Now, he immediately connects that to some of the work that he did in an earlier book called *The Agony of Eros*, 2017, to his discussion of pornography. I'm not going to say anything graphic here. I'm just going to talk about pornography.
- 1.16** He argues that pornography is the epitome of the ethics of the smooth that is masking and preventing us from having an experience of beauty. Because when you're looking at the pornographic object, that other, and this is why we talk—we even use the language of objectification. That other is completely consumable by us. We don't care to know anything more about them. We don't want to have any insight into them. We don't care how fake it is. The other poses no obstacle. There's no resistance whatsoever to our pleasure. It's easily consumable pleasure in which we do not care whether or not it is real. There's no challenge, no mystery.

- 1.17** Now, I have to stop here because I've introduced another word we use all the time and we don't use it correctly. I'm going to do that a lot in this course, because how we use language really shapes how we think. When people hear the word mystery, they think of a mystery novel. Now, here's the thing. Mystery novels don't actually have mystery in them. Mystery novels are problems that are difficult to solve, and when you solve the problem, you're done. If you were reading a mystery novel and you never found out who did it, it would turn from a pleasure into some hell. But who did it? But who did it? But who did it?
- 1.18** OK. I want you to compare this to another phenomena. When I was living with one of my stepsons, he had a smaller whiteboard in his bedroom. Because I'm a cognitive scientist and a psychologist and a philosopher, and he was an adolescent, I would write things on his whiteboard to try and be provocative. I thought that was a good way of being a father figure. I don't know. He says it was. We'll see. But I would go in and write things. Here's one of the things I once wrote, and it really twisted him. It's like, does time take time to happen? What? When you're trying to think about what time is, well, time is things moving, but doesn't motion require time? Oh, yeah.
- 1.19** Notice what happens. This is an idea of what a mystery is. Mystery actually means to close your mouth and close your eyes. It means to fall into silence. It doesn't mean to get an answer. Gabriel Marcel, in one of his important essays on existential mystery says, "What happens in a mystery is we have something we think is a problem and we put a frame around it." Now, we'll get a lot more into what that framing is, but just think about the way we box things and focus on them, what we're concentrating on, how we understand it.
- 1.20** Remember when I talked about hermeneutics as a framework of interpretation? We have a problem and we think we put this, oh, does time take time to happen? Then we realize that the framework is itself problematic. We go, oh, I need a bigger frame. Then we go out to there and we go, wait, that's not working. We get this trajectory, and then we get a sense of, oh, this isn't going to end. This isn't going to end.
- 1.21** Now, you want some things—and we'll come back to this—you want some things. I'm going to use the word "entity" because the word "thing" sounds like an object. The word entity is very neutral. It's anything I can think about. Is that OK? It's a philosophical term. It helps us from misunderstanding. I'm going to say this, and then I'll come back to it, develop it. You want your partner to be a mystery. You don't want them to be a problem you solved. Think about that. Think about if you said that to them. "You know, I got you. I completely understand you and I know what you are, through and through." How is your relationship going?
- 1.22** Now, why do you want them to be a mystery? Because you have a sense that reality actually exceeds your grasp of things. If you're mature and not a narcissist, and I'm hoping none of you are, because if you are, this lecture won't matter to you because it's not making you the center of attention. But notice what you get. You get, oh, there's

something, and I'm going to use that word again, I want to realize this person. I want to come to know them more and more, and I want to help them more, become more and more real. Help them actualize who and what they are, their identity.

1.23 When you love somebody, you want to participate in realizing their identity with them and allowing them to do that with you, and you get that bond. What you get is, I'm never going to get—I'm straight, so I'm just going to use that language for a way of talking. I don't mean anything by it. It's just easy for me. I'm never going to fully get her because she's real. I want you to remember that. There's something—we're going to come back to this again and again— there's something inexhaustible about realness.

1.24 Let's go back to the shadow and the stick. You examine the shadow and you get a few things about it, and there's not much more you can learn about it. But the stick, oh, my gosh, there's all kinds of facts and more and more things you can understand. That's how you know the difference between a dream and reality. I hope you think this is reality. If it is a dream, it's a really bizarre and boring dream, and you should see your therapist. The dream world doesn't have that inexhaustibleness to it. The illusion doesn't—the bent stick in the water. Yeah, but if I do some more exploration, I find that the bent stick disappears. Illusions can disappear. They can cease to be. Reality is inexhaustible. Do you see how mystery points us towards that?

1.25 OK, let's develop this in conjunction with another idea. This is an idea from Erich Fromm, and I've already laid out it intuitively, but I want to make it a little bit more clear because I want to be able to use it throughout. So Fromm made a distinction between two kinds of modes. What's a mode? What's an existential mode? So, an existential mode is made up of a relationship between an agent and an arena. This is work that Chris Mastropietro and I did making use of Clifford Geertz's idea.

1.26 Right now, I'm adopting a particular shape of agency. I'm taking on a particular role. Yes? I'm a teacher, and I'm assigning identities to this space. It's a space in which being a teacher makes sense. This is an arena, and you are students, and here's a board, and yes? See how the two identities are bound together. If I try to take up my teaching role with my partner, things are going badly. She will sometimes say that to me. She'll say, "I'm not one of your students." You've probably made mistakes like that. You realize, oh, right. I'm not getting this right.

1.27 So, an existential mode is when you are enacting an agent-arena relationship. You have lots of existential modes because they are ways in which your identity takes place. I'm a teacher. I'm a lover, in the sense that I have a partner that I love. I'm a father. I'm a friend. I'm a citizen. I assume you have multiple roles. Part of what yourself is, and we'll talk about this later, is you're trying to thread through all of those and keep them together and related somehow.

1.28 Now, Erich Fromm talked about two really crucial existential modes. He talked, and they're organized around two kinds of needs. It's the having mode, which is organized

around having, and what he called the being mode. I think it would have been better to call it the becoming mode or the developmental mode, but I understand what he means. You need to have things. You need to have oxygen. You need to have water. You need to have food. You need to actually be able to really control these things and consume them. There's nothing evil in that because if you don't do it, you're dead.

1.29 Now, how do I relate to things in that mode? I relate to them as problems to be solved. They're either things that will give me, satisfy my having needs, or are obstacles I have to overcome. So I relate to things in what Martin Buber called, and notice this is an agent-arena relationship, an "I-it." Things are it. This is a marker. I categorize it, I know how to solve problems with it, and I understand it only insofar as it belongs to a category of other markers, and I want to be able to manipulate it and control it.

1.30 But as we've already talked about, you know this isn't your only mode. Imagine again if I said that to my beloved partner. "You know why I'm with you? Because you remind me of all the other women I've been with. I can easily put you into that category and allows me to predict and control you and consume you as I need." Not good. There's another mode we have. The being mode is the mode in which you are trying to not have something. You satisfy these needs by becoming something.

1.31 For example, you have a need to become mature. And mature is to face reality. Now, notice that. Remember our little diagram? When I'm trying to face reality, I'm ultimately having to confront a mystery. It's not a problem I can fully ever solve or get complete control of. If you think you have complete control of reality such that it's consumable to you, you're very, very immature. I'm not in an I-it relationship with my partner. I'm in an I-thou relationship, and I'm in that relationship precisely because it is a way of maturing. It is a way of growing up. It is a way of facing a deep, mysterious reality in another person.

1.32 Being in love. Compare having sex to being in love. Now we've circled back. Do you see what the pornographer is all about? We're having sex, and we are not confronting the mystery of another person. When you treat something from the wrong mode, when you're trying to satisfy your being needs, from the having mode, that's modal confusion. I need to mature. Well, I know what I'll do. I'll buy a car. I'll have a car. I need to be in love. I know what I'll do. I'll have lots of sex. That's modal confusion. You see, the pornographer is actually, with the aesthetics of the smooth, luring us into modal confusion. Just like advertisers are luring you into modal confusion. If you just buy this shampoo, everybody will love you.

1.33 Now, this tells us something right away. Just like we have to be in the right mode to properly, to be in right relationship to a person, or to reality, we will need to be in the right mode, the right relationship, in order to appreciate beauty. The aesthetics of the smooth hides that fact from you. It's no challenge, no requirement. There's nothing you need to do. Just open up the mouth of your consumption and eat, whatever it is.

- 1.34** Notice there's these different orientations. There's consumption, and now I'm going to use an ancient word, contemplation. Well, contemplation means coming into right relationship with things from the being mode. Many of you do contemplative practices, and you'll know what I'm talking about. Now, let's pick up something else about the smooth. The smooth has a really important property that goes with the hermeneutics of suspicion, another important one. When I want to project onto a screen, I need the screen to be smooth. I need it to be empty. I need it to be blank. I need it to be completely hidden behind whatever I'm projecting. It's a bad screen if it doesn't do that.
- 1.35** Now, in the ancient view, beauty showed that there was something in reality beyond our grasp of it. We've mentioned this. In fact, the Greek word, one of the important Greek words, again, if you didn't, well, my hope is, my suspicion is, I hope that's not a pun, my suspicion is that if you weren't doing this lecture, this wouldn't make any sense to you. One of the important Greek words for beauty, ancient Greek words, was kallos, which means to call. Beauty is a calling to us.
- 1.36** As Scarry would talk about, it's like beauty greets us, almost like a person. It's an encounter with another, a mysterious other. Now, compare that to a notion from these important figures within the hermeneutics of suspicion. Nietzsche, Freud, Marx. They're all deeply influenced by Feuerbach, who you probably haven't heard of. But the idea I'm talking about is the idea of projection. You're just projecting. You're just projecting. You're just projecting. Now, notice that only works if you're projecting onto something that is smooth, that is an empty screen.
- 1.37** What's behind—and this is ironic because I'm saying there's something behind the hermeneutics of suspicion—what's behind the hermeneutics of suspicion is a model of reality as indeterminate, empty, shallow. Like a screen, and we project on. Or it's like a canvas that we paint our experience on. Why do we like that, according to Han? Because the thing is, if we can project onto it, that means it has no depth. If it has no depth, there aren't any hidden secrets lurking beneath it. We're completely safe.
- 1.38** See, the hermeneutics of suspicion wants to make you see the world is actually something that you can smooth, that you can project upon, and you don't have to worry about those depths, those hidden things getting you. But notice this language. Smooth, empty, shallow. Would you like your life to be like that? These are features, and we'll talk about this later, that people use when they describe their lives as meaningless. They use something very similar to smooth. It's all flat. It's all flat. It's empty. It's shallow. It's like, oh, no. Something deeply meaningful is missing when we really live from the hermeneutics of suspicion.
- 1.39** We're going to see that there's an alternative model. It's one that we've had some hints about, that reality is actually a plenitude. Reality is actually an inexhaustible source of new meaning. That could give us some idea about what beauty could be. Beauty could be the shining forth into our experience of that inexhaustibility.

- 1.40 Now, let's return back to Han. What's another way in which beauty has fallen? We've done a lot on the hermeneutics of suspicion and the aesthetics of the smooth. What I'm trying to do is make all of this very problematic because I'm trying to open up a space so we can reconsider the ancient model of beauty because that's what D. C. Schindler is arguing for. I want to say, David's a friend of mine, and his work has been just profoundly and in an ongoing fashion influencing me. I want to try and show you why this is the case.
- 1.41 OK, back to Han, though. What does pornography also point to? It points to another way in which we have caused beauty to fall. This is a Darwinian reductionism. I'm a scientist, so I'm a big believer in Darwin, so I'm not here to make people who want to say the Earth is only 6,000 years old, something like that. I'm not trying to do that. That's not what I'm talking about. But Darwin is a scientist, and therefore, as a scientist, we should be able to criticize his thought as well.
- 1.42 This is an idea, and there's lots of books that are around this, and a lot of people say this. Beauty is just a byproduct of sexual attraction. That's all it is. When we're talking about beauty, all we mean is we want to have sex with it. That's all we mean by it. Now, right away, that can't quite be right because a lot of music is beautiful. A mountain could be beautiful, and it's like, your child is beautiful. All of this is, like—but let's just go ahead. This is the idea. We have genes that determine our behavior, or Dawkins talks about memes, ideas that are parasites in our mind. They are deceiving us. They are making us attracted to people. Dawkins talks about that as the selfish gene. The gene doesn't care about you. It's selfish.
- 1.43 Or one of my colleagues from the University of Toronto, Keith Stanovich, talks about the robot's rebellion, the idea that the memes and the genes are making us do stuff that isn't to our benefit. We all know. I shouldn't presume, I'm much older than many of you. I've come to realize I can't trust my automatic sexual attraction radar because all it cares about is genetic matching. It doesn't care about my happiness at all. You have to be really careful about that.
- 1.44 Now, all of that has some interesting things to say to us about sexual attraction, et cetera, but that's not our topic here. Our topic is beauty and the fall of beauty right now. I want to say, and I've already hinted at this, that there's important cognitive science—and Stanovich is a psychologist and cognitive scientist—there's important cognitive science that actually challenges this reduction of beauty to mere sexual attraction. That's deceptive. You see the hermeneutics of suspicion still. It's deceptive. It doesn't care about you. You're just a machine for reproducing your genes or reproducing your memes.
- 1.45 This is the psychological phenomena called fluency. This has got a lot of research, ongoing. You just go into Google Scholar and type in the psychology of fluency, you'll get a ton of articles. I'm not going to cite any one person around this. There's just so

much work being done. What is fluency? Fluency is something like the ease of processing.

- 1.46** If I give you the same text and I give it to you in two different formats, one is black on white and the other is blue on green, you can still read it. Do you understand? But it's a little bit more difficult to read. The exact same text, and you read it black and white or you read it blue and green. Do you understand? It's a basic experiment. Then I asked you to judge the text. You're much more likely to say the text is true and beautiful. Notice those are associated together in people's judgments, contrary to the hermeneutics of suspicion. People will say, "That writing was beautiful and is probably true." What about the same text, word for word the same, blue-green? "That was kind of ugly. I don't think it's true."
- 1.47** What's going on there? An important point is, this is process-based. It's what's called domain general. It's not dependent on the content of what you're doing. It's dependent on how you're doing it. You can get it with reading a text, you can get it with trying to manipulate a spatial puzzle. Many, all kinds of tasks, you'll get fluency effects. Do you understand? It's not bound to any particular kind of object, any particular domain. It's reflecting something really fundamental about your cognition. I'll come back to that.
- 1.48** It's process-based, it's domain general. Judgments of beauty and truth that are being driven by fluency, and they are being driven by fluency, are not based on any particular object or kind of object, nor are they based on any particular domain of experience. Did you get that? It's not based on any particular kind of object. It's process-based, and it's not based on any particular domain of experience. It's really general.
- 1.49** What does that mean? Beauty can't be belonging to a particular kind of object in a particular kind of domain. It can't be reducible to properties of sexual objects because then you can't explain the massively replicated finding of fluency effects on judgments of beauty and truth. I keep reminding you, those are woven together for people. OK, does that make sense as an argument? It's like, whoa, OK, wow, something else is going on here. We'll come back to fluency and ask what's going on in fluency in a bit, but we haven't finished what we're doing right now, which is the fall of beauty.
- 1.50** The final dimension of the fall is the replacement of beauty, which is called the aesthetic sense. This starts in Kant, and it picks up. If you take a course on aesthetics, you very probably will not talk about beauty in that course. You will talk about the properties of art, what makes something a work of art. We've shifted from talking about beauty to talking about art. Now, don't misunderstand me. I think we should talk about art. I think we should talk about anything that's important to human beings. But notice that shift has also shifted our attention away from beauty.
- 1.51** Now, this notion of art also reverberates back in the way—it not only makes us ignore beauty, it makes us dismissive of it. Let me try and explain that. A really important book on aesthetics, maybe, I think, Ridley from 1998, was correct to say this is one of the

most important influential ideas in aesthetics in the 20th century, was Collingwood's *Principles of Art* from 1958. What Collingwood does is—let's take a look at—I'm choosing this very carefully. I don't know, how many of you have ever seen *Guernica* by Picasso? It's that famous picture with the horse and the light bulb above. I think they have hanging in the UN or something because it's about the bombing of Guernica in 1937 by the Nazis in the Spanish Civil War.

- 1.52** Now, what is Picasso trying to get with this? If you look at it, it doesn't have verisimilitude. It doesn't look like a photograph of the Battle of Guernica. That's not what he's trying to get. He's not trying to help you do an "I-it." He wants you to realize there was something absolutely, horrifically unique about this event. He wants you to really contemplate it, not just consume it. The work of art is trying to get you to see how things are in their uniqueness. Collingwood talks about not seeing things categorically, but seeing them expressively. Listen to that language. We talk about how things are expressed in art.
- 1.53** Notice, oh, by the way, express. What does that word mean? To push out. To push out onto the empty screen, onto the blank canvas. You express yourself. The idea is, art is trying to shift you into the being mode so you can contemplate something as you would a thou, an individual. You're trying to see what's unique about this. This is unlike other moments of war, and that's why *Guernica* is an astonishing work of art. I would think many people would not call *Guernica* beautiful. It is shocking and horrific, but it's a great work of art because it does exactly what Collingwood is talking about. Do you see that?
- 1.54** The unique is shocking. It wants us to realize how something is different from all the other members of a category, and that this difference matters, and we should come into a proper appreciation of it. Now, when we take a look at the work of Elaine Scarry, which we'll get to, we'll see beauty also has something to tell us about you shocking. The ancient world talked about beauty as shocking, by the way, and talks about uniqueness. There's some overlap here, but there are other important properties to beauty, other than the shocking uniqueness. There was a very famous TV series, mini-series, called *The Shock of the New*, about art.
- 1.55** Because what's going on here? When you get to the aesthetics of the smooth, we don't have beauty available to us. So art is going to rely on the shock of the new, the shock of the unique. It can be ugly. It can be horrific, like *Guernica*. The emphasis on shock and uniqueness prioritizes originality. It prioritizes a triad of things. The work should be as original as possible because if it's like anything else, oh, it's derivative, it's formulaic. It just belongs to the category. It can't possibly be a work of art. See, I'm falling into that horrible snobby accent. I don't mean to be.
- 1.56** Connected to that individuality, the artist must be expressing their uniqueness, their individuality. It has to be an act of self-expression, something that only they are experiencing in this way. That means we get an emphasis on confrontational self-

expression. A lot of art is designed to shock you and make you realize that you're confronting the originality and the individuality of the self-expression of the artist. Art becomes obsessed with the history of art. How is this related to art? How is it new? How am I different from Picasso? And et cetera, et cetera, et cetera.

- 1.57** Now, again, this isn't a lecture on art, but what we have is that all of this move, the replacement of beauty by the aesthetic of art, emphasizes subjectivity. Subjectivity. This is my unique personal experience, and all I'm doing right now is an act of self-expression about it. We get the idea "art for art's sake," and "beauty is in the eye of the beholder." Of course, when reality is smooth, empty, shallow canvas, subjectivity is free to paint on it as it wants. It's not bound by anything at all. The freedom of self-expression and the world being a blank canvas go hand in hand.
- 1.58** In this, beauty either disappears or it's completely disconnected from truth, objectivity in any way, and it's also disconnected from the good. Although there's something been going on in art in the last 10, 15 years that is trying to reorient because this has been understood, because the good is about how we ought to behave. What does that have to do with subjective self-expression? Now, again, I'm not here to get into art. I'm here just to point to a phenomenon to help explain the fall of beauty. I want to challenge this picture presupposed by this final reduction of beauty. But in order to do that challenge, I'm going to go back to the cognitive science of fluency, as I promised.
- 1.59** OK, so, thankfully, I left the term on the board. Fluency, ease of processing. Processing what? Well, everything, but that can't be right because you're always processing potentially anything or everything. So, this is a problem in psychology. We sometimes confuse naming an effect with explaining how it comes about. Ease of processing. But it has to be domain general. There has to be something we're doing that's very domain general that we're finding it, we can do very readily. Is that making sense? Because remember, fluency is domain general. And somehow, something that has a domain-general application, we're processing it in an easy manner.
- 1.60** It can't just be simple ease. For example, I can make something really easy for you by merely repeating it to you. Cat, cat, cat, cat, cat, cat, cat, cat. Now, notice you're not going, "How beautiful. Oh, I think that's true." In fact, you're going, "This is becoming meaningless." The word cat is losing its meaning. We got to get a better answer than just ease. Ease of what? Yes, it has to be domain general, but that doesn't mean just anything. We want to take a look at something that's domain general, a general process relevant to our judgments about truth and, ultimately, beauty, because fluency is affecting both of those.
- 1.61** We're not talking about any particular problem, any particular goal we're trying to achieve. We're talking about something really important about you. You are a domain-general problem solver. I talked a lot about this in a previous course I've done on intelligence, rationality, wisdom, and spirituality. I'm going to talk about this whole art line of argument a lot more when I do the nature of intelligence. If you want deeper

versions, go there. I guess that was a shameless plug for more Peterson courses, at least mine. So, it's a shameless plug for me, too.

- 1.62** What do I mean by that? Let's take a calculator. Calculator solves certain problems, yes? In that very limited way, it has a kind of intelligence. It can do arithmetic probably better than you. That's why you trust it in a way you don't trust yourself. When you're doing your bank accounting for your taxes, you don't go [noise]. You own a calculator. If you do it. But you don't ask your calculator to make you lunch. Or, hey, do you want to go to the beach and go swimming? Hey, do you want to learn about the Spanish Civil War? Hey, do you want to participate in a good conversation? That's ridiculous.
- 1.63** But you can do all of those and more. You can solve a wide variety of problems in a wide variety of domains in a wide variety of ways. This is why the quest is on right now within the LLMs, the large language models like ChatGPT, for what they're calling Artificial General Intelligence, because that's the kind of intelligence you have. You have general intelligence. Now, this was actually discovered way back in the 1920s by Spearman. He found that how kids did in any one subject was strongly correlated with how they would do in any other subjects in school, contrary to a lot of popular mythology we have, about people who are good at sports can't be smart and vice versa.
- 1.64** This has been a massively replicated finding. More and more sophistication, more and more revision of the test to weed out culturally specific knowledge, to weed out the effects of bias. All of these criticisms have been made of measurements of intelligence. They're good criticisms, but the thing you need to remember is that they have been responded to much better than any other social science predictor. This is why measures of g are so predictive, reliably predictive, of your health, your relationships, your longevity, et cetera.
- 1.65** First of all, I want to pause and make a note here. When we are talking about intelligence, we're actually now on the doorstep of an important term that's used in the ancient model of beauty. This is the word intelligibility. How many of you have heard that word, intelligibility? Some of you. What does intelligibility mean? It means how something makes sense to us. If something has intelligibility, I can make sense of it. I can come to understand it. I can gain knowledge of it. If it's unintelligible to me, I can't do that. Is that OK? The ancient world draws a lot of deep connections between beauty and intelligibility. I need you to put a pin in that. We're going to come back to that.
- 1.66** Let's go back to general intelligence. OK. What's going on in general intelligence? Well, it's what a—general intelligence is what allows you to be a domain-general problem solver. Now, here's a proposal that I have been arguing for since my thesis in '97, and I published on it in 2012, 2013, blah, blah, blah. I published on it just last year. I keep publishing on it. Just had a paper come out. Johannes Jaeger, the main author. It's just coming out now. So lots of publications on this, other people publishing on this.

- 1.67** If I'm going to find something that is domain-general to my problem solving, it has to be something, a feature, that all problems in some important way share. Doesn't that make sense? Because if it applies to all problems, it has to pick up on something that all problems share. So, general intelligence has to apply to meta problems. Meta means above. A meta problem is a kind of problem that all problems share. Here's the idea. General intelligence solves the meta problems that you have to solve whenever you're trying to solve any specific problem.
- 1.68** What are some candidates for those meta problems? Well, I've argued, and many people convergently argue, that there are two meta problems. One, and this is if you want some recent work on this, take a look at the work of Michael Levin. He's a biologist, cognitive scientist, at Tufts, and he has a lot of stuff online. I have some recorded dialogues with him if you're interested. He talks about a cognitive light cone. The idea is this. We can find a universal scale for talking about how intelligent an organism is by how deeply it can anticipate into the future. This is why—I'm sorry, I'm going to be treading on deeply religious ground here—we regard dogs as more intelligent than cats. We should, by the way, because we have evidence. I know, I know. There's the big debate. But cats are so aloof. Big deal. It's easy to be aloof. I love cats, by the way.
- 1.69** But you can do this. I also have a dog, Sadie, and I can say, "Sadie, go get your ball." She'll go to another room, look around, find it under some furniture, and bring the ball back. What do I say about her? I go, "Oh, you're so smart." Do that with your cat. Cat looks at you like, "Are you giving me food? OK, get lost." This is your ability to predict and prepare for the future. This is your ability of anticipation. Now, we have a huge and powerful framework within cognitive science, bridging between psychology and neuroscience and computer science, that talks about how intelligence is due to your brain's capacity to anticipate the world. It's called the predictive processing model.
- 1.70** Now, I'm not going to get technical about that. I get technical in the other courses. The basic idea here is what your brain is constantly trying to do is anticipate the world. One question you should be asking right away is, well, anticipate what? Hold that question. We'll come back to it, OK? Hold that question. But let's get at, what's the proposal about how your brain is doing this? Because the proposal, even at an intuitive level, has very important implications for our discussion of beauty.
- 1.71** The idea is actually all the time your brain is trying to anticipate the world. For example, if I'm moving and I start moving at a certain speed, the sensorimotor loop, the speed at which I get information in from my perception and I can send signals to my legs and my body, is too slow to get at that certain speed. What actually works? Well, you have your cerebellum, which is linked to your cortex, and what the cerebellum is doing is doing exactly that, which is why you sometimes trip.
- 1.72** Let's do another example of it. This one's a little bit more creepy for people. What color is this? White. Now, your eye can't actually take this all in. Your eye is what's called

subtending. It's taking little tiny samples from this, and then it's anticipating what the rest of it is. This is strange. You're actually—and I'm going to qualify this in an important way, but I'm going to say it now just to be provocative—you're actually imagining it much more than you're seeing it. That doesn't mean it's false because you can have true predictions. Does that make sense? As soon as you do that, whoa, that's interesting. I'm not going to get into hermeneutic suspicion. I'm going to be doing something else. Because some people, oh, all of reality is an illusion. I don't know what that means. That's like saying everything is tall. Compared to what? Compared to what?

1.73 Now, in psychology and cognitive science, we talk about top-down versus bottom-up processing. Top-down means it starts in the mind and works down to affecting perception. Was that OK? You can see this at work on all kinds of phenomena. A very famous one that predictive processing people like to do is they'll play some noises to you and you'll hear them go, "I don't know what that is." Then they'll say the sentence, "The shark is in the water." Then you listen to the same thing, you hear, "The shark is in the water." It's really creepy. I've had that done to me multiple times. Eventually, you want to say to the people, "Stop doing that," because it really, it's like, whoa. This is called top-down. Does that make sense? Is that OK?

1.74 Now, if you were just top-down, you'd be dreaming. There has to be bottom-up. There has to be, the information's coming up that tells you when you've made a mistake. Like when I trip. Oh, the floor isn't flat. I tripped coming into the room. There's that little tiny thing there. I didn't see it. Does that make sense? You've got top-down prediction and preparation, top-down anticipation, bottom-up detection and correction. That's happening moment by moment in everything you're doing. What does this help your brain do? Anticipate the world well and deal with how complex and big the world is, even though you are very small. It allows you to have a very significant cognitive light cone.

1.75 Now, when you have just the top-down, this is pure imagination. If you could have just the bottom-up, this would be pure perception. But you can't have either one of these pure. They're always mixed. Even when you're asleep and dreaming, you're getting a little bit of perception. That's why you can be woken up by a sudden noise. Now, I need to work with you on this word. Remember I said I'm going to be constantly going back and opening things up, because everything is crammed, reduced, fallen, smooth, and easily consumable by us so that we will buy more stuff until we die.

1.76 I'm going to make use of a distinction by another philosopher, Henry Corbin. If you get interested in his work, there's a whole bunch of books by Thomas Cheetham on Corbin. Big colleague of Jung, by the way, for those of you who are interested in Jung. Corbin has a huge influence on Jung, which Jung really doesn't admit. Jung has a huge influence on Corbin, which Corbin admits. I think Corbin is a better guy. Corbin made a distinction between the imaginary and the imaginal. The imaginary and the imaginal.

- 1.77** What's the imaginary? I want you to picture in your mind a sailboat. Are you doing it? Does it have its sails up or down? It doesn't matter. Now, notice what you're doing. You're forming a picture and you're looking at it. Does that make sense? You're forming a picture and you're looking at it, and it's actually taking you away from reality. Is that OK? It's almost pure this. Now, I want you to compare that to a child playing. Now, I'm going to ask you to make another note. Play. Play is going to turn out to be important. And notice we talk about play with respect to things that we consider beautiful, like playing music. Going to a play.
- 1.78** In tai chi chuan, which I practice and teach, you don't do tai chi, you play it. Same verb for playing music. Here's a child about to play, and they're going to pretend that they're Superman, and they tie a blanket around their neck, and they raise their arms, and they run around like this. Now, are they looking at an image of Superman? No. What they're doing is they're looking through an image of Superman. They're adopting the agent-arena relationship of Superman. What would Superman notice, and how would Superman respond?
- 1.79** That's the imaginal. You're not looking at an image, you're looking through it, so that you can see things within and without that you weren't seeing before. You can develop and grow. That's why kids play, so they can mature. The imaginal is linked to development and maturation. It is linked to the being mode. Is that all tracking? Now, I want to show you the imaginal. I've already shown you it without. That wall is imaginal. You're not picturing a wall in your mind, but you're looking through an image. Yes?
- 1.80** OK, now I want you to do another thing. I want you to multiply in your head 22 times 33. Can you do that? She looked up to her left or to her right. OK, so you went to that space, right? Is that space real? Is it a physical space? Can I crack open your skull and go, yeah, there it is. It's all good. There's the 22 and that's the 33. Is it a physical space in any way? OK, now, is it just a fiction? No, because that space allows you to become aware of your cognition and your thinking. Do you understand? That space inside your head, which is the core of your subjectivity and for many people, is actually imaginal in nature. The imaginal is within and without.
- 1.81** Notice that the imaginal is between the top and the bottom, and it's between the in and the out. It's doing this thing, of helping you to imagine so that you can anticipate the world, top-down, bottom-up, but it's also helping you realize within and without. This is the imaginal. Notice this isn't—notice what I keep doing. I give you a philosophical idea, but I show how it's grounded in cognitive science. OK, that's the first meta problem. What are we doing? We're addressing this issue off beauty being subjective. In order to do that, I went back to fluency. In order to get into fluency, I went into it being domain-general. We got into general intelligence. Then we're looking at general intelligence in terms of the two meta problems. One is anticipation, and we get that, and that gives us this notion of the imaginal.

- 1.82** Now we're going to take a look at the other meta problem, the one that I've been obsessed with for my whole of my academic career, and I've mentioned, at least alluded to. As I anticipate more and more into the future, what happens? What happens to my cone? It gets bigger and bigger. So I have to pay attention to more and more things. Yes? Now, let's just start intuitively. How many things could you pay attention to in this room? You can even be really boring. I'm going to pay attention to that little patch of white. Now this one. Now that one. I'm going to make a pattern. This one, that one, this one. No, that one, this one, this one. How many things and how many patterns of things could you pay attention to in this room? How many?
- 1.83** Huge. You don't. That's just right now. Now, you got to do that with the world going into the future. How many things can you remember? Is your memory full? Don't teach me anything, I'm done. How many things do you think you have in there? How many combinations of things? Aardvark, Australia, Captain Marvel. You know what your brain is doing right now? How are they connected? So all the things in there and all the possible ways you can connect them. How many possibilities are there? Logical possibilities. How many sequences of actions can you perform? Well, I could bend this finger and then this finger, or I could bend these two fingers, or I could bend all three, or I could bend this one. Are you getting a sense about this? This is a problem. This is a problem.

Lecture 2: The Return to Beauty

At a glance — The return to beauty, drawing on modern psychology, computer science, and AI.

- 2.1 Some of the important work done at the forefront of modern psychology and computer science and AI was work done by Newell and Simon on creating a general problem solver. They were trying to create artificial intelligence by making an entity that could solve problems in a domain-general way. They hit a crucial problem. They didn't succeed. I want to give you just a quick tour of their thinking.
- 2.2 They analyzed a problem into four components. Your initial state. This is the state you're in, and your goal state. That's the state you want to be in. If your initial state corresponds to your goal state, you don't have a problem. I want to be sitting. I'm sitting. No problem. I'm thirsty. I need to drink. I'm not drinking. I need to do something. Do you see? A problem exists when the space, and notice this is an anticipatory space, when the space opened up between the initial state and the goal state. Is that OK?
- 2.3 Now, what you can do is you can perform an operation that will change your initial state into another state. You could perform this one or this one or this one. Then when you're there, you could do that one and that one. This one, no, it's not going to get me anywhere. Oh, this has a lot of options. I can go there or there. It opens up, and right. Now, because you're a domain-general problem solver, you also have constraints on this. I want you to remember that. You don't want to solve this problem to the detriment of you solving other problems because you're a domain-general problem solver.
- 2.4 I could cook my food by burning down my house. Nobody goes, "Hey, that's brilliant." I've solved the one goal, but I've really reduced my chances of solving other problems. Does that make sense? OK. All right. So, a problem solution is any sequence of operations that will turn the initial state into the goal state while obeying the path constraints. You go, OK, great. They got all kinds awards and are famous for that. I can do that. That took me five minutes.
- 2.5 Well, here's the thing. Finding that pathway is really, really hard. See, the problem with this diagram is it misleads you. You're out here and you can see all of the pathways all at once, and you can see the one that stands out. In life, you're here and you don't know which of these. Why is that problematic? So Holyoak did a famous argument about this from the 1990s. He talked about a game of chess. Calculating the number of pathways here is F to the D . Number of options, number of steps. OK? A typical game of chess, at any one point, you have 30 legal moves available to you, on average.
- 2.6 Now, obviously, right near checkmate, that goes down. But on average, you have 30 potential moves. Now, you'll say most of them are stupid. You can't put that in here. We're trying to explain intelligence. We can't presume it. How many steps in a chess

game, on average? Sixty. That's the number of alternative pathways. That's greater than the number of atomic particles in the universe. That's why they're famous, because you didn't know that, did you? You see, what happens is, you don't search most of that space.

- 2.7** This sounds almost like a Zen koan. What you do is you ignore most of the information. Here's all the information, and you only search a little bit of it, and you find, because you're such a powerful general problem solver, you find the relevant information. You don't search it and say, "No, that's irrelevant." Imagine if I did that. "No, that's irrelevant to my lecture. That's irrelevant to my lecture. That's irrelevant to my lecture. That's, oh, the history of the British Empire, Alfred the Great, that's relevant to—" I can't do that. I couldn't even get out of bed. I have to ignore most of the information. I have to put a frame around it. I have to put a frame around it.
- 2.8** I call this relevance realization. You have to realize what's relevant. Here's the thing. Your brain is doing that so fluently that you get a mark of fluency in relevance realization. It's obvious to you what you should be doing. It's obvious I should be paying attention to John, at least I hope you are. It's obvious I should be thinking about mind and beauty and not about that picnic I went on three years ago. But you know what? Obviousness is not a property of the physics of the world. "Well, look, Look, Bill, 17 grams of obviousness. We should pay more attention here."
- 2.9** Because obvious is so fluent for you. It's like your glasses. It's transparent. You don't step back look at, "Yeah, but how did I find things obvious?" You're just like, oh, obvious, obvious, obvious, obvious. And sometimes, we'll come back to this in a sec, you make a mistake and go, oh, I thought she was angry, turns out she's afraid, so remember that. That's a moment of insight. We've talked about insight and realization with beauty. Now, notice something here. Is reality a blank slate? Is it an empty canvas? Is it that screen?
- 2.10** "If you could take off the glasses of obviousness, if the doors of perception were cleansed, then man would see things as they truly are, infinite." That's William Blake in a famous line. If you could take away all the obviousness of this, how many properties and facts are actually here? It's combinatorially explosive. It is vast. It is not a blank screen. It is an inexhaustible fount of intelligibility. Anything could, therefore, be opened up to you like that. Maybe beauty is when something does that to us. We go, "I didn't realize."
- 2.11** This is what you're not doing. You're not detecting relevance. Relevance isn't there like the solidity of this lectern. You, oh, relevance. Why? Because nothing is intrinsically relevant. This is relevant. Was it relevant three seconds ago? No. Other than being relevant, what do relevant things have in common? Some are big, some are small, some are fast, some are slow, some are complex, some are simple, some are familiar, some are less familiar. It's not intrinsic, it's not invariant, and it's not stable. When I

want to talk about what something has in it, it has to belong to it. It has to belong to it stably. It has to remain that way.

- 2.12** Relevance isn't objective. You can't detect it. Oh, see? They were right all along. It's purely subjective. Oh, really? Let's be careful. Can you sometimes be wrong about what you're considering relevant? Yeah. You go, "I thought she was angry, and it turns out she was afraid." If it's purely subjective, how can you be wrong? Why do you find moments of insight so powerful? Relevance realization is about problem solving. Are problems objective? Does the world in itself have problems? Nope, the world just is. Is your problem merely subjective? Well, no, because you often have to change the world in order to solve your problem. Yes?
- 2.13** This is weird. Relevance and problems, they are not clearly subjective or objective. I've coined a term for this. They're transjective. They're between us and the world. The way in which the world and I are fitted, when things are obvious, or not fitted, when things are problematic. Obviousness is a transjective phenomenon. Being a problem is transjective. Being relevant is transjective. Now, notice this is like another thing. Darwinian adaptation. The adaptivity of the great white shark. Is that in the shark? No. Take the shark out of the ocean, plop it in the desert. What happens to the shark? It dies. Is it just in the environment, objectively? That makes no sense. Adaptivity is transjective.
- 2.14** Perception works largely in terms of what are called affordances. I perceive that this floor is walkable. Yes? That's how agent-arena— I'm perceiving it in such a way that action becomes available to me. It's walkable. Now, is it walkable by all things? Can a blue whale walk on this floor? Can I walk on anything I want? I'm going to walk on the sun. Being walkable is not in me. It's not in there. It's the way me and that fit together. Do you get it? Affordances, adaptivity, relevance, problems, obviousness, these are all transjective in nature. We have this wonderful system. We think the world either cleanly falls into subjectivity or objectivity, and we're actually missing where our intelligence and problem solving are working. What if beauty is also transjective in nature?
- 2.15** We went from fluency to domain-general, to general intelligence, to anticipatory relevance realization, the fact that it's constantly correcting itself in insight. Let's just quickly dip into this because we're going to need some language here. OK, so this is a problem that's become somewhat associated with me. I'm not the author of it, but. It's called the nine-dot problem because there are nine dots. You have to join all nine dots with four straight lines, and you can't take your pen off the paper or the marker off the board.
- 2.16** People initially think this is really easy. One, two, three. Oh, wait. One, two, three. In fact, this is a really hard problem. How could it be hard? Look at how simple this is. But the solution rate is statistically indistinguishable from zero. Some people solve it spontaneously. Most people don't. So four straight lines. One, two, three, four. Why

was that so hard? Because you framed it in a certain way. It was obvious to you that those nine dots form a square. Therefore, the square is relevant to the solution.

2.17 It's obvious to you that this is a connect-the-dot problem. You did connect the dots as a kid. You don't change direction unless there's a dot. Because if you change direction and there's no dot, you don't get a picture of a daffodil, you get a Jackson Pollock painting. You assume, "I'm a dot connector, and I know about squares. It's obvious what I should do," and then you can't solve it. Notice what you have to do in order to solve a problem. You have to break a frame, and then you have to make a new way of framing it. You have to break a frame. So, in insight, you break a frame, and then you make a new way of seeing it, of framing it. Does that make sense?

2.18 It's a change in what you're finding salient, how things are catching your attention. It's a change in what Matheson called sizing up, what you're foregrounding and backgrounding. Normally, you don't pay attention to those. You only pay attention through them. So your relevance realization is evolving, just like organisms in the environment. That's an adaptivity and evolution are both transjective phenomena. Is evolution in the organism? That doesn't make any sense. Is it in the environment? No. It's about how organisms in the environment fit together, yes?

2.19 See how I can keep finding these phenomena for you? And yet our grammar for how we talk about things, subjective or objective, that's all, doesn't allow us to actually place any of these. Then we wonder why we don't have a place for beauty, and it's clearly not objective, so therefore it must be purely subjective. What happens with organisms? Here's an organism, here's the environment. I'm not going to try and draw something because that would be silly. You have a phenomenon called niche construction. It's part of how evolution works. Yes, the environment is putting selective pressure on the organism. The environment is shaping the organism, but the organism is also constantly shaping its environment.

2.20 What happens is, they mutually shape until they fit well together, and then you get belonging, connectedness. It's obvious to the beaver what it should do. It really is. You don't see beavers wrestling existentially. "I don't want to build a dam. I'm not in it. It's not working for me." They're not doing any of that. Or if they are, they're keeping it really secret, and the world's a lot more horrific than we thought. I want you to notice how insights between perception and understanding. When you have an insight, you have a new understanding.

2.21 But look at the word we use, insight. There's a change in salience. There's a change in how you're sizing things up. There's a change in the way you're seeing things. It's a bridge between perception and understanding. You don't do insights. "I need an insight now. OK, insight, go away. Go." You don't just receive insights. "I'm waiting for an insight." You participate in an insight. You do things, and then the insight starts to take shape, and you participate in it.

- 2.22** A lot of this language around insight and relevance realization is this language that people are using when they're trying to bring back the ancient understanding of beauty. That beauty involves a frame-breaking and a frame-making. Realization, that you participate. Or do you just do beauty? You just passively receive it? No, you participate in it. You're involved in it. Beauty has an element of self-correction in it, like insight. You realize, I didn't realize that a tree could look like that. You realize that your habitual ways of seeing and being could be in error. There could be a deep way in which you're not connected to reality.
- 2.23** And notice what's happening in insight. You go from appearances being deceptive to appearances disclosing reality. You have an occurrence of truth. You have a moment of realization. You even get that flash. It becomes more salient. It draws you in. You get involved and you feel happy. You don't go, "Oh, damn, an insight." You don't do that. You go, "I love my insights." Now, here's another connection. Topolinski and Reber argued very well, in 2010, scientific publication, that insight is a fluency spike. Insight is when fluency gets a lot better. You see how this is all connected together?
- 2.24** Well, what's fluency about? It's about relevance realization. What's happening in insight? You're evolving your relevance realization. That's giving you a spike in fluency. Do you see how it all hangs together? Leo Ferrero and Arianne Herrera-Bennett, I argued in 2018, a publication, that the flow experience is a cascade of insights. You know what flow is? People talk about this. You do improv or you do jazz or you do martial arts sparring, and you're in flow. And the athlete and the musician, and the improv people, they love flow. They love flow. It's one of the most important experiences people have.
- 2.25** You need flow in it to explain why people do rock climbing. Because rock climbing is otherwise completely absurd. What are you going to do right now? I'm going to go up this rock surface, and it's going to be hard, and I'm going to get hurt and I might fall and get really damaged or kill myself. What are you going to do when you get to the top? I'm going to come back down. People do rock climbing because they get into the flow state. Now, think about what's happening. You're looking at the rock face and you're, oh, you realize, "I might be misframing. I get stuck and I have to break that frame and get a new frame and move."
- 2.26** The jazz artist, "I've picked up pattern, but I've got to improvise on it." Do you see what's going on? You're going, aha, aha, aha, aha. Insight is a fluency spike, and flow is a fluency of insights. It's a cascade of insights. You love flow. If I wanted to ask if your life is meaningful, one of the best questions I can ask you is, how often do you get into the flow state? Because if you get into it more often, you're much more likely to say, "My life is meaningful."
- 2.27** Now, it's not perfect because we've invented a wonderful way to hijack the flow state, which is called video games. Video games can really make you believe that you can only find flow in the video game, and that's video game addiction. When you can't find flow

in the world, what's the opposite of flow? Depression. So the world is depressing, and in the game I flow, so I'm going to stay in the game as much as I can.

- 2.28** Another important thing about flow. You stop being egocentric in flow because you're really focused on the task. Because if you're not focused on the task, you'll fail. You got to be giving it your all, as we say. You know that horrible nattering nanny ego in your head? "How am I doing? How do I look? How's my hair? Can they see my stomach? How do I look? Do they like my shoes? How am I doing? How am I doing? Do they like me? How am I doing? Should I move? Am I making too much noise? How am I doing? How am I doing? Do they like me? How am I doing?" You know that voice? It goes away in flow.
- 2.29** You become un-self-centered. You lose that kind of—you don't lose consciousness. You lose that self-consciousness. You go through a process of unselfing. Here's the wonderful thing about flow. Flow points to a lie your ego tells you. The ego says, "Unless I'm in charge, your agency will fail. I have to be in charge at all times because, if I'm not in charge, your agency will fail." But flow says, actually, no. Look what happens when you put aside the ego. You actually have improved agency.
- 2.30** Fluency, insight, flow. There's a cognitive continuum between all of them, and all of them are overlapping with beauty. All of them are overlapping with beauty. When you're in the flow state, the world seems intensely beautiful to you. It's so beautiful, it's so elegant, it's so graceful. It flows. By the way, flow. Is your experience literally flowing? Well, no. Is that just an illusion? No. Flow is imaginal. It's how you are realizing this way you're coupled to the world. We can use this whole family of well established psychological phenomena to understand beauty and understand how beauty is not subjective. It's transjective in nature.
- 2.31** We can begin to think of beauty as imaginal transjectivity, like flow, like insight. Is there really a flash of light when you have an insight? Of course not. That's the way your brain makes certain things more salient to you. Stand out, catch your attention. We've challenged all of the dimensions of the fall of beauty. We've challenged the hermeneutics of suspicion. It depends on a hermeneutics of beauty. We've challenged the aesthetics of the smooth. We don't want the smooth and empty or flat. That's meaningless. We want to be coupled to a reality that can challenge us. We are coupled in that when we have relevance, fluency, insight, flow. We find our life more meaningful.
- 2.32** Why is that real? Because reality is not shallow, flat, and empty. It is combinatorially explosive. It is an inexhaustible fount of intelligibility. We cannot suck it dry. It will not fail. Maybe beauty is part of the promise of that. Beauty is a deep remembering that, oh, that promise has always been kept. Let's do this. Let's do this for—OK. Simple object, right? I know what that is. It's a brush. OK. Are you seeing the brush? Are you sure you're seeing the brush? Tell me when you see all the brush. Oh, guess what? You never see all of the brush. In fact, how many different aspects are there potentially?

And not just physical, I can also bring in more cognitive aspects. I could use this as the letter I. This looks like a car.

- 2.33** There's a plentitude of aspects. Every object is multi-aspectual. What's interesting, though—think about this, and John Russon makes this point—it's not like these aspects aren't identical. Try to think very logically here. Is this, as you're seeing it, identical to that? No. They're not logically identical, but you don't go, "What's that?" There's a throughline. There's a throughline running through all those aspects. The throughline is not itself an aspect because it binds all the aspects together. Do you get that? There's a throughline. It's not any aspect.
- 2.34** It's like music. The notes all belong together, but they're not identical to—this is not a good song [beeping]. It's not a good song, is it? There's a throughline, like a melody. There's a musicality to your intelligibility. John Russon talks about this in *Bearing Witness to Epiphany*, that throughline. And you should be able to tell me, what's the nature of that throughline? Is it objective? Is it something you're detecting and seeing? No, because I don't actually see the throughline. I see through the throughline. It's imaginal. And yet you're doing it all the time in every act.
- 2.35** What about the idea that beauty is just a Darwinian byproduct? Well, we put that aside with fluency. What about the replacement of beauty with the aesthetic? Well, the idea that beauty is just subjective, we've done this huge long argument because that's a really deep ingrained belief in our culture. Beauty is not subjective. Fluency is not subjective. We've talked about all these things, anticipation, relevance realization, that are transjective in nature, this evolving transjectivity, the ongoing indispensable need for the imaginal.
- 2.36** So, here's a possibility we can now consider. Possibly, beauty is imaginal, flowing niche construction. Something's beautiful when you've got an imaginal relationship to it. It opens up, you shape it, and it shapes you so you have a new way of belonging to the world that you didn't have before. Think about that. I hope I've done enough. I hope I've done enough to show you that the fall of beauty is something we can deeply question. Cleared a space for going back to—along the way, we keep bumping into ideas that were in that ancient model of beauty. We're going to go back to it.
- 2.37** The way we're going to do that is we're going to start by looking at a book that is considered really seminal in what's been called *The Return to Beauty*. This is Elaine Scarry's book from 1999, *On Beauty and Being Just*. So Han cites and makes use of Scarry, and somebody else whose work we're going to look at, Sonia Sedivy's work, also makes use of Scarry. So Scarry is going to be really influential throughout the rest of the course.
- 2.38** Scarry talks about five features of beauty. She talks about a passage from Homer where Odysseus is coming off the beach and he's seeing Nausicaa and he's struck. Listen to that language. He's struck by her beauty. That's not the smooth. That's not merely

subjective. When something strikes you, it's not subjective. He's struck by her beauty. It's like he's been greeted by something really, something new, encountering something other than what he's experienced before.

- 2.39** She lists some features of beauty that we can get from this ancient literature. One is, and here again, we're back to this weird notion. Beauty is sacred. It's a language she uses. I'm not imposing that on her. Beauty evokes—there's something beyond itself. There's something more going on. There's something really real going on here. Something's being called into a more encompassing framework. Zwicky, in his book, *The Experience of Meaning*, says that's what meaning is, when we situate something into a more encompassing framework, and we go, "Oh, right." So it's this experience of meaning. But what kind of meaning? Stop signs are meaningful. You go, "Oh, beautiful"? No. It's still not enough. We're going to have to keep coming back to sacredness.
- 2.40** The second factor she talks about is that beauty is unprecedented. It has this, "I've never seen something like that before." If you go, "Oh, yes, another beautiful mountain," you're being sarcastic. You mean it's not beautiful to you anymore. I've seen 17,000 of these. I don't care anymore. It's not meaningful to me anymore. There's something unprecedented. That gives us a little bit more because there's something about sacredness that's unprecedented. You don't treat sacred things the way you habitually treat normal things. When you're coming before something you may regard as sacred, you act in a very unprecedented way. You act very differently than how you act normally in the world.
- 2.41** When you go to church, if you go to church or you go to mosque or go to temple, I'm not picking any particular thing here, you don't act there the way you act in your everyday life. In fact, that's weird. You're not supposed to do that. Or think of an event that, even if you're not particularly religious, has an air of sacredness around it. You're at a funeral, the casket's there. How do you behave? Do you behave the way you normally behave? No way. If you do, people are like, "What's wrong with you? What's wrong with you?"
- 2.42** There's something, and now, and see, here's the overlap I promised you, there's something uniquely new about the beautiful, and that's how it overlapped with art. Remember? There's something uniquely new about the beautiful. What is this newness? Let's zero in on it. Well, it's like the frame-breaking in insight. When you have the insight, you go [gasp]. You give up a habitual way of seeing and thinking. Scarry makes use of somebody who deeply influences her, Iris Murdoch. Iris Murdoch wrote an astonishing little thin book. As I get older, I like thin books because I'm closer and closer to death. So, a little thin book called *The Sovereignty of the Good*.
- 2.43** In it, she gives this example, and then John Wright, a philosopher, picked up on it. So he gives this example of this mother-in-law, and she has a daughter-in-law. She doesn't really like the daughter-in-law. The daughter-in-law is coarse and loud and just doesn't

exercise proper decorum. But then something happens, and this is really tricky because it's a special insight. The mother-in-law realizes that she's been misframing the daughter-in-law. She starts to see, maybe she's not coarse, maybe she's spontaneous, maybe she's not decorum, maybe she's really grounded and authentic.

- 2.44 What she comes to do is she comes to not only see the daughter differently, she comes to change how she's seeing things in general. Do you see that? It's not like the nine-dot problem where you just do this one thing. This is a general. It has both of these aspects to it. It's not just reframing, it's transframing. You're not just coming up with a new frame, you're coming up with a new—in coming up with a new frame, you're also coming up with a new way of framing. John Wright calls that sensibility transcendence.
- 2.45 You're transcending how you normally are finding things obvious, how you habitually relate to them. You're led into a kind of radical questioning. Rilke in his famous poem about the archaic bust of Apollo, he's going through this and he's taking you through the tour of this bust and you're getting all of this. Then the poem breaks and there's a line. "You must change your life." That's the end of the poem. You must change your life. He confronts this beauty, and it leads to such sensibility transcendence that he realizes he has to change his life. There's something aspirational in the confrontation, the contemplative confrontation with beauty.
- 2.46 Now, this leads to the third factor that she points out. You can see how this just felt—beauty is life-giving. It's life-saving. Beauty makes the thing alive and makes you more alive. You come more alive and the thing comes. It's almost like it's alive. It's life-saving. It's life-giving. Augustine called beauty "a plank among the waves of the sea." You're in this overwhelming ocean, combinatorially explosive reality, and beauty is a plank that gives you life. It gives you life.
- 2.47 Scarry says it makes life worth living. That tells us something. That tells us that the nature of the kind of meaning in beauty. It's not the meaning of a sentence, like the cat is on the mat. You don't go, oh. I study, and many other people do, philosophy, psychology, what's called meaning in life, not the meaning of life. The meaning of life is some kind of metaphysical proposal about your destiny. I don't think you have such a thing. But maybe you do. I don't care. We're not dealing with that.
- 2.48 Meaning in life is, what makes your life worth living? Even when you're failing, even when things are frustrating you, even when you wake up at 3 AM and realize all your faults, "I'm a shitty person," what makes life worth living? These are three questions you can ask yourself to determine how much meaning in life you have. What do you want to exist, even if you don't? Because meaning is about being connected to something bigger than yourself, beyond yourself. That's what Susan Wolf argues in her book, *Meaning in Life and Why It Matters*. There's experimental research to show this.
- 2.49 What do you want to exist even if you don't? Second question, how real is it? How real is it? How much does it really connect you to reality? And thirdly, how connected are

you to it? How connected are you to it? Now, what's interesting, if you ask people about beautiful things, they want beautiful things to exist even if they don't. They're a little bit hesitant on the thing because of all the hermeneutics of suspicion, but when you take them outside of that, they're just experiencing. They're experiencing moments of realization and beauty. They feel that they're connected to reality and that it is real.

- 2.50** See, there's all this research around meaning in life. What makes your life meaningful? There's four characteristics. Purpose. We think it because we're in a post-Protestant world. We think that's all that there is to meaningful. You must have a purpose. You must have an overarching goal. You must work towards—work, do you hear me? Work. Come on. Are you working? You can rest, but only so that you can go back to work. Purpose matters, but contrary to what your culture tells you, it doesn't matter the most.
- 2.51** Here's some other factors. Coherence. The world has to be, get this, intelligible to you. It can't be absurd. You have to have something in the world that's significant to you. It's deep, it's real. And here's the one that might be the most important, mattering. It has to matter to you. You have to feel deeply connected to it. That's why many people say their kids. My kids make my life meaningful. Well, because I want my kids to survive when I'm not here. I think my kids are real because if I don't think my kids are real, I'm really messed up. And I'm really connected to them if I'm a good parent. In fact, I love my kids.
- 2.52** There's the ancient association between love and beauty. We love something because it's beautiful, but also, if we love something, it becomes beautiful to us. Again, as we start to go this way, we start to open up all kinds of connections, all kinds of realizations that we've lost when we threw out the ancient bathwater, we lost the baby of beauty. Maybe the kind of meaning that's happening in beauty is meaning in life. Not like the meaning of a scientific text, semantic meaning, but meaning in life.
- 2.53** Meaning in life, and this is the work of Kelly-Ann Allen and related work called the Psychology of Belonging. If you don't have that sense of belonging, connectedness, meaning in life, you're in trouble. You're in trouble psychologically, physiologically, financially, socially, morally. You're in trouble. This is life-saving and life-giving to you. If you do not have experiences that continually educate and evolve that, you're in trouble in terms of your maturation. Maybe beauty has a very important job.
- 2.54** Relevance realization is not cold calculation. It's about what you're focusing your attention on, what's grabbing your attention, what's arousing you, what's motivating you to action, what's giving you affect, and you're taking a chance because I'm paying attention to this and not that, and that might have the tiger over there. It's not cold calculation. It is a profound, caring, committed connectedness. When we have things, we have experiences that say that's going well, we are careful towards them.

- 2.55** Scarry says beauty demands reverence, and now we're overlapping with the sacred again. You express reverence when you come before something that's sacred. Fourth feature. Beauty elicits, educes. The word education doesn't mean to put in. Educe means to draw out. Educe is actually a transjective word. Beauty demands, draws out, elicits reflection. We think, we are motivated to think. I didn't realize, this is Odysseus, I didn't realize a woman could be so beautiful. How could I have not seen that? What is it about me that made me incapable of seeing this before?
- 2.56** Fuller, in his book on wonder, excellent book, by the way, makes a distinction between wonder and curiosity. We can use the existential modes to talk about. Curiosity is the having mode. I need to have an answer. That's what you have, by the way, in the mystery novel that's not a mystery novel. You have a hole and you want—oh, there's what I need. Hole fixed, I'm done. That's curiosity. Curiosity is really important because, if you're not curious about your environment, if you're not exploring for new sources of water and food and shelter and medicine and mating, you're doomed.
- 2.57** But that's not what wonder is. Remember, does time take time to happen? Wonder is when the world and you together, transjectively, come into question. I wonder. I wonder. You see, this is the difference between a question and something like a koan, Zen koan. They sound like questions like, what was your mother's face like before she was born? Or does time take time to happen? The point is not to get an answer. The point is not a question, the point is to go on a quest. It is to call more and more of a reality into question.
- 2.58** Zen is about trying to get you to wake up, profound realization, wake up from all your habitual way of seeing the world and being in the world. It doesn't mean you're going to some other place. Nirvana isn't somewhere else. Look, before, this is a famous thing. Before I did Zen, mountains were mountains and rivers were rivers. While I was doing Zen, mountains weren't mountains and rivers weren't rivers. Brain-breaking. But after I got through Zen, mountains were mountains and rivers were rivers. A deep recovery of the beauty of the world within and without.
- 2.59** So beauty provokes wonder. How often do you wonder? You're curious all day long. You got advertising that's making you curious all day long. Do I need this? Do I need this? Do I want that? Do I want that? Do I need this? Do I need this? Do I want that? Entertainment. Hey, look at this. Look at this. Look at this. Hey, hey, look at this. Look at this. How often do you go, I'm going to put all that aside. I wonder. I wonder. Beauty is an opportunity to engage in that wonder.
- 2.60** The fifth feature, according to Scarry, which she calls clear discernibility, this is part of the frame-making aspect of beauty. The beautiful thing is clear to you. It has clarity. Thomas Aquinas talks about this. It has to have claritas. The beautiful thing has to be clear. It has to have splendor. This is why you can find things like light beautiful. Sunlight. Oh, the sunlight's so beautiful. What are you looking at? You're looking at clear discernibility itself. Why do you like it? It makes all of your behavior more fluent.

- 2.61** You're constantly making a new frame. You're challenging your salience landscaping. Notice how what's salient is constantly shifting. It's like this flowing topography, salience landscaping. You're changing how you're sizing things up. What are you foregrounding? What are you backgrounding? How are you framing it? You're constantly doing that. When it lands, clear discernibility. You have insight. You're seeing into it. You understand it now. Beauty, like insight, has a frame-breaking, frame-making dynamic. And like flow, we experience it. We feel it. See, fluency you're not usually feeling. You're feeling things in terms of fluency. But flow, you actually feel, and beauty, you actually feel.
- 2.62** You actually are aware of it. It's not just behind the scenes. It's come in front of you and you're aware of it imaginally because you're aware through it. Like flow, beauty is something for its own sake. This is how beauty is different from pornography. The point of seeing the painting of the beautiful nude is the beauty. The point of the pornography is something other than the pornographic picture. Being and having.
- 2.63** We cleared away to follow beauty. We opened up a lot of language from cognitive science, psychology, philosophy. Gave us a lot of new ways of thinking, new ways of situating beauty. We made a lot of connections to the ancient model, and now we've turned to one of the premier authors about the recovery of beauty, the Return to Beauty, Elaine Scarry's book. We're not done it, but we're done for now. Thank you, everyone, for your time and attention. Now, we'll take some questions. Yes.
- 2.64** OK. I spent the entire lecture trying to figure out how to ask this question. At the beginning, you were talking about how things, when they're real and they're intelligible, there's more of a mystery behind it, and you see more and more and more of it. I've noticed, for example, in modern art compared to previous art, and even in our general day-to-day, the minimalism of our visual environment, including art—
- 2.65** If I could interject, musicologists talk about the minimalization of music, that we're losing complexity and we're replacing it with salience of beat. Yes.
- 2.66** So, you were talking about how art is constantly obsessed with looking at itself or its history. I was also thinking about how, when we project into the future, everything seems to be smooth in the future. When you see the smooth trains, and that was always a thing in sci-fi movies and things like that. So, I guess, is this a visual manifestation or an attempt to narrow down that cone to make the future less scary or more predictable?
- 2.67** That's an excellent question. So one of the things we do is we do something that's imaginal. We look through a narrative. We have two kinds of narratives that we are really fascinated with. They go back to two founding myths. We have the utopic narrative, which is the future, and that's like Abraham going to the promised land. We have the promised land and we have the utopic. Then we, of course, have the shadow side of that, the dystopia, Orwell, something like that. Or we have the past. I got to get

back home. This is Odysseus, by the way. He's got to get back home. And this is nostalgia.

- 2.68** They're both examples of the fact that narrative has that tremendous power. We look through it. It's imaginal. Try this with me. There is actually in the physics no story going on right now. But yet, when you meet somebody, what do you tell them? You tell them your story. How did your day go? Well, I think I walked 37 steps. I believe my heart was beating throughout. I remember my eyes were open. Is that a good? No, you tell the person the story of your day. We endlessly practice this. We're endlessly—and we have an illusion. It's called the narrative bias. When we think we have a narrative, we think we've got the whole of the reality of something. That's the simplification you're talking.
- 2.69** We do really strange and bizarre things. Think about this has to do with the truth, the realization. They'll present some horrible thing on the news, mass murder. We go [gasp], and then they give us the story. It turns out blah, blah, blah. We go [sigh]. All the people are still dead. But we feel better because we have a narrative. So narrative bias. We are doing that exactly as a way of trying to deal with a combinatorially explosive manner. Narratives are imaginal. They seem so real to us because they're not merely illusions. They are ways of putting us into contact with reality, giving us an agent-arena relationship. They're doing an indispensable job. But for that very same reason, they're also guilty of oversimplifying things.
- 2.70** A good narrative, a narrative that's beautiful. Teaching a course, I just taught the course. One of the books we were doing, it's on literature and the meaning crisis, was the Death of Ivan Ilyich. The thing about Ilyich is he's consumed by the narrative of having. He wants to have status and he wants to have power and he wants to have a new house and he wants to have a wife. He's not really in a good relationship with her. He's doing all of this, he's doing all this. One day he falls, as he's putting up a new curtain, and he hurts himself, and he doesn't get better, and he doesn't get better, and he doesn't get better, and he tries to avoid it, and he realizes he's going to die.
- 2.71** He's astonished and upset and angry that his narrative, the momentum of his narrative, didn't keep him alive. We do this. We go to these movies, which I think are one of the great evils of modern society. They're called romantic comedies. Because what romantic comedies make you think is, when you fall in love, reality conspires to keep it going. That's not how reality works. You can have just found the person you want to spend your life with, and you're going to meet them, and you walk into the street, and a truck hits you. You can't say to the physics, "Wait, I shall not die because I'm in a great story."
- 2.72** Yes, profoundly yes. A good work of literature should remind you. It's like the Zen koan. It should get you to wonder about narrative. It should get you to call it and yourself in question as you're interacting with the narrative, and therefore, is the potential to be something very beautiful.

- 2.73** Hi, you talked about relevancy and how relevance is obvious and it's transjective. This means that we have nothing to do with selecting it. We do not select what is relevant for us or the meaning that is relevant for us. We don't select that. It's just, we encounter.
- 2.74** No, actually, I was arguing against that. That would be the idea that relevance is there to be detected or encountered. I was trying to indicate, no, you participate in it. You and the world together fit each other. You and the world together make relevance. Make obviousness, make adaptivity, make the flow state. You're co-creating, you're participating in it, like the way you participate in a conversation. You don't just speak to have a conversation, and you don't just listen to have a conversation, but you participate in it. That's the same thing with all of these.
- 2.75** Earlier in the lecture, about a third of the way in, you talked about intelligibility, and that was the robustness of intelligence as a measurable thing. You said that beauty requires intelligibility in order to be apprehended or perceived. I was wondering if you could clarify a little bit. Since people of varying intelligence might find different things intelligible, does that mean that certain aspects of beauty might be reached by certain people, but not necessarily attained by others? Can you clarify that a little bit?
- 2.76** Yeah, very much. Here's where we also have to be really, really careful because the language of subjectivity and objectivity doesn't help us. Let's take a look at evolution. Here's the interesting thing. Evolution is a universal process, yes? So wherever there's life, there's evolution, yeah? Does that mean that everything that's produced by that process is the same or homogeneous? In fact, what does it predict? It predicts you're going to have an increasing diversity of things because the reality is so complex and rich.
- 2.77** So, we can talk about the, and this is why I started you with fluency. We're not talking about properties of the object, we're talking about properties of the processing. We can talk about there being universal aspects of it. Insofar as you're all human beings, you have domain-general G, but is there variance? Is your G different than hers? Yes. In a similar way, the things that might strike you as beautiful are going to be different from her. Now, we can immediately say, oh, that means it's purely subjective. But the whole point of that argument, just like adaptivity, is no, no, no, that doesn't make it subjective. You can't just paint on the empty canvas of the world.
- 2.78** We have to make a distinction between a universality of the process and a great diversity of the products and the objects. Does that make sense? OK, so how many sentences can I say? But you can understand them. You're going to understand a sentence. I hope you've never heard it before because if you've heard it before, you need therapy. "Currently, there are no super-evolved mosquitoes in hyper-spaceships attacking the sun in order to destroy their enemies on Mars." You understood that. You know the sentence isn't true. There are no such things. There are universal processes of intelligibility. It doesn't mean all the sentences are the same. Do you see?

- 2.79** You mentioned that in movies, and I guess in art, there is a moving away from the smoothness. There's utility in the smoothness, but it reduces beauty. How do you see that as reversing, I guess, in the art today?
- 2.80** Yeah. One of the things that—you can play with the smoothness, but then what you typically happens is it's still culturally formulaic and that you fall into the shock of the uniquely new or original. I mean, you're going to get terribly avant-garde films that are just shocking and unique and self-expressive, and that will always happen. When movies try to get back to beauty and not just be works of art, what you'll see them often doing is trying to wake you up in some fashion, not to how great the movie is, but to an aspect.
- 2.81** So beauty is something that should wake you up. Remember that sensibility transcendence? You're going to start seeing everything, including yourself, differently. So, movies that are works of art—sorry, let me change that. I want to be really careful. Movies that we take to be great works of art because they are beautiful are things that make us re-realize something that we had forgotten, or realize something that we haven't seen before. I don't know if that's happening very much right now in movies.
- 2.82** Interestingly, in some places, you'll get this weird integration of the smooth with the mythos of waking up, like the Matrix was around that before they sort of degenerated it into, I don't know how many versions there are now. But the original one, everything's very smooth. It's very clean aesthetics and you have all this flowing movement and everything. But it was in service of trying to make you consider that everything could be, in some sense— this is a hermeneutics of suspicion—but it was offering you the possibility that you could wake up, you could come into the real world.
- 2.83** Now, a lot of people didn't realize that about The Matrix. The Matrix is actually a Neoplatonic gnostic movie. That's why Neo is called Neo. It comes from Neoplatonism, and he's the one, which is the primary reality in Neoplatonism. Neoplatonism is the idea that a lot of what we are taking to be most real is actually a shadow compared to something that is much more real. That's why that movie had a beauty to it. People got really deeply invested in it and attracted to it. It became like a cultural meme. There was an aspect of that, about waking up.
- 2.84** It's hard for me to think of movies right now that—I'm happy to hear a suggestion you might have—movies that are doing that right now. Maybe [Everything Everywhere All at Once]. It was trying to make you realize the combinatorially explosive nature of reality, but it wasn't really getting at the intelligibility. Many people don't find that movie beautiful. They find that movie horrifying. Then they try to patch it up with romantic comedy at, oh, but love. OK. That's a really good question. I mean, there have been movies that do that.
- 2.85** An older movie that did that, that tried to make you wake up. There's a movie that's one of my very favorite movies, and it's an older movie. It's from the Golden Age. It's

called Sunset Boulevard. Sunset Boulevard is about this woman who—the movie takes place, it's filmed and takes place in the '40s, William Holden, Gloria Swanson. She actually was the actress way before postmodernism. It was self-referential. Gloria Swanson, who's in the movie, was a famous silent screen starlet. But the character she plays, Norma Desmond, was terrifically famous in the silent era. Then when the talkies came, she was completely forgotten.

- 2.86** And so she's constantly trapped in illusion. She's constantly—what that movie does is, it does something really powerful. It stands back and criticizes how Hollywood has been blurring the line between illusion and reality. This is a dangerous thing that can destroy people's lives. She's destroyed. Spoiler alert, she kills another person. There's a beauty to this movie, and it's shot very—it's almost film noir. You get this tremendous sense of, oh, this is really important. This is really important. That would be an example.
- 2.87** I think one thing that's really drawing my curiosity is I feel that there's a clash between this idea of beauty being patterns, very mathematical, very predictable. Then you were talking a lot about beauty being the shocking, what creates wonder. And that makes me think about how a lot of beauty can be related to evoking a strong emotion such as the sublime and how that is maybe one aspect of beauty. And so I'm curious, where do you think this idea of patterns and smooth and the comfort of that mathematical predictability of the world coincides with the shocking, with the more sublime?
- 2.88** So I think what we've done—and so this is very prescient because this is going to be part of the argument in the next lecture—what we've done is we've broken these two apart and set them against each other. We have the artistic world in which the shocking and the unique is important. Then, as you said, we have the mathematically predictable world, which teeters towards being meaningless for us. What we're going to see, although we've had some good foundation for it, the beauty actually is both of those. That beauty is the new that falls into order or the new that renews what's ordered.
- 2.89** But it also shows how order can give emergence to something new. It's actually about a relationship between them, which, of course, is what's happening in insight because you have to break the old frame of mathematically and smoothly connecting the dots. Oh, I don't know how to do this. That's a shock. Then, oh, wait. Then you get a new order in which it's taken up again. This is why you'll find very—and we'll talk a little bit about this—how an aspect of beauty, elegance, plays a very significant role in science. Precisely about that. That there's some, beauty is not truth. Who said that? Was that, I can't remember. Was that Keats? I can't remember. But it's an aid. It's an ally to truth.
- 2.90** I guess this is more like a personal reassurance. You talked about how God is beautiful and how that's more of the original—
- 2.91** In ancient, yeah.
- 2.92** Yeah, ideas of beauty. I was just thinking of spirituality and meaningful life and the philosophies that we all have. Do you think that that's why spirituality is so important

to people, because of the aids that it brings towards those who maybe believe in a God or a deity or a higher being, and the curiosities that, or the mysteries that we're trying to figure out in our own lives. Do you think that spirituality is very important and part of that beauty?

2.93 Yeah. I'm known for making a very extended and ongoing argument about how we're in a meaning crisis, where the meaning isn't semantic meaning, it's meaning in life, meaning people are drifting. People look towards spirituality. What is spirituality, by the way? It's a very odd question. It's basically, people are gathering from religion, practices from religion or from philosophy. They're gathering practices and they're trying to enhance meaning in life. That's important. But frequently, they're doing it in a very dangerous way. They're doing it in a very fragmentary, often isolated way.

2.94 Why is that problematic? Because, well, think about it. Relevance realization is behind that sense of connectedness, right? And you're carrying connectedness and you're involved and it's deep and it's real. But what's relevance realization also doing? It's blinding you to a lot of reality. You need not only meaning enhancement, you need enhancement of you challenging your proclivity to self-deception. You need to be cultivating—and this is an ancient model, too— you need to be cultivating wisdom as you're cultivating. If we mean by wisdom, not just knowledge. Knowledge overcomes ignorance. Wisdom overcomes foolishness, the way we deceive ourselves.

2.95 And by the way, foolishness is domain-general. Is there any area of your life where you can't be foolish? No. Any particular? No, I could be foolish there. Another way of putting this is, I sometimes will ask students, "Where do you go for information?" They'll hold up their phones because we're almost like cyborgs now. "Where do you go for knowledge?" And they'll sometimes say, "Well, science or history or university." They're bitten by postmodernism, and so they're a little bit like, "Oh, not sure."

2.96 Then I say, "Where do you go for wisdom?" This is what I get, a stony silence. Or some of them, very meekly and really looking around at everybody, "Well, I go to church. I go to temple." What's the connection? OK, so beauty is connected to meaning, and therefore to a spirituality, but beauty is also connected to wisdom. We're going to find this when we talk about Plato. Because Socrates said, "Wisdom begins in wonder." And beauty is something that makes you profoundly call everything into question and wonder, but not in a horrific way, but in a way that invites you to correct yourself comprehensively.

2.97 OK, thank you, everyone.

Lecture 3: Beauty and Understanding

At a glance — Beauty and understanding — beauty's cognitive role.

- 3.1 Welcome back to Lecture 3 of the Primacy of Beauty. Just to remind you, the Primacy of Beauty is deeply indebted to and inspired by David Schindler's, D.C. Schindler's essay, "The Primacy of Beauty, the Centrality of Goodness, and the Ultimacy of Truth." What does he mean by the primacy of beauty? Last time, what we did is we talked about four factors driving the fall of beauty. We've got the idea that beauty used to be something very, very, well, primary, sacred, important. Instead, we've taken a look at some of the things that caused it to fall from that pedestal, if we want to put it that way.
- 3.2 We took a look at the hermeneutics of suspicion, but we saw that the hermeneutics of suspicion can be challenged by the fact that the hermeneutics of suspicion is ultimately dependent on the hermeneutics of beauty. We talked about related ideas around realization, insight, the moment of truth, the occurrence of truth, et cetera. We then took a look at Han's point from Saving Beauty, about the reduction of beauty to the aesthetics of the smooth. When we were talking off-camera, some of you were mentioning how much you liked that idea. The criticism there is that the aesthetics of the smooth actually leads to nihilism, and it presupposes a model of reality as impoverished, where it might, in fact, be the case that reality is a plenitude.
- 3.3 Then we took a look at, in relation to the smooth, the idea of pornography, as Han was discussing it, and along with that, the Darwinian reduction, which is the idea that the beautiful is just a byproduct of sexual attraction. We took a look at fluency and how fluency is a good way of undermining that claim. We also took a look at modal confusion from Fromm, about confusing having and being needs. Another source of the fall of beauty was, beauty was replaced by the sense of the aesthetic, the work of art. We took a look at the influential work of Collingwood in which uniqueness and shock and even ugliness are given priority.
- 3.4 We took a look around this triad of uniqueness, originality, and the confrontational self-expression of the artist. We called all of this into question by going at the heart of that triad, which is the idea that beauty is something merely subjective. We went back to the notion of fluency. We went into the fact, again, that it's domain-general. We talked about general intelligence. We talked about the two meta problems that are solved, I argue, by our general intelligence. The first is anticipation, the cognitive light cone, as Michael Levin would put it. We took a look at predictive processing, and we got into the imaginal, both the top-down, bottom-up, and the in-out of the imaginal.
- 3.5 Then we noticed a second interlocking meta problem, the problem of relevance realization. How do we zero in, home in on, the relevant information? That gave us a good argument that reality is actually a plenitude. It is an inexhaustible source of new

intelligibility, rather than being the flat, shallow screen that is presupposed by the hermeneutics of suspicion. I want to come back to this issue of relevance realization a little bit later when we talk about non-propositional knowing. But we took the notion of the imaginal and relevance realization together. We lumped it in with—sorry, not lumped it in, placed it in. Lumped it in sounds clumsy.

- 3.6 We placed it in with a bunch of other phenomena like adaptivity and affordance, and we talked about transjectivity and how important transjectivity is. We talked about things like insight, and we talked about the way in which there's this dynamic coupling, this evolution of how we're zeroing in on what's relevant. We talked about, of course, the imaginal as also being transjective. We talked about all of this involving our salience landscapes, our sizing up, how we find things obvious, and all of these phenomena that are so central to our cognitive agency but do not fall nice and cleanly into the subjective-objective divide.
- 3.7 We started to open up the space of transjectivity, and we started to get some ideas that would go into that space with respect to beauty. I'm making the proposal that beauty can be found in the transjective domain, and it is going to be connected to things like realization, like relevance realization, like insight, like the imaginal. We then took a look at some of the overlap between beauty and insight. Both beauty and insight involve frame-breaking and frame-making, the connection of perception and understanding. We participate in it as it refits how we're coupled and connected to the world.
- 3.8 In both insight and beauty, we've got the possibility of appearance disclosing reality, realization. Then we talked about the notion of attraction and that, how salience and sizing up and relevance realization is about caring and being involved and all of this—ways in which we can think about, rather than we're projecting onto the world, there's a way in which the world is attracting us and we're fitting to the world. We talked about things like niche construction, how the world and we are shaping each other, and organisms are doing this as well.
- 3.9 Then talked about, made connections between insight and fluency by talking about insight as a fluency spike. Then we talked about flow as a fluency of insights and insight cascade. It shows up in improv, jazz, martial arts, rock climbing. We said, oh, wow, they're in this realm of transjectivity. There's this whole family of phenomena, and we can use that family in the space of transjectivity to talk more deeply about beauty. We'll put beauty into the family with the imaginally transjective. We talked a little bit about the imaginal throughline and multi-aspectuality. Again, about the idea of the world as a, of reality as being this plenitude, this inexhaustible fount of intelligibility that is disclosed to us, at least that's a proposal in beauty.
- 3.10 I gave you an initial proposal. I'm going to keep revising this or else there'd be no point for me continuing to lecture. And I've been contracted to give all four lectures, so there you go. Beauty as the imaginal fluency of niche construction. We're doing this. Once

we'd cleared that space from the four factors that caused the fall, and once we opened up the space of the transjective and we situated within that the family of things like insight and flow, et cetera, we're well disposed to now turn towards a lot of the work that's being done to recover, renew beauty.

- 3.11** We started that. We're going to continue it on today, but just a little bit more review. We started that with the work of Elaine Scarry, in her really important book, *On Beauty and Being Just*. We were taking a look at five factors of beauty. One was sacredness. Beauty involves something beyond itself. It involves setting things into a deeper context. We talked about Zwicky's idea that that's the experience of meaning. But we're still like, what's the sacred? This is a very difficult notion for us right now. There's many people who simply reject that notion. There's many people who identify it, perhaps too readily, with the supernatural.
- 3.12** I'm going, as I think we all should, very carefully. I don't want to be allergic to the idea of the sacred, and I don't want to just automatically acquiesce in it. I want to explore it with you as we're doing this. We talked about beauty is unprecedented. That was the second factor. It's got like "never before in the history of the world" kind of sense to it. That's part of what the sacred is, too. The sacred is unprecedented. It breaks us away from our habitual ways of seeing and being and acting in the world.
- 3.13** We talked about that Nunez, and we explored the work of Iris Murdoch, as influenced, sorry, as interpreted by John Wright. And Iris Murdoch has a huge influence on Scarry. This was the idea of sensibility transcendence. It's an example of this imaginal niche construction. Remember with the daughter-in-law and the mother-in-law. There's bidirectional insight into the phenomena, but also the insight into the very process of framing. And so this transframing, not just reframing a problem, but transframing your whole relationship to reality.
- 3.14** We got into that and how there's an aspirational dimension to beauty. It at least is a calling to us. I reminded you that the ancient Greek word, one of the primary words for beauty, is *kallos*, which comes from *call*. Beauty is calling us to something more, not only to see something more, but to be something more than what we are. Now, of course, we may not take that up in the right mode. If we are engaged in modal confusion, we will not be in the right stance and orientation because beauty requires both the world and us, because it's transjective in the right way. We have to be in right relationship.
- 3.15** Making use of all of that, Scarry proposed that beauty demands reverence from us. That got into the idea of the kind of meaning that's at work here. We talked about meaning in life, and that what beauty is about is not about semantic meaning, it's about meaning in life. In that sense, it's life-giving, it's life-saving, which is another characteristic of beauty that Scarry talks about. That was the third characteristic. The fourth characteristic is that beauty provokes wonder. Not curiosity, wonder. Calling the world and yourself into question in a deep way. As Socrates famously said, "Wisdom

begins in wonder." That wondering is essential for people who want to cultivate wisdom, rather than just acquiring knowledge.

- 3.16** And even worse than that, just gathering information. T. S. Elliott says, "Where's all the wisdom we have lost in knowledge and where's all the knowledge we have lost in information?" And he said that way before the Internet. Very prescient, which is, of course, why he gets to be T. S. Elliott and not Bob the poet. The fifth feature, the clear discernibility. There's a splendor. There's a shining salience. We use shining metaphors for salience. It's shining. It's shining. It's splendor. It's clearly discernible. There's frame-making. Not only is there frame-breaking, but there's frame making. Beauty has the insight dynamics of frame-breaking and frame-making. Like flow, we experience it as something for its own sake that we deeply embody and enjoy.
- 3.17** OK, that's the review. That's where the argument is so far. Now we're going to move to new material, and I'll slow down. I speed up a bit in the review because, well, you just heard it. So, Scarry, after giving the five characteristics and talking about Odysseus seeing Nausicaa, she moves into this discussion of seeing a beautiful tree. It's clear enough that we can at least relate to it. But she says it has this really interesting feature of it. OK, so the tree shines for us. The word phenomena, and phenomenology—phenomenology is the academic philosophical study of the structures of our experience about how the world is intelligible to us in our experience. But the word phenomenon comes from a Greek word which means shining, shining forth. The word exist means to stand out. These are all salience words. They are all salience words.
- 3.18** The tree suddenly catches your attention. You foreground it and you center it. Everything is oriented towards it, and it's shining, it's standing out for you. First of all, you got that. You got this clarity, the claritas. Then she says, and then part of your mind is racing backwards. You're saying, I didn't realize trees could be like that. You're thinking of all the previous trees you've seen, and they're gathered together in your mind. You've got all—I saw that tree there and that tree and that tree and that tree. They're all leading to this, but this is something beyond that.
- 3.19** You do this search. None of them is good enough. You don't settle there and go, oh, yeah, it's just another tree. You do this search, and then everything converges back on this tree that's something beyond that. But then it doesn't stop there. She said your mind also races forward because you think about, well, maybe I could see other beautiful trees, or maybe this way of seeing will show up for other—and your mind goes open, and there's a promise of new ways of seeing things in many different domains. Maybe I could even make a beautiful painting of a tree.
- 3.20** Plato talks about when you see beauty, you want to give birth to beautiful things. Really interesting idea. Notice how that's very different from the smooth. When you're done with the smooth, you're just done with it. "Oh, I want to make everything smooth. I want to make more smooths." That doesn't have that same sort of feel. But when you—think about, you hear some beautiful piece of music, and what do you want to do?

You're humming it a lot. You want to carry it forth. You want to carry it to other places. It has this really interesting structure to it. She says what's happening is, your mind is racing back and forth, back and forth, back and forth, which is really interesting.

- 3.21** So, in some ways, and I'll come back to this point, you're looking back to precedent, because the tree might be unprecedented, but you're also seeing, maybe I can set a new precedent, maybe I can carry this into new places in some ways. That's a very interesting structure. This is really good phenomenology that she's doing. This is phenomenology, opening up the structure of your experience and how you're making things intelligible in the way you're experiencing them. Is that OK? All right.
- 3.22** Now, I want to pick up on this structure, this weird spider shape, and I want to relate it to intelligibility. Again, what do we mean by intelligibility? We mean making sense, understanding, explaining. I want to talk about something that I'm getting published this year, about work on plausibility. Now, initially, I'm going to ask for your patience. Initially, it's going to be, why is he talking about this and how does this relate to beauty? I'm going to ask, hang in, hang in, because, actually, if I can get this argument for plausibility to be plausible to you—and sorry, I actually want to make that self-reference. It's not just a joke—I'll have a lot of helping to explain the primacy of beauty. I'm asking you to hang with me for that because there's a big payoff if it lands, if it works. Is that OK?
- 3.23** What I've been trying to do is, I've tried to figure out, we have this word plausible. Now, there's two different meanings of plausible. One means it's just a synonym for highly probable. Highly probable, you establish that empirically. You run experiments, you gather data. That's one meaning. Now, a more established meaning, and the one I want to make use of, is where we say, "Oh, that's plausible." What we mean by that is, listen to, we'll say this. "That makes good sense." Oh, that's an interesting thing. That makes good sense. Not just sense, that makes good sense. That stands to reason. That convinces me that I've understood this. Makes me take it seriously.
- 3.24** Saying something's plausible is not saying it's probable, therefore you should believe it, or saying it's certain, therefore you must believe it. It's saying, "I understand that. I'm going to take that seriously." We need that because we have to have something that does an initial sorting between the thing, relevance realization, between the things we don't take seriously and the things we should take seriously. When we get that wrong, oh boy, do we pay for it. Your spouse. "You're not taking me seriously." That's a really dangerous sentence. You got to say, wait, that's like the alarm bells going off. OK, cast everything aside. Let's sit down. We got to work this out. This is a disaster.
- 3.25** That's the sense of plausibility that I've been talking about, talking about at conferences. It's showing up in a couple of things I'm getting published. I want to lay that out, not because of egotistical, ruthless self-promotion, although I'm sure there's part of that in that, because I'm a primate. But I'm also, this is going to be really central to making the argument for the primacy of beauty. Because I'm going to make an

argument for the primacy of plausibility. You're going to see me drawing this spider diagram. That very spider diagram that Scarry says is at work in beauty. OK?

- 3.26** All right, so, Nicholas Rescher, back in the '70s, wrote a book on plausibility, and he's had a lot of good things in there, but there's a point that he makes that's a really, really important point. You can show this. Also, it's been shown experimentally. One of the things we like is when we have a lot of independent sources of information that converge on the same thing. Why would we like that? Well, the chances that each one of the, the chances that—if I have only one, let's put it this way, if I have only one, the chance that whatever I'm coming here, whatever model I'm forming here, there's a high chance it might just be created by the subjective bias of this channel, yes?
- 3.27** But the more I have of these, the chance that it's due to subjective bias goes down. I'm reducing the chance that the model was produced by bias. This is why, by the way, and even babies show this, you prefer things that are multisensory. If you can only see something, you're not sure if it's real. If you can see it and hear it, maybe it's real. If you can see it, hear it, and touch it, it's probably real. Do you know that there's a really horrible form of, thankfully rare, of psychosis in some forms of schizophrenia where people have hallucinations? You know how schizophrenic people hear voices, but they not only hear voices, they see. Then there's a small group of people, they hear and see and they can touch it. It's almost impossible to convince those people that those things aren't real.
- 3.28** This is why science likes numbers. It's not because we're fascists. We like numbers because you can see three, you can hear three, you can touch three. One, two, three. The numbers allow us to reduce the probability that our model is being created by subjective bias. Does that make sense? OK, so this is convergence. We look for convergence because this gives us, and this is the term that Rescher uses, trustworthiness. Trustworthiness is not truth, it's trustworthiness. Trustworthiness means you have good reason to believe that the probability of this being produced by bias has been significantly reduced. That's not the same thing as probability. It's not the same thing as certainty. But it's important. It's important. That's why you prefer multisensory information. That's why we use numbers in science. Is that OK?
- 3.29** Now, from work that Kyle has done on the kinds of explanations we like, and other people work on the psychology of explanation, work drawn from the philosophy of science, we also like something else. We also like a model that we can use to explain many different things in many different domains. Kitcher, the philosopher, talks about this, also. Force equals mass times acceleration. You know what's great about that? I can use that to talk about whales floating in the ocean. I can use that to talk about Mars. I can use that to talk about what would happen if I was to throw this magic marker. I can use it to talk about what happens when a car hits a—do you see that? I can use the same model in many different domains, domains that we used to think were disparate.

- 3.30** If you go to somebody in the Middle Ages and say, "Hey, you know what? Light and electricity and magnetism and sound, they're all wave phenomena," and they'll put you away for being a witch or something. But we like it because we got a model that goes to areas that people used to think were disparate and unconnected and draws them all together. Do you see that? This is what scientists frequently mean when they say a theory is elegant. It's elegant. You have convergence for trustworthiness, but we also want something that's elegant.
- 3.31** Elegance. What does elegance give us? It gives us power. These models are powerful. They give us the capacity to go into large parts of the world, find, formulate, and solve problems. They make us powerful. If you think there isn't a relationship between the judgment of power and the judgment of realness, well, you're not paying attention to what's been happening in the culture for the last 30 years. But also, you're not paying attention to the fact that science has so much authority because it generates technological power. Science wouldn't have the authority it had if it was just a theory and we didn't get all of this from our scientific knowledge.
- 3.32** We really like it when we have both. In fact, this is the work of Elijah Millgram, the work he's done on practical induction. There's a whole lecture I could give on what is that and why does that matter? But we're just going to go through this carefully for what we need. We want a balance between these two. How much we commit to the backward-looking and how much we look to the forward, we want a balance between those. If you say something that doesn't have much forward, it's not going to change my view of the world very much. I like vanilla ice cream. It's like, OK. But I don't need a lot of convergence on that, doesn't it? It doesn't require much forward, so I don't have much backwards.
- 3.33** If you tell me, I think the British monarchy are actually lizard people from outer space, well, that's different because that's going to change a lot. I need a lot of this to back it. Now, let's look at what happens when the balance isn't there. If you get something that's really trustworthy but doesn't have much power to it, we have a word for that. Trivial. Something's trivial. Trivial means it's true and I don't care because it doesn't make much of a difference. You've got overwhelming evidence that when people are hungry, they seek food. What do you think about that? You go, yeah, so what? That's a trivial. Yeah, we all know that. That's trivial.
- 3.34** We have a lot of this and very little of that, we don't care about it. We don't take it seriously. What about if we have a lot of this, but not much of that? Well, I just did it. That's when something is far-fetched. That's like when somebody says to you, this is what conspiracy theories typically are, which is not the same thing as a theory of conspiracy. It's like, yeah, if you—look, it's true, by the way. If you accept—if, remember the if, please—if you accept that the British Royal family are reptiles from outer space, you can explain so much. Everything gets so explained. But the problem is, if you only look at this and you realize you don't have that, then you're in trouble

because that's a far-fetched model. That's a far-fetched model. We shouldn't take seriously things that are trivial or far-fetched.

- 3.35** Now, there's another phenomenon I need to talk about. I'm going to use this in a technical sense, but it's a word that's usually considered vulgar. But I need to use this word. This was based on a famous essay by Harry Frankfurt called *On Bullshit*, because Frankfurt wanted to distinguish between bullshit and lying. See, philosophers—who else but a philosopher would do that? The thing about lying, this is how lying works. Lying works because I depend on your commitment to the truth. I commit on, that if you believe something is true, it will change your behavior. I try to convince you that something is true that I know is false. That's the lie. That's the lie.
- 3.36** The bullshit artist works very differently. The bullshit artist tries to get you unconcerned with whether or not it's true. How much of advertising is actually technically bullshit? Alcohol commercial. Here's some alcohol. Gorgeous person, a bunch of other gorgeous people. Clearly sober. Happy, clean-cut, well-lit room, everybody. Have you been in a bar? I have. Lots of bars. Bars aren't like that. That's not the people in a bar. Here's the thing. Here's the thing. You know that. The advertisers know you know that, and they're counting on you saying, "Oh, I know that's not true." And then you don't care that it's not true. You give up caring that it's not true.
- 3.37** What are you caught up in? You're caught up in how salient it is, how much it stands out, how attractive the people are, how attractive the situation is. What do you do? You go into the liquor store, and that bottle of alcohol is salient to you. It leaps out. So you buy that alcohol. That's why they spend hundreds of billions of dollars on advertising. It's bullshit. It literally is. Much of many political speeches are bullshit. "America is the greatest country in the world." What does that mean? It's either fault or it's just bullshit. Sort of. The real answer, well, it's really complex and there's 17,000 factors. And placing that against England is what—they're not doing that. England, that's the greatest country in the world.
- 3.38** The Simpsons had this thing about, there's an episode where there are the aliens, talk about aliens from outer space, and they're running for political office, and they give this following speech. Aliens. "My fellow Americans, when I was young, I dreamt of being a baseball, but now we must move forward. Not forward, upward, twirling, twirling towards freedom." When you hear that and you're an American, I'm a Canadian, so you get this rush. But there's nothing being said. There's nothing being said. That's bullshit. Do you understand what bullshit is?
- 3.39** Here's a really interesting thing you got to keep in mind about self-deception. You can't actually lie to yourself. That's a bad metaphor. I'm lying to myself. How do I do that? Well, I know, but I say to my wife. That doesn't work. You can't lie to yourself. But you know what you can do? You can bullshit yourself because attention has this weird thing. Salience can grab your attention, but you can also make something salient by paying attention to it. Your left big toe, it's now salient to you. You can attend to

something, the bottle of liquor, and then that makes it more salient, so that it's more likely to grab your attention when you go in the store and you buy it. Is this making sense?

- 3.40** One of the things we do is we bullshit ourselves with this. I'm going to have to break this up into two diagrams. This is Dan Dennett. We use this when we do experimental work on bullshit. Imagine being able to write that as a grant proposal. I want to do experiments on bullshit. You can. This is called the deepity. People will say things like this. "Love is just a four-letter word." That sounds so profound. Well, it's like, when you look at just this, this graphic thing, it is just a four-letter word. You've seen it multiple times. Yay, lots of trustworthiness. But then we move from the word to the thing, and I'll put it in capital letters, the actual phenomena. Love has a huge impact on your life, yes? I hope it does, or else you're living a very bad life.
- 3.41** You see what they're doing? They're equivocating between these two things. Love is just a four-letter word, and you go, oh yeah, love is just a four-letter—oh, love. Oh, oh. You think something profound has been said, and actually nothing's going on at all. See, one of the things that plausibility does is it protects us from triviality, far-fetchedness, and this kind of pseudo-profound bullshit. If you don't think we're facing a problem with all of those in our social media, I would suggest you go back and take a careful look at it. We are awash in far-fetchedness, triviality, and pseudo-profound bullshit. OK.
- 3.42** We're still not done the plausibility model. We have convergence, we have elegance, trustworthiness, power, and we've got a balance between them. See, Vervaeke is being the professor, and he's giving you words that all rhyme with each other to remember this. There's one other feature. Here. What's in there? That model has to hang together well. I've talked about a gestalt before. Let's talk about how that applies to understanding, to having a concept of something.
- 3.43** For example, if you ask people what a bird is, they'll say things to you. "Oh, well, it has wings, feathers, a beak. It flies." They give you a list of features. Do you see that? Now, imagine if I put a couple of wings here, some feathers, a beak, gathered it all together and flung it. Is that a bird? I've satisfied the definition. What's missing? What's missing? What's missing is the structural functional organization that holds it all together. That holds it all together so you can predict how a bird is going to work in the world, how a bird is going to behave.
- 3.44** We don't have a good word for that. Plato had a good word for it, eidos, which we mistranslate as the word form. The Germans have a word for it because the Germans have a word for everything, gestalt. What the gestalt does, what the eidos does, what it does is, it makes this clear, makes it hang together, and also importantly, it rules out and rules in. It tells you what birds can do and what birds can't do. Does that make sense? Your model rules. That's what information is. Information is the ruling out of alternatives. What I want is, I want it to hang together in an informative way. We have a word for that, coherence, which happens to rhyme. The model has to be coherent.

- 3.45 Now, I put it to you that when we have this, when we have a model that is a result of deep convergence, promises deep elegance, there's a significant balance, and the model itself is coherent, we find it very plausible. We understand it well. We grasp the significance of the information that we have been presented, and we take it very seriously. Is that OK? Now, notice what I've done already. That's the beauty map. Remember? There was the convergence. There was the promise. There was the clear discernibility at the center. I added in the balance. That's important because without that balance, the relationship between beauty and truth gets lost, and beauty can shade into bullshit.
- 3.46 OK. Is this making sense about what plausibility is? You're doing it all the time. If you notice, my lectures tend to have that structure. I will bring a lot of things together, and then I'll show you what you can do with those things. Because that's how understanding works. That's how intelligibility works. The more it's like that, and I'm not trying to compliment myself, sorry, but the more that happens, you'll say, "That was beautiful."
- 3.47 Now, we're already seeing how this is mapping on to the phenomenology, the experience, the structures, and the experience of beauty, as Scarry has related it. But I want to talk now about the primacy of plausibility. This goes to some work I did with Dan Chiappe way back in 1997, Chiappe and Vervaeke, 1997. Same year, I was getting my thesis completed and defending my dissertation, getting my PhD a long time ago in the before times, before Covid, and then ancient history, before cell phones, and even more ancient history, right before the Internet. Oh, I used to have to go to the library and stuff like that. It was traumatic.
- 3.48 OK. All right. You're a scientist. You want to do science. Do you consider all possible hypotheses that could possibly be thought? Is that how you do it? How many of them? I've taught you enough. I hope you get it. What's the number of possible hypotheses? Combinatorially, explosive. You can't do that. What do you have to do? Well, I'll run experiments to pick up. No, no, no, we're trying to get to the very beginning of an experiment. You have to use—Lipton and other people talk about this—plausibility filters. You only choose hypotheses that strike you as plausible. Remember, that can't mean probable because you haven't run the experiment yet.
- 3.49 OK, so now you're running the experiment. In an experiment, you have to do what's called controlling for confounds. You have to, listen to the language, rule out potentially competing alternative explanations. You have to do all this control to make sure that, if somebody looks at your results, they can't say, "Oh, but it's not because of what you say, it's because of this alternative possibility or this alternative possibility." Notice I have to rule out alternative explanations. See that? Do I consider all possible alternative explanations? No, combinatorially explosive. What do I pick? The plausible ones, usually five or six, and those are the ones I control for when I'm designing my experiment.

- 3.50** OK, so now I run the experiment and I get my data. Do I derive all the logical possible implications from the data? No. Combinatorially explosive. Which ones do I derive? The ones that strike me as plausible. Then when I defend my theory against other people, do I take on anybody who criticizes my theory? No. I only consider, debate, with people who are presenting me with plausible theories of their own. Plausibility is before, during, and after any scientific work. It is before, during, and after any scientific work. You can't do scientific work to establish your initial plausibility judgments. Do you see that?
- 3.51** This is the primacy of plausibility. Without plausibility, you can't filter the world, relevance realization, in the way you need to do in order to do science. This is why scientists like elegant theories. They're actually talking about plausible theories, by the way, because they don't like far-fetched theories. They want theories that are elegant and trustworthy with a model that is informative and coherent.
- 3.52** If beauty has the phenomenological structure of plausibility, and it's deeply involved in educating our relevance realization so we can more rationally investigate the world, beauty would have the primacy that plausibility has. Now, it's not the same. Plausibility is the genus, beauty is the species they're in. But do you understand? If we can understand what plausibility is, and we can understand what the phenomenological structure of beauty is, we can say, "Oh, I'm actually getting an experience of this." Therefore, the primacy of plausibility is what's at work in the primacy of beauty.
- 3.53** If you weren't capable of beauty, that would mean there would be some serious defect in your ability to do plausibility, which would undermine your ability to understand, your ability to interpret, and your ability to even do science. When we're doing this—this is additional connections between beauty and plausibility—when we're doing this, we're doing convergence. When I'm giving you something that comes out of work by deep learning, the kind of thing that's at the heart of ChatGPT, deep learning, you're doing what's called compression. You're bringing a lot of different things together and you're finding what's invariant between all of them.
- 3.54** This is like when you do a scatterplot, like in high school. You get one of these and you draw the line of best fit because it allows you to generalize. That's data compression. This is compression because compression reveals the invariant things that you should trust, trustworthiness. But if you pay attention to Geoff Hinton's deep learning, and if you want, I've got work on that online if you want to see me talking about that more in-depth. Sorry, that was a bad pun. There's a stage in deep learning. At one stage, the machine, the neural network, does compression, but at another stage, it actually disconnects from the world and does something like dreaming, in which it generates all kinds of variations from its compression. It generates all kinds of variations.
- 3.55** It sees which one of those connect to the world, and then it pumps that back into the compression, and it keeps running like that. Do you see that? Now, that's important. That's actually the machinery of evolution. Evolution selects. It collapses down. It

removes options. It finds the things that need to stay in order for the organism to stay, or the species to stay, I should say. But look around. It also—evolution needs variation. This is what, in fact, you do. This is what I argue, I don't know if Geoff would agree with me, but I argue, because I'm using relevance realization theory, that this is how deep learning works, to the degree to which it does.

3.56 It works like evolution. It does compression to get some initial selection, and then it does variation, and then from that, selection, and it evolves how it's fitted to the world. So, plausibility also evolves our cognitive fittedness. It affords deep learning, which, of course, is related to deep understanding. Here's another thing. This is me, and this is, Scarry says, this is me seeking precedents. This is me setting precedents.

3.57 Now, believe it or not, this has to do with the work of Hegel, who most of you might have heard of, but probably not read. Hegel's terrifically, famously difficult to read. But there's some excellent work done on it by Brandom now, *Reason in Philosophy*, *Spirit of Trust*, and Pinkert and others. Hegel is trying to ask this question, where does normativity come from? I don't think he gives a complete answer, but I don't need that for what I'm doing here right here.

3.58 So think about how common law works. You come in, and does the judge just make a decision? No, no. The judge is trying to do things justly, how they ought to be done. Yes? Now, I know you're all saying, oh, the system is corrupt. Let's put that aside for now. Let's put that aside. How it's supposed to work. What you do is you pay attention to precedent in law. You cite precedent. Are you absolutely bound to the citation of precedent? No, because sometimes judges think they need to set a new precedent.

3.59 Now, that might not get taken up by other judges. Like evolution, it just dies off. Some judge makes some wacky thing, thinks they're going to set precedent. Everybody else goes, "That's crazy." It dies. But sometimes it makes a new precedent. Do you see? This is how we actually come to decisions in common law. We are constantly to-ing and fro-ing between seeking precedents and the possibility of setting precedents. Plausibility is generating understanding, what we should take seriously. It's driving deeper learning, and it's giving us an ought, what we ought to do, because it helps us consult precedent and try to set precedent.

3.60 This would help to explain, again, somehow, beauty is uncertainty. Not at all. It's not even probability. But it has some—we take it seriously, and it has a primacy for us. We ought to treat it in a certain way. We ought to relate to it in a certain way. We've already heard Scarry arguing that. By bringing in plausibility in this way, we can start to get a deeper understanding of what's going on in beauty. We can now talk about, how is beauty a specific, species-specific, a specific instance of plausibility? Because not all plausibility judgments are the experience of beauty.

3.61 Genus and species, all Cadillacs are cars. That doesn't mean all cars are Cadillacs. While beauty may be plausibility, that doesn't mean every instance of plausibility is the

experience of beauty. And beauty is an experiential thing. Beauty is like humor. You have to experience it. If you try to explain a joke and people don't get it, that's not going to make a joke. Now, what's happening in beauty is we're participating in the emergence of a new plausibility. There's a new. This model has just been realized, and it's gathering, and it's promising so much.

- 3.62** It's very personally meaningful to us. It's not filled with semantic meaning. It is filled with meaning in life for us. It's an existential plausibility, not just a factual plausibility. Remember what Rilke said. "You must change your life." It's an emergence of a real possibility of a new agent-arena relationship for us, of who we can be. This is why there is a sense of sacredness. But as Scarry says, there's a sense of urgency to beauty, like where our mind is rushing back and forth. We're trying to get at this. So beauty is the emergence of an embodied, enacted, evolving existential plausibility within an imaginal flowing niche construction.
- 3.63** We're getting a, would have said, "This is a serious way in which I could be, and the world could be to me, and we could be together. Here, now, open before me." A reminder, beauty is transjective. It requires that we be in the right mode. It's opening us to a mystery, the inexhaustible plenitude. So notice how we got these two things that are going on in beauty. Something is shining clearly to us, and yet it's also withdrawing into mystery. It's disclosing the inexhaustible plenitude. When you see a beautiful person, it's like that. They shine, but they're also, we have this word, they're alluring. We're getting drawn in, we're getting drawn beyond. But that can be also the welcoming, the greeting of the beautiful mountain, or the piece of music that does that to you as well.
- 3.64** I want to talk a little bit about this plenitude. Just a little. I'm going to come back to it again. This is not meant to be complete. This is just opening it up. We've already made a space for it. We've made a case for it, I should say, with combinatorial explosion. But there's two dimensions to this, phenomenologically. There's a moreness to everything. Remember when I did the brush and I just moved? There's a moreness. OK, now here, that one's easier. This one's harder. If you've had some mindfulness practice, it helps. But even if you can't, try and imagine this.
- 3.65** I want you to look at this and don't compare it to anything else. Don't think of it how it's like other or like other tools or like other writing instruments. Just try to see this as a raw individual. Can you do it? It's hard, but that's how your beloved wants you to treat them. It's not only they're a mystery, there's the moreness, but there's also another kind here. The Buddhists have a great word for this. They call it suchness, the suchness of this. What this is independent of its belonging to any category, its suchness, the way it shines here, now, this.
- 3.66** We pick up suchness with demonstrative reference. What's that? Most words refer categorically. When you see this, you think of the land shark with brains that pretends to love you. Do you see how it points you to a category? Now, compare that to the

following word. This, this, this, this, this, this, this. Does it pick out anything categorical? No. All it does, and Zenon Pylyshyn has done great work on this, psychological work, experimental work with what's called multiple object tracking, but what it basically means is, he says—Michelle, I'm just going to trespass on your, just for a moment. OK, so suppose I didn't know who was here. What I could do is I could put my finger on them and I could keep track of where they were. I don't even I know—sorry, I don't mean any insult. I don't even know what this is. It's just this. Does that make sense? Just this really basic contact.

- 3.67** You, of course, you don't just point and touch with fingers, you point and touch with words, like when I say "this." What I'm getting at is the here, now-ness. What I'm doing is, all I'm doing is, I'm making, I'm just, I'm salience tagging and foregrounding, but there's no content to it. It's just salience tagging and foregrounding. That's all it is. The beautiful thing is calling us to its uniqueness. Remember, that's the overlap with the work of art. It's calling us to its suchness, and it's also calling us to its moreness. I want you to remember that because I want you to get a rich sense of this plenitude.
- 3.68** There's a sense in which it's beneath and before any of our categories and our concepts, and there's a sense in which it extends beyond all of our possible conceptualization. Beauty reminds us of that. It reminds us how our grasp is in between what's beneath it and must be beneath it. Look, I can't form a category unless I can do demonstrative reference. I want to make a new category, so I have to do the following. This, this, this, this, this. And then you can form a category. You see, the suchness comes before any categories, and the moreness goes beyond any categories, to understand the plenitude is rich in both directions.
- 3.69** Sorry for using this spatial metaphor. Is that all right? You're called in both those directions when you get the call of beauty. It's like, when I'm—try not to say your name because who knows who's going to be watching this. I want to be with you. You. And yet, you're a portal to the entire universe for me. And again, what's Vervaeke doing? He's getting you to remember the ancient relationship between beauty and love, and how underneath all of our science, we still expect people to love the truth. When they don't love the truth, we get worried about the science being corrupted.
- 3.70** All right. Scarry makes two more remaining important points about beauty, and these are exactly the connections to truth and justice. Notice right away that she doesn't do what she's accused of doing, which is saying that beauty is truth. She says beauty is allied to truth. Of course, we've already seen that alliance in the occurrence of truth, realization. Han develops this, cites Scarry, and then develops this point around Heidegger's notion of aletheia. We'll come back to that when we talk about Schindler. If you don't get this right away, don't worry, we'll come back to it.
- 3.71** But Heidegger talks about this deeper sense of truth, the Greek notion of aletheia. We have a notion of, I have a coherence of propositions, and they correspond to the world. Heidegger says, yeah, you got subjective, objective. Then he asked the really important

question, "What glues the subjective and the objective together? What makes them fit?" He says there has to be a deeper notion of truth. Truth as realization, truth as aletheia. He calls it unconcealedness. Lethe was the river of forgetfulness. He gives this etymology. There's debates about whether or not it's true. The point doesn't matter on the etymology being right.

- 3.72** There has to be a sense in which there is that fittedness between the mind and the world that makes the coherence and the correspondence work. Beauty is the plausible presencing of that fittedness. We have to start with something, remember the primacy of plausibility, that we take seriously, that affords deep learning, that gives us some sense of telling us how we ought to behave, the normativity. Han says beauty "defines anew what is real. It brings forth us, it brings forth another is." He uses the word is as a noun. "Defines anew what is real. It brings forth another is." Listen to the language here. Listen to this language. Things now appear in a new light. Appearance disclosing reality, rather than hiding it.
- 3.73** Our relationship to things are changed. You must change your life. Beauty also makes us appreciate in both the sense of be grateful for, value, and understand, like music appreciation. Beauty makes us appreciate clarity. I would add coherence and plausibility. It gets us to pay attention to our cognitive processes, not just the cognitive products. This is a defining feature of rational people.
- 3.74** You want to look for a mark of somebody being rational? The degree to which you see them doing important self-correction. This is why I'm very critical of some people who claim to be paragons of rationality, and I never see them doing important self-correction, like Sam Harris. It's one of my criticisms of him. He says he does a lot of other good work. But Sam, maybe some of the criticisms aren't people just misunderstanding you. Maybe you have to engage in self-correction.
- 3.75** One of the things I do as a scientist, and I do it publicly, is I will criticize my own work. You have to. Beauty makes you aware of how your habits can be radically wrong, how what is obvious to you can be false. It helps make you reasonable. We make this distinction between rationality and reasonable. Reasonable points to a more ancient notion of reason. We'll talk about this when we talk about Plato. Rational means you overcome self-deception, you self-correct. Good. We use logic for that, and math, and other things.
- 3.76** But in law, we have the standard of a reasonable person. You have to do what a reasonable person would do. That doesn't mean the reasonable person runs a logical argument. What do we mean? What do we mean is, a reasonable person puts a situation into properly proportioned, salience and sizing up, properly proportioned perspective, and they properly proportion their participation in it, their responsibility to it. That's a reasonable person. That's what reasonable means.

- 3.77** Do you see how beauty teaches you all of that? Putting things proportionately into perspective, sizing them up, salience landscaping them, participating in them with reverence and appropriately. Beauty teaches. Beauty is a schoolhouse for being reasonable. It's a schoolhouse for pursuing loving clarity. It's a schoolhouse for practicing plausibility. It's a schoolhouse for getting us to self-correct and to look at our processes and our framing, and not always unquestioningly to look through our framing. Without beauty, we deny a deep, deep education in those things that make us more rational, make us more reasonable.
- 3.78** Of course, that is how it's allied to the pursuit of truth. Beauty has a lot to do with the imaginal. Yes? In order for you to be rational and/or reasonable, you have to be able to step away and look at the process in your mind. Remember that space that you're holding inside your head? That's the space of metacognition. Beauty teaches you that.

Lecture 4: Beauty and Meaning

At a glance — Beauty and meaning — metacognition and the imaginal.

- 4.1 In order to be rational and reasonable, you have to be metacognitive. You need to be able to play with the imaginal. To be rational and reasonable, you have to be able to know what's going on in other people's mind. Can you literally see into other people's minds? It's imaginal. In fact, your ability to reflect on your own thinking, you did this as a kid. You practiced imitating how other people were paying attention to you, and you internalized their perspectives on you until you can do that without them, and then you do that on your own, and that's how you become metacognitive.
- 4.2 If you're going to be rational, you have to link your present self to your future self. That's an imaginal thing. Herschfield, classic experiment that he does. You go into academics, we prize ourselves, or at least we pretend, we're supposed to be very rational, reasonable. We pay attention to evidence and arguments. At least that's what I was taught you should be as an academic. You go into these people and you give them overwhelming evidence. You allow them to argue and you convince them, and they all agree that they should start saving for their retirement right now.
- 4.3 You come back in six months, how many of them are saving? None of them. Now you replace it with, instead of giving them the argument, that's probably not good science, in addition to giving them the argument, better. You do the following. I want you to imagine your future self as a beloved family member that you've always cared about and taken care of. Every day, I want you to imagine your future self like that. Do it every day. You come back in six months and you find two things. The people that did that are saving, and the people that imagined it more vividly are saving more.
- 4.4 The imaginal. The imaginal is at the heart of the rational and the reasonable. It's at the heart of the metacognitive. Beauty is a powerful, motivating, experientially memorable education in those things that make us attracted to reason and rationality and self-regulation. Beauty is a profound ally of the truth. What about justice, which is in the title of her book? That's her sense of the good. Plato thought that there's an important relationship between the good and justice, and I think he's right about that. I think we are tempted in our culture to idolize justice and think it is the only aspect of the good, and I think that's problematic.
- 4.5 But justice is important. Our culture has really, like, yes. OK, so, again, although I have criticisms about the details, I think the overall point is a good one. Notice the things that beauty does for us. Beauty unselfs us. It makes us less self-centered. You need that in order to be just. Beauty makes us care about something, meaning in life, that might exist even if we don't. Justice needs that. Justice needs that. Scarry quotes Murdoch again. Murdoch, there's a quote. "Anything which alters consciousness in the direction

of unselfishness, objectivity, and realism is to be connected to virtue." That's in the Sovereignty of the Good.

- 4.6 It's a radical decentering. Again, this justice actually also connects back to rationality. This is work done by Igor Grossmann, a colleague of mine. We've done some work together. We did work together on a wisdom consensus paper from 2020. We literally got all the people who work on wisdom academically, psychologists, neuroscientists, cognitive scientists. We got them all together, either physically or digitally in the one room, and we had to stay there, and we had to bash out what we thought were the central features of wisdom. What a weird thing to do. We called ourselves the Wisdom Task Force. Sounds like a great job.
- 4.7 What's some of the stuff that Igor's work has shown? This is called the Solomon Effect, making you more wise. Ask somebody to describe a problem they're having to you. They will inevitably describe it egocentrically, from a first-person perspective. Now get them to redescribe the same problem from the third-person perspective as a friend would see it. They will almost always realize something or have an insight. That's called the Solomon Effect. Decentering. Decentering. There's a lot of convergent evidence from other things, work on construal level, decentering, stuff from the wisdom literature. I won't go in. I'm asking you to trust me. There's a lot of evidence that converges on this point.
- 4.8 We already got some really huge overlaps with how it's preparing us for justice. Beauty. Scarry does something really interesting. Just one of those moments when I was reading the book where I went, oh, you know those moments where you—that's brilliant. I feel so stupid. Because she says, you notice that we use the word fair both for beauty and for justice? "That was fair" means you did something justly, you treated things fairly, or she is fair of face. Her face is very fair. By the way, those two meanings share the same etymological root.
- 4.9 Why? What's going on there? Because in both fairness as justice and fairness as beauty, we care about balanced and well-proportioned. We want appearances that are not hiding but disclosing reality. We want something that is giving us an optimal grip on the world. We use all these balance and proportion. That's a disproportionate response. You hear that all through the media. Well, what teaches you proportionality in your perspectival judgments? Beauty. Beauty. Beauty prepares us for justice.
- 4.10 So beauty is allied with truth and goodness. This is Scarry's point, and I've helped to buttress that point, I hope, for you. And this is the ancient view of beauty, once again. That the true and the good and the beautiful are all deeply interconnected with each other. Notice you have to love the truth to be a good scientist, and you have to think that getting the truth is something good for its own sake, to be a good scientist. Even a scientist is supposed to be, I don't care about it. You're actually committed to beauty and goodness in being a good scientist in your pursuit of the truth.

- 4.11 This allows us to move to our next major thinker. We've done Han, we've done Scarry, and now we do Sonia Sedivy, who I actually know personally. I know her, I don't know her well, but grad school, same time, and had a couple conferences together and showed up in a couple meetings together, a couple conversations. I'm always deeply impressed by Sonia. Her book is *Beauty and the End of Art*. Really nice title, by the way, because the end of art sounds like— could mean how art is ending, or when we say, what's the end as the goal of something? What's the role of art, and she's playing with that ambiguity because we're in that ambiguous time about art.
- 4.12 She's got a lot of really brilliant things to say about art, and I'm not going to teach you any of them because I'm going to concentrate on what she has to say about beauty. Because to be fair to me, that's actually the first word in the title of her book. *Beauty and the End of Art*. She's going to pick up on something we've talked about already, this beauty and this connection to presence and plenitude. Sedivy foregrounds and makes explicit a theme of beauty already alluded to by Han and by Scarry.
- 4.13 This is, beauty cannot be completely captured in words or concepts. I showed you that. Remember? I can't capture it in my categories because it's combinatorially explosive. I can't capture it also because it has this suchness that's before any categorization. There's this excess to beauty. It has an excess of intelligibility. It makes sense to us beyond what we can put into words. People frequently will say that, and we have all these trite Hallmark card sayings. "It took my breath away," which doesn't mean you're asphyxiated. That's terrifying. Imagine if you—that's a horrible experience. What you mean is, you stopped talking. You stop talking. Myeo, mystery.
- 4.14 Beauty cannot be completely captured by words or concepts. It has an excess of intelligibility. Why? Because it's pointing to the fact that reality is an inexhaustible fount of intelligibility, both beneath and before our thinking, and above and beyond our thinking. Again, this is how beauty is like insight. There's work done on what's called the ineffability of insight. When you have an insight, how did you come to that? You go [noise]. You don't know. You can say some things you were doing before. I was taking a shower.
- 4.15 Baker-Sennet, and Ceci in 1996 actually did work showing experimentally that insight involves this leap. Remember, leaping to a bigger gestalt. There's this leap. That leap takes you into the gestalt that discloses new meaning, but it also, in beauty, ushers you into a flow into mystery. You're leaping into mystery, which sounds like a very dangerous thing to do, which, of course, is why we want beauty there to give us the plausibility that we're going to land. Sedivy defends Scarry against a lot of criticisms that misattribute to her the claim that beauty is true and/or it makes us good. And Sedivy, like I did with you as well, just takes all those apart. No, that's not what's going on.
- 4.16 It tells you, and she says, it's really important to pay attention not only to the criticism, but the hostility behind the criticisms. There's a willful misapprehension of what Scarry

is saying, and it bespeaks the fact that people just don't want to hear this about beauty. That, of course, is some of the power and the pervasiveness of the hermeneutics of suspicion and the idea of art as shocking confrontational subjectivity. So, Sedivy likes a particular—she focuses on one statement from Scarry's book that she really likes, that a beautiful thing, quote, "lifts"—leap—"facts into intelligibility." Sedivy says this is a really, really insightful thing to say. "Beauty lifts facts into intelligibility," the experience of meaning, all the stuff we've been talking about.

- 4.17 That little phrase—I agree with Sonia—that little phrase captures so much of what we've been talking about. Sedivy also endorses the proposal from Scarry that beauty helps make cognition and consciousness more elastic and plastic. Scarry actually uses those words, and Sedivy quotes them. Sedivy says, "Beauty helps develop a more capacious consciousness." Now, the thing about this, though, is there's this elasticity and plasticity. That and the shining, the clear discernibility. I used to talk about plausibility, that to-ing and fro-ing. Sedivy doesn't consider that. She does talk about the clear discernibility, but she doesn't really go in on the back-and-forth movement that Scarry talks about so explicitly.
- 4.18 She ignores all the five factors, pretty much, that Scarry lays out for beauty. She's just really interested in this elasticity and the lifting into intelligibility. This connection between facts and intelligibility and the excess of intelligibility and beauty, this is what she's concentrating on. This is what Sedivy wants to explain. This is the philosophical problem she set herself to. She first focuses on how things are actually present in perception. We've been talking about that a lot, but she says let's zero in on perceptual presence, perceptual engagement.
- 4.19 Now, she does this as an analytic philosopher. Before we get to that, I want you to notice something. Notice the difference between this word, which obviously points to the presence of something. I'm going to break it up so you see it, the word again. The attempt to make something present to your mind that is actually absent. We sometimes forget, and we have Hallmark card sayings, "the map is not the territory." The map is not the territory. Yes. But let's really think this through very, very deeply, and that's what Sedivy is going to do.
- 4.20 She says, OK, so two things are going on. We say two things about X, when X is perceptually present to us, when we're perceptually engaged with it. The first thing, X might have other properties. When we're looking at things, we get the sense of the inexhaustibility of the thing in perception. But the second thing, those properties might belong to things other than X. Well, these two are interdefining. The properties that are here might be in other things. I think about how this can be related to other things, yes? Or this is a marker and that's a marker. Notice this is a brush and there are other brushes.
- 4.21 On one hand, there are more properties. On the other hand, each one of those aspects means I'm seeing it from a different point of view. I'm seeing it in relationship to

something other than itself. You see that? These are intertwining. I have a sense of there being more to the object, but I also have a sense of how the object is enmeshed in a field of relations. We have, when we're perceiving something, there's an inexhaustible field of relations available, and there's the inexhaustible flow of the aspects of a thing, and these are interwoven. I can move around it, this is the field of relations, and I can see many different aspects. Because this is a real thing, it doesn't disappear when I move around it.

- 4.22 All of this is pointing to the moreness. In perceptual experience, we get the moreness. But we also get this. In addition to the plenitude, we get the fact that it's present. There's a here, now, this-ness to it. Here, now, this. Here, now, this. Yes? Themoreness and the suchness, the plenitude, but they're bound up with presence. A way of bringing this together is in perception. Plenitude is presencing. Not just thinking it, plenitude is actually presencing. Now, that's really important because Polanyi, important philosopher, talks about this. Really good book on this is Esther Lightcap Meek. I've got a chance to talk to Esther. Wrote a really good book on this called Contact With Reality, from 2017.
- 4.23 She builds on, but she develops Polanyi's model that that's our touchstone. Listen to the word, our touchstone, contact with reality. That's our touchstone for real. We got that perceptualplenitude, the presencing of plenitude. It's inexhaustible, but it's not inexhaustible in a cacophony. There's that musicality of intelligibility. There's a throughline. It's inexhaustible, but it's constantly flowing into presence for us. We're experiencing it here, now, this. I want to go back to a question that was asked. Notice what that does for us. It helps us see how beauty captures two senses of realness that are bound up with that presencing of plenitude. We have two senses of real.
- 4.24 There's two times when we say, "That's real." We've two kinds of time. One is confirmation. It all comes together. Yeah, he really did it. He really did. Look, all the evidence. Confirmation. Listen to the language. Confirming. Confirming. That's our one sense of reality. The other is the sense of reality and realization. "I didn't realize. I've been blind all these years." Our realness is bound between these two because it's bound between order, how things are confirming in presence, this, here, now, hanging together, and how they're also continually opening us up above and beneath our thought to plenitude, from which we can be surprised. Beauty, like realness, is always interweaving a between of order and surprise.
- 4.25 In fact, Miravalle, in his book, What Beauty Is and Why It Matters, from 2019, that's his definition of beauty. I think it's not enough. He says it's ordered surprise. But he's on to something. Yeah, those are important senses of realness, and beauty taps into those two senses and brings them together at the same time. All right.
- 4.26 So, Sedivy makes a good case for all of that. Now we can see why ineffability is just bound in, even with perception. This is why you find it very hard to try and capture something that's unique. In fact, I bet you this, I predict—I will be a scientist—I predict

all of you have had this experience. You're in the wonderful sunset, you take a picture of it, and then you go to show a friend, and it looks like this tepid thing. "Oh, that's nice. What was that?" You know, you [noise].

4.27 OK, so within this polarity—what do I mean by polarity? Having to do with two poles. Within this polarity between the suchness and the moreness, we have the presencing of plenitude. Suchness and the moreness, the ineffable, it's drawn in. OK, so we have all this ineffable, below, before, beneath, above, beyond, in perception. That's what makes it real. That's why we based scientific claims—our most abstract mathematical formulations have to be grounded in empirical evidence. But what's the problem then? Well, here's the problem. How do we think reality? How do we think it?

4.28 Once you understand, once you've really unpacked the phenomenology of perception, it's like, wait, in order to think, I have to have determinate thought. I need a definition that has to be finite, limited, bound, not inexhaustible. I have to be able to speak it. When we ask people to defend a position, they're not allowed to say, "Well, you know —" They have to give us a definition. They have to bring it into determinate thought. They're not allowed to say things that are bordering on inexpressibility, ineffability.

4.29 Now, if they're trying to perform beauty, that's a different thing, like in poetry. You now know that I don't think of poetry as some subjective thing you do. You can mark how well developed the culture is or how in trouble it is by the degree of reverence it gives to poetry. So, the issue is, though, there's a specific kind of thought. We're going to come back and talk about different ways of knowing. But what the problem is here is, how do we take this excess, this inexhaustible, this ineffable, that is not some necessarily mystical experience, although I have no problem with mystical experiences.

4.30 But this is just here-now experience, and yet we're supposed to be able to think about it, because I have to ask you questions like, "Where's the door?" You don't want to say, "Well, you know." What do I do? I'm just lost. It's over there, and this is what a door is. We're talking about propositional, inferential, conceptual thought, the kind of thought that goes into our theories, our beliefs. I happen to believe that cats are mammals. Yes, I'm obsessed with cats. You can see this. I'm not actually, well, I have a tiger tattooed on my arm, so sort of. Kind of, I guess.

4.31 Here's the thing about language. Cats are mammals. That's called predication. That's when I predicate a category of something. A cat is a mammal. A mammal is a living thing. Notice what I'm doing. I'm relying on categorization. Remember, we talked about this. I'm not picking out the unique individual. I'm not picking out what is beyond words and concepts. How do we appropriately speak or think in terms of concepts and inferences and propositions about our perceptual experience? Now, notice you say, I don't ever ask that question. That's because we have this entire cultural framework that's supposed to answer that question. Me, too, until I did some academic work. We don't step back and call in the—well, I look at things and I measure them.

- 4.32 But how? How do you get perception into thought? This is the question that is asked by Sonia Sedivy's two most favorite philosophers, Immanuel Kant and Ludwig Wittgenstein. Of course, now we're into the Germans because they wrestled with this problem, and they continue to wrestle with it in a really, really profound way. This was a question that really bedeviled Kant. Sedivy is going to concentrate on Kant, and then she's going to use Wittgenstein to help her. Because like me, she's going to reject Kant's idealism. She uses Wittgenstein to argue for a realistic interpretation. That's getting fussy for some of you. That's sort of academic. I'm just going to mention it. We can put it aside. I'll talk about it a little bit, but let's go back.
- 4.33 Kant was really wrestling with this question of, how do I get this into this, in a way that's justifiable, in a way that allows me to say this is true about this? I'm going really slow here because we take for granted that it's obvious how you do it. One of the jobs of philosophers, because they do actually have a job. It's not about sitting around in cafes going, "It is not the being of nothingness, it is the nothingness of being." It's not that. OK? Philosophy is about making you wonder. It's about making you step back and question what you normally find obvious. It's really, slow down. Let this soak into you. How do we do that?
- 4.34 Now, what Sedivy is going to argue using Kant and Wittgenstein, I'm going to start that argument now. I'm not going to finish it now. She's going to argue, beauty is what does that. Beauty is what does that. Beauty, not specifically. It's not that everything has to be beautiful. That's a silly claim. It's that beauty teaches us how to do that. Because there's something about beauty. It brings all into this, in this clear way that's plausible, sets us up for reason, all of that stuff.
- 4.35 She zeroes in on Kant. Kant talks about—sorry, it's hard to talk about this without it sounding a little bit. Kant talks about reciprocal stimulation, which sounds a little bit like something you want to do with somebody behind closed doors. But he uses that language. He talks about reciprocal stimulation. I think this notion of reciprocal will turn out to be important. Or he uses the language of a free and harmonious interplay between imagination and understanding.
- 4.36 Oh, here's the imagination coming in again. Here's Kant, who's supposed to be the epitome of the Enlightenment, the epitome of, we're going to put away all metaphysics, we're going to put away everything that takes us away from Newtonian science. And yet he's invoking the imagination as playing a crucial role. There's a really good book about this by Matt Segall out, on the etheric imagination. Really good book. First of all, Kant is obviously not talking about mental imagery, like when you picture things in your mind, or if he is, he's making a mistake. But I can't see him clearly talking about that the way we do.
- 4.37 He's talking about—he wouldn't use this language because he's an idealist. But he's talking about what I've talked about when I've been talking about the imaginal. He's talking about the imagination that is necessary to bridge between perception and

understanding. OK? Oh, OK, that lines up? One of the things I hope to do if I'm a good teacher and I've educated you is I give you a conceptual vocabulary and a theoretical grammar so you can approach material that might be otherwise inaccessible and it becomes accessible to you and go, oh, that's what this means. That's what's going on.

- 4.38 Now, in order to get this, we have to look at the contrast. Kant writes three critiques, the Critique of Pure Reason, the Critique of Practical Judgment, and then, I forget the name of the third critique. It's the critique that's about aesthetics, about beauty. When he talks about beauty in the sublime. What judgment is it? I can't remember. Anyways, there's a contrast between when he's talking about beauty and when he's talking about knowledge. That's, by the way, what the word cognition means. Cognition means that part of your psychology that has to do with knowing.
- 4.39 All right, so we're in the relationship between perception and cognition and the imagination as the imaginal is what binds the two together. We've seen that. Say a little bit more, Immanuel, Immanuel Kant. What's happening in normal cognition, according to Kant, is, and this was revolutionary for the time, Kant proposed that the mind has rules that it imposes on reality. It basically filters, shapes, structures reality to follow the rules so that our experience becomes meaningful to us. He called it his Copernican Revolution. Copernicus flips things around. What's Kant flipping around?
- 4.40 The old model was, the world is the way it is, and what I'm trying to do and experience is conform to the world. I make my mind conform to the world. Kant flips this around and says, no, what's actually happening is we're making the world conform to our mind. To use our language, his model is a completely top-down model of knowing, completely top-down. In fact, he makes this rather radical proposal. Now, Kant is very complex, and no matter what I say about Kant, someone's like, "No, you're not saying it right," but I'll take that as it comes.
- 4.41 But Kant has this proposal of the thing in itself. He says the mind, and we have to use the language, is projecting all of these categorical rules on how experience has to shape, such that we never know the thing in itself. We never know reality as it is in itself. We always only see it from within inside the mind. This is why he's an idealist. Now, I reject that. To tell you why I reject it, I've got lots of lectures online you can see about why I reject that. That's a huge argument because Kant is a pivotal figure. Why am I teaching it to you then if I don't think it's true? Because you need to understand it in order to understand what he's going to say about beauty. That's why we're doing it.
- 4.42 We have this completely top-down. He's the opposite of the empiricist like John Locke. We think the mind is a blank slate. That's John Locke, tabula rasa. The mind is just a blank slate that experience writes on. Then you have the Romantics. No, no, the world is a canvas, and I paint on it. Then Kant's saying, No, no. The world is mathematical, and we impose math on the world, and everything comes to us that way, mathematically. That's why science works. It's a powerful argument, by the way. He's not silly. I think it's wrong. This is definitely profound.

- 4.43 But what he wants to say is, when we experience beauty, something else is happening. The imagination comes in. Instead of the imagination just being the mediator between cognition and perception, the imagination starts to do free play in a way that's harmonious with understanding. But by doing that free play, it actually discloses something about how we make sense of the world. This is a really good cliffhanger to end on. What is it that the imagination is doing? How is it that it is actually doing that? How is it that the experience of beauty makes the world thinkable, intelligible, to us.
- 4.44 We're going to see that it lines up with everything we've said. It also gets us enmeshed in a profound thinker, Kant, but it then opens us up to what Kant is in deep opposition to, which is Plato. Plato shows up in almost every book on duty because he has profound philosophical reflection. Remember, now, you can remember, all those people I was citing about, who kept beauty on a pedestal—Augustine, Dionysus, Aquinas—they're all deeply influenced by what? Neoplatonism. We kind of eventually work our way back to that. That's what we're doing. We're working our way back, carefully, because it takes great care.
- 4.45 So we've got a question, a question we're going to broach next time. What's going on in Kant? What does Sedivy think about it? What can we learn about this? Then how can that set us towards what Plato has to say about it? By this long journey, which I hope wasn't a waste of time, we found our way back in a plausible manner to the ancient view of beauty that we had lost when beauty fell. Thank you. We'll now take some questions, some Q&A.
- 4.46 Hi.
- 4.47 Hi.
- 4.48 At the beginning—
- 4.49 By the way, can I just ask you a question? Do you see how your question in the previous lecture was prescient for some of the stuff we've done?
- 4.50 Yes.
- 4.51 Excellent. By the way, that's so encouraging when a student is prescient because it means I'm not wasting my time. So thank you.
- 4.52 Thank you. At the beginning of this particular lecture, you were talking about the concept of plausibility and how plausibility has to do with scientific inquiry. My question is, I guess I'm struggling with this concept of plausibility because the assumption would be that the scientists, through some sort of pattern recognition or experience, develops a theory that something has the potential to work or be true.
- 4.53 My question to you would be, I've heard of artists, scientists, inventors, creators, who explain that their ideas almost came from some sort of revelation. Across time, there have always been great thinkers who have come up with ideas that nobody could even conceive of being plausible, and yet, with further scientific inquiry, were proven to be

true. I'm curious how you see plausibility relating to some of these potential exceptions.

4.54 Right. Just allow me to reinforce what I said. Remember, I'm not saying that plausibility is certainty or even probability. It's just what you need to take to help you make the judgments of what you should take seriously and where you have to invest your limited time and attention, et cetera, and that's absolutely necessary. Let's pick a specific example. Einstein, when coming up with his theory, and it came to him like that, it came to him, and you're right. These are realizations, these are insight experiences, and they have this ineffability to them.

4.55 Einstein was, well, now that I've given you the language, I can say this and you'll know what I mean. He found the beauty of his theory so plausible that he was convinced of it ahead of any empirical evidence, and it gave him the determination and the confidence to keep pushing people to look in different ways until the evidence was found. I think it is correct. Now, this can go astray. Sabine Hofstetter, I believe that's her name, she's got a YouTube channel. She talks about how current physics is intoxicated by beauty because we're doing all this stuff and the math is beautiful and we have many worlds and we have string theory and we have these theories that—and all that we have is that they're beautiful.

4.56 So, you don't want to—you don't want to confuse plausibility with probability, and with mathematical certainty. But why? Why do we need to integrate relativity and quantum mechanics? Is this bothering you? Are you, oh my God, I can't live my life. I don't know how quantum mechanics and relativity go together. Is any of our technology not working? We're driven by beauty. We're driven by, I want to be able to put an equation on a T-shirt that captures it all. Somehow the whole plenitude comes into this one thing. It's all clear, it's all plausible.

4.57 I hope this is answering your question. I think it is deeply driven by this. We have to remember that scientists are not particularly good at explaining how they do science, any more than artists are particularly good at explaining how they do art. So, we have to be very, very careful to distinguish how we have to justify our scientific claims, with all of the processes by which we come up with these powerful theories in the first place. Does that answer your question?

4.58 So, is plausibility the subjective experience of the scientist?

4.59 I think plausibility is a transjective experience that says there's a really good chance my cognitive model is fitting reality in the right way. That's what I would say.

4.60 I hope you'll allow me to take what I've learned into another topic that I've been interested in. In relation to the ancient world of thinking and ancient texts, do you think that what we talked about today can be seen a lot in how femininity is talked about in ancient text in regards to female being wisdom, for example, in the Bible, or this idea of the mystery behind the feminine? Would you be able to touch on that a little bit?

- 4.61 Yeah. I mean, this is fraught, of course, because there's also a lot of ways in which the ancient world was particularly nasty to women. The place, Athens, Socrates, Plato, Aristotle, the last place I'd want to live in the ancient world, if I was a woman, was Athens. They treated women horribly. I don't want to dismiss or diminish any of that. That's all the case. But nevertheless, I don't think it's happenstance, again, for a lot of the same not-justifiable reasons, that it's men that are writing, and they're often using women as an example of this kind of thing. This will come up in some really interesting ways.
- 4.62 By the way, to give him credit, Plato did argue, he's really straining at the limits of his abilities, but I give him credit for it. He did argue that women could be rulers, philosopher-kings. But there are crucial places in Plato's text, and we'll talk about this when we talk about Plato, where Socrates, who's usually the master of ceremonies in Plato, actually defers and is being taught by a woman, especially about beauty and love. There was definitely that association. As you say, sophia, not just in the Hebrew, but in the Greek tradition, feminine.
- 4.63 I think there is a relationship, there's an explanation. I'm not making a justification. There's an explanation for the fact that many men are using women as prototypical instances of their experience of beauty and mystery and depth and being called to a more expansive understanding of reality. And also bound up with love, which we keep seeing hinted at as this reciprocal relationship with beauty. We love something because it's beautiful, but it becomes beautiful because we love it. All of that is woven up together. I'm asking for charity on your part that you don't confuse my explanation with any justification. I'm not making a political justification. I'm talking about, well, does that make sense that it would have unfolded that way? I'm trying to say, yes, it does.
- 4.64 Do you have any practical advice? Sorry if I'm jumping ahead on this, too. Any practical advice for somebody? Given that beauty, you can give it a definition, but it takes a long time. People appreciate beauty who could not articulate that definition. How would you advise somebody who's attempting to cultivate their sense of beauty and their fluency, if I'm using that right, with it?
- 4.65 I'm doing a couple of things. I'm trying to recommend exemplary literature to you that will help. Don't just rely on me. That's ridiculous. Exemplary literature will help give you the tools. But you want to also engage in practices that train your attention, give it this elasticity and plasticity that get you to remember the suchness, like in deep meditation, or the moreness in deep contemplation, and how to flow between them. I talk about this in some of the work I've got online about mindfulness and meditative practices and contemplative practices.
- 4.66 I've also published on this, that the mindfulness practices that help to give the elasticity and the plasticity and help you deeply, experientially, not just in words, but experientially remember the suchness, oh, the moreness. Where you get caught, where

you get taken into the ineffable source of intelligibility, not as a thought, but as a direct realization. You want to engage in imaginal practices, practices that are designed to get you to be explicitly aware of the imaginal and to make use of it and practice it. You want to have practices that have to do with the four Es that I'm going to talk about, but I've already alluded to them, practices that get you to reexperience cognition as transjective, not in your head, but as embodied, enacted, extended between you and the world.

4.67 You need embodied practices. Particularly mindful martial arts are really important for this. And you need dialogical practices. You haven't got the argument for that yet. That argument is coming. But here's the foreshadowing it. Contrary to Descartes, you don't reason best monologically, in both senses of the word, using logic, pure logic, or as a monologue by yourself. First, why not pure logic? Pure logic works in terms of algorithmic certainty, rule-following certainty, yes?

4.68 If I want to be certain that I found the solution in the search space, how much of the search space do I need to search? How much? All of it or most of it? That's cognitive suicide. Contrary to Spock and data, you don't want to be comprehensively logical. Being rational isn't about being logical. It's about knowing where, when, and what degree to be logical. That's a very different thing. That's Aristotle's model. You have to be reasonable about how you're logical. First of all, there's that.

4.69 And monological—you actually, and more and more experimental evidence about this. I just gave a talk at Harvard on this. We reason better when we reason together. You take a standard reasoning experiment, the Wason selection task. We've been doing it since 1966. We've been doing it on really bright people who are in university—and massive replication, it's never failed to replicate. Only 10% of those people get it right. It's a really simple task. It's like the nine-dot problem. It looks easy, and everybody gets it wrong. Reliably. People are like, "Why did they get it wrong? What's going on?"

4.70 I teach a course on this, but trying to summarize all of this into a little thing. Take that same task, the Wason selection task, which, when people do it individually, only 10% of them get it right. Let four people, give it four people, and they have to work together. They have to be dialogical, not debating and confrontational. They have to be dialogical. They have to question and answer. They have to, like what Socrates did with people. The success rate goes from 10% to 82%. Here's the thing. You might be thinking, well, what happens is, one person gets the answer and then convinces everybody else. It's not the group. It's one person, and then they persuade everybody else. This is called the persuasion model.

4.71 What you can do is you can run an experiment on that. What you'll do is you're going to give people the Wason selection task. You have them try it first individually, and then you have them try it and do it in a group. Now, what you see is, if the people came up with the right answer individually, does that predict success in the group? Here's the really clear answer. It is neither necessary nor sufficient for an individual to have got

the right answer, which means, we have empirical evidence that it's the group as a whole that comes up with the answer, not a particular individual.

4.72 There's mathematical argument and evidence for that, the work of Erik Hoel and other people. That's not part of this course. That is a part of other courses I teach. But you want to do dialogical practices, imaginal practices, mindfulness practices, and embodied practices. We have an acronym for that. We call it DIME. That's the stuff you want to do, in addition to the philosophy, which is—you need the philosophy. Why do you need the philosophy? I know how to—I've got a tiger on me. Why? Because I do tai chi chuan. Tai chi chuan is, and I do qi gong and other things. You get into the flow state.

4.73 But it comes out of Daoism. Daoism is basically the philosophical religion of flow. Think about the person who is the video game. The flow is locked into this. It doesn't transfer broadly and deeply to many parts of their life. It doesn't transform them and call them beyond themselves, yes? What you need is, you need a philosophical framework to make sure that your practice here and now transfers broadly and deeply and transforms you broadly and deeply. That's the role of a philosophical framework. You need the DIME ecology of practices, but you need a philosophical framework around it. That would be my more complete answer to you. Thank you, everyone.

Lecture 5: Beauty and Perception

At a glance — Beauty and perception, engaging Elaine Scarry's work.

- 5.1** Welcome back, everyone, to Lecture 5 of the Primacy of Beauty. Last time, we were taking a look at Scarry's work, and I built on that a proposal for a model of plausibility. The basic idea is, in plausibility, we have convergence that gives us trustworthiness. We have elegance that gives us power. This also gives us compression that extracts things that are invariants. This gives us variation, and therefore, we can get some deep learning. This is precedent seeking. This is precedent setting, and that gives us a normativity. In the core of it, we have the realization of coherence, that it hangs together well, it's informative, it rules out alternatives, rules in the right information. Then, of course, there's balance between them.
- 5.2** I argued that that's what's going on in plausibility, when what we mean by plausibility is, it makes good sense, it should be taken seriously, et cetera. I argued for the primacy of plausibility. We need it before, during, and after our scientific investigation always. It's irremovable, it's indispensable. It comes first in a very important foundational way. Of course, that structure maps quite readily on to the structure that Scarry gives for the phenomenology of experiencing the beautiful tree.
- 5.3** That means that I've tried to make a case that beauty is a species of plausibility. In particular, what is that specific version of plausibility that is beauty, beauty as the emergence of embodied, enacted, evolving existential plausibility? Remember, it has to do with meaning in life. This is happening within an imaginal flowing niche construction process, mutual fitting, belonging, all that relevance realization stuff. It's juicy with relevance realization.
- 5.4** Now this, of course, because it's transjective in nature, has to occur with the right mode, existential mode, the right mode of orientation, in order to recognize the mysterious. I mean that in the sense we've talked about here, the mysterious polarity of the presencing of plenitude that is the hallmark of perceptual experience. That's foreshadowing Sedivy. Then we took a look at Scarry's argument, and also some from Han, which goes towards the primacy of beauty in the argument that what beauty prepares us for.
- 5.5** She argues that beauty prepares us for truth. It gives us those moments of realization, clear discernibility. It makes us open to the imaginal that's at work in being rational, being reasonable, getting metacognitive, reflection, all those things we talked about. Beauty makes us non-egocentric. It opens us up to self-correction, makes us care about clarity, and makes us, of course—she doesn't quite say this, but something like, we start to fall in love with truth. We start to love it. I added to all of the ways in which beauty is preparing us for truth, that beauty gives us coherence and plausibility, which are also very central for our achieving the truth.

- 5.6 She also argued that beauty not only prepares us or affords us the truth, it's not only allied to the truth, but it's allied to the good, specifically in that it prepares us for justice, a particular species of the good that our culture, but also Plato, he wrote a whole book about it, the Republic, is deeply reflecting upon right now. How does beauty prepare us for justice? We have that it teaches us un-selfing. It has us caring for something other than ourselves, which is why it makes it have meaning in life for us.
- 5.7 It, of course, is about fairness. That pointed us towards properly balanced and proportioned prioritization of what we find salient and putting things into perspective and participating in the right way. And of course, all of those also help make us more reasonable, more rational, and all of this comes together in making us more just. So beauty has primacy because it prepares us for truth and it prepares us for the good, prepares us for justice.
- 5.8 We move to Sedivy, Sonia Sedivy, and foregrounds and explicates something implicit in Han and Scarry, which is the ineffable excess of intelligibility in beauty. Beauty is ineffable in some ways. It goes beyond our ability to capture it in concepts and in words. Beauty, like insight, involves a leap. If you remember, we talked about that there's a leap of ineffability in insight, there's ineffability in flow experience. Beauty is that kind of leap that's flowing into mystery in a very powerful way. And mystery also is very deeply ineffable, ultimately.
- 5.9 She then, of course, also defends Scarry against some unnecessary accusations and points out the hostility towards beauty. Hostility towards beauty that's not properly argued for. She actually uses the phrase at one point, or she quotes somebody using the phrase. Somebody's saying, well, "this model of beauty violates the hermeneutics of suspicion," as if, oh, don't dare do that. That, to Sedivy's credit, she carefully stands aside from the bombast and carefully goes through and says, "Oh, no, look, look."
- 5.10 Now, what she really likes from Scarry is this one particular phrase, how beauty lifts fact into intelligibility. This connection between perception and conception, or perception and cognition, is really central to her concern about beauty. She likes the model of how beauty brings an elasticity and a plasticity and an expansion to the mind. She thinks Scarry is bang on about that, and she thinks that's good. She doesn't get into the to-ing and fro-ing, so she doesn't have much connection, like I've made, to plausibility or to insight and flow, because she really wants to zero in on this connection between perception and conception, and how does this unpack and help us to understand this excess of intelligibility issue that she's been talking about.
- 5.11 She goes into perceptual presence. What is it for things to be present to us, for us to be perceptually engaged? She goes over it quite analytically, but we got to this idea. In any perception of anything, there's a moreness of how it is relationally situated in a field of relations. We also have the suchness, the here-now-thisness, the pure indexicality that comes before and is presupposed by any categorical conceptual identity. Remember,

we have to be able to literally point the mind at something before we can get anything else going.

- 5.12** Both of these are there in our perception. We have this plenitude that's being presented to us. This presenting of plenitude is the defining feature of perception. And Polanyi, Michael Polanyi, a philosopher, argues this. Excellent book by Esther Lightcap Meek recently on this, *Contact With Reality*, that our sense of contact with reality is exactly this sense of an inexhaustible fount of intelligibility that is presenting to us. It's like a touchstone for realness. And so, implicit behind this is, this is kind of like the standard against which we are comparing things when we're talking about realness.
- 5.13** That's where we make a contact. We're not representing realness, we're actually in touch with realness. We have that language. It's lost touch with reality. It's lost. Get a grip on reality, all that language. And Sedivy turns to how is the presenting of the inexhaustible plenitude, how does that come in as intelligible to us? How does it become something that we can ultimately conceive of and speak of? How can we bring it into determinate, conceptual, propositional thought? What happens to the excess of intelligibility?
- 5.14** This is the focal point where Sedivy really zeroes in and she turns to Kant. Kant was really wrestling with, how is all of that intelligible excess in the presenting of plenitude in perception collapsed into determinate categorical content for propositional, conceptual, inferential, theoretical cognition? OK. Now, Kant argues that in normal cognition, cognition imposes rules on perceptual content. Remember, that's his Copernican Revolution. Basically, it's a model of pure top-down projection. The mind projects basically the mathematical categories on reality, like the three dimensions of space, the three tenses of time, all this stuff, is projected on to reality in order to make experience meaningful to us, intelligible to us.
- 5.15** Kant argues that these rules are the very conditions for the possibility of us having experience that makes some sense to us. It's a completely top-down model. I have criticisms of it. We'll get a little bit more into that today. Sedivy has criticisms of that, and she uses Wittgenstein to ameliorate that purely top-down Kantian model. Kant is basically saying that beauty is this reciprocal, harmonious free play between imagination and understanding. That's his definition of it. I pointed out that he's basically—I don't want to be anachronistic to him. He's way before Corbin, but he could really use the concept of the imaginal here.
- 5.16** We're going to come back into whether or not we can actually understand the imaginal in a purely top-down fashion. That's going to be part of the problem that I'm going to pose to the Kantian perspective. Now, as Kant is trying to answer the question of what—so, this is his definition of beauty. He's giving us a normal model, a model of normal cognition, and he gives us a definition of beauty. Then we got, OK, what's the relationship? The excess is basically screened off and forced into certain framework by the rules, the top-down rules, of cognition.

- 5.17 But in beauty, there's a free play of the imagination with respect to understanding. What's going on there? In order to get at that, Kant turns to another problem that Sedivy goes into, which is, how can beauty be more than idiosyncratic preference? It seems to be more. Now, of course, the people who say beauty is purely subjective would deny that. I think we've already got enough evidence and argument that that's a very hard position to actually defend. It's like, your preferences are idiosyncratic and you don't have to justify them. "I like caramel more than chocolate." Well, why?
- 5.18 That doesn't seem to me like a stand a person should take. We don't do that. Or maybe you do when you're drunk at a party or something, I don't know. But you certainly don't do that in normal. But when somebody says, "Hey, I think that painting is really beautiful," you go, "Well, why?" You are open to being persuaded in a way you are not open to being persuaded about your idiosyncratic preferences. Do you understand this is Kant's point? There's something going on here. There's a shared normativity. There's some universality to beauty. But of course, there's a problem because we don't find the same things beautiful.
- 5.19 OK, so let's get really slow down about this now. Let's get the idea. There seems to be something universal. We can persuade each other about beauty in a way we can't with our idiosyncratic preferences. But we face this problem because what we find beautiful seems so variable. It seems changeable. I thought that was really beautiful. Have you ever done this? You look at a picture of somebody you were with. I'm a little bit older than all of you, but 20 years ago. But hopefully you've had something and you look at them and you go, "What did I see in this person? They seemed so gorgeous." And now it's like, "Meh."
- 5.20 You're all laughing. It's like, what happened there? That, of course, has to do with that love beauty loop we've been talking about. But see, the point I'm making is, you may find X beautiful, I don't. I might find X beautiful at time T, and then much later, not find it beautiful. So it's very variable. Beauty doesn't seem to be intrinsic to a thing. It's not something we could ever have a physics of. A lot of the things that are usually the markers of objective, of universality, of objectivity and universality, are missing. And yet, beauty isn't just reducible, it seems, to idiosyncratic subjective preference.
- 5.21 Kant says, "How do I solve this problem?" He solves this problem, by the way, in a way that inspired me. A little bit of autobiography. I was working on my thesis in 1997, and I went through all the problems around relevance in categorization and communication, in rule-following. This is what my thesis is about. I came to the conclusion, well, there's a problem. Relevance doesn't seem to be intrinsic to a thing. Relevance is changeable. I find something relevant one minute and not relevant the next. And it's variable. You may find something relevant that I don't.
- 5.22 I was like, "Oh, we can't have a science of relevance." If relevance is at the center of cognition, think how my thesis was ending. Then we can't have a cognitive science because we need to have a science of relevance, and we can't have a science of

relevance, so we can't have a science of cognition. Cognitive science is doomed, and what's my field? Cognitive science. Now, to their credit, my PhD committee said this was a really great thesis. They liked my thesis because they could have been all really pissed off at me, but it was like, no, it was really good.

- 5.23** But when I was done, it was sort of like, grr. I was getting a glimmer of an idea because I was already starting to draw this analogy that I've already given to you between relevance and adaptivity. That relevance is basically cognitive adaptivity, and that, like adaptivity, it evolves. Then I realized, oh, you know what Darwin did? He didn't come up with a definition of the essence of adaptivity. Because what makes something adaptive? Well, it can be big, it can be small, it can be soft, it can be hard, it can be fast, it can be slow, it can be complex, it can be simple.
- 5.24** And what makes it adaptive at one point, doesn't mean it's adaptive forever because eventually it will go extinct. You see the same? It's exactly the same. But you don't want to say, "Well, I guess. Adaptivity is just a subjective idiosyncratic preference." That makes no sense, because then evolution isn't real and the whole thing falls apart. You go, "No, no, no." What Darwin did is he understood adaptivity as a relation, a real relation of fittedness between the organism and the environment. He didn't try to come up with an objective account of adaptivity. He came up with an objective account of the process by which adaptivity evolves.
- 5.25** Do you see the difference? He didn't claim that there was some objective essential features. There's one essential feature. It has to enable the organism to survive long enough to reproduce. But what allows an organism to do that is overwhelming. Do you see the move? He moves from trying to find something universal in all the products of evolution to finding universals in the process of evolution. This is Kant makes the same move with beauty. Let's stop looking at all the beautiful things and trying to find their universal essence because we won't. We won't.
- 5.26** But he doesn't conclude, "Oh, well, that's it." Instead, he says, "Let's look at universals in the process by which beauty is realized." Do you see the difference? I want to point out that this has happened also in psychology, and you'll see all the analogies, and this is why all these things hang together. When people were doing work on insight problem solving, remember the nine-dot problem? They were going along and going along. Then in 1995, a guy by the name of Weisberg said, "Hey, there's a problem here. You're behaving as if something is just objectively an insight problem." As if, in and of itself, those nine dots are a problem.
- 5.27** He said, "But problems," and he quite rightly says, "Problems don't objectively exist." What might be an insight problem for you might not be an insight problem for her because she might have the relevant expertise to just roll. What was once an insight problem to you might not be an insight problem to you anymore. In fact, that's what happens in development. As a little kid, you solved a lot of insight problems, and then

you don't have to go, "Aha, a chair." You just go, "Chair." Do you understand? Insight is exactly the same way.

- 5.28** The literature realized, "Oh, we can't find the objective features in the problems because problems don't objectively exist." Instead, what they did, Jung-Beeman, Bowden, Kounios, a whole bunch of people, they said, "Let's see if there's universals in the process by which insight occurs. We'll give people a whole bunch of problems. Some of them will find these set insights, some will find these insights, some will find these insights. We don't care about that. But let's see if there's anything universal and shared between all of them whenever they say, whenever they declare, 'I'm having an insight.'" You shift off the product to the process. Does that make sense?
- 5.29** It's a brilliant move. Notice that these three things hang together. Doing the same move for beauty, that's Kant. I did it with relevance. Sorry, I'm not in the same category as Kant or anything like that. Then the psychology of insight made exactly the same move. As I've argued, this points us towards the reality of transjectivity. Are we OK with that? All right. We can now turn back to Sedivy, and through Sedivy, to Kant.
- 5.30** What's the universal process in beauty? Not the universal product, but whenever anybody says, "I'm experiencing beauty," what's going on in the process? What's happening, Kant is basically arguing, is that we're realizing that imagination is indispensable in its role of making perceptual presentations resonate with determinate thought. First of all, we realized the indispensable role of the imagination. I would say the imaginal here. The point is, wait, without this, I can't be a cognitive agent. If I can't get those two to resonate together, then I'm in trouble.
- 5.31** What about the rule-following? Just hang on, we'll get back to that. We'll get back to that. Let's get into this. Beauty is the free play. It's not rule-bound. It's not algorithmic. It's not arbitrary, remember, between arbitrary and algorithmic. It's not rule-bound, and it's this resonance between perception and cognition. We're still not, yeah, but why are we doing this? Why are we moving outside using the rules? Because the free play actually focuses on the process rather than any specific product, any specific intelligible object. It makes us stand back and become more aware. It makes us take off the glasses that are normally filtering our experience and look at them and go, "Oh, oh, oh."
- 5.32** Remember, that's actually a hallmark of rationality, when you can step back and look at your framing rather than automatically looking through it. We realized, according to Kant, I would say imaginally, in beauty, that the power of perception, that tremendous plenitude, can always be subsumed under the power of conception. What we realize in beauty, and we focus on this, we realize there's a promise here. There's a promise of ongoing intelligibility rather than horror. There's a promise that—I'll anthropomorphize for a sec.

- 5.33 Beauty is saying, "Don't be afraid. I'm here to show you that you'll always be able to translate perception into conception. Always." Beauty is your focused, direct, celebratory experience of the realization that the power of perception can be domesticated, tamed, marshaled, in the power of conception. How would you show that? Well, you would take people outside of normal rule-governed experience, do weird things with experience, and go, "But it still makes sense, right?" You go, "Wow, look at that. It still makes sense." You look at this.
- 5.34 Do you see? The—what do I want to call it? I want to be really careful with that. The non-normalcy of works of art, which is what Kant is really thinking about, are often like, "Look, look at how much I can distort your perception, and you can still make sense of it." That's really, really, whoa, that's really profoundly reassuring. It gives you a sense of that there's a deep competence to your cognitive power.
- 5.35 Like relevance, beauty can't be captured by rules, but it's not just arbitrary. It's putting us in that place in between, so that we can open up the vista on what's happening in the relationship between perception and cognition, and experience a profound reassurance, a profound promise that that resonance will not fail. Now, of course, what you are thinking probably right now is, "But doesn't it fail sometimes?" Horror? Yes. But this doesn't destroy Kant's argument because what is the experience of horror? Most horror movies are not horror experiences. They're based on our ancient fear of things leaping out of the dark and biting us. We do variations on that.
- 5.36 We're also horrified by things that are big and powerful and stuff like that. Basically, this is the ancient fear of tigers. That's why I have a tiger. OK. Now, in horror, you get a different aesthetic experience. You can actually have it separate from terror. What terror is that? I'm going to be eaten, I'm going to be mutilated, I'm going to be destroyed. In a very non-terrifying situation, you can be made to feel as if your grip on reality is being lost. That you're going slightly insane. A good horror movie will do that.
- 5.37 There's a scene in *The Shining* where Jack Nicholson's character is inside a pantry and it's been locked from the outside, and he's talking to the voices in his head. I thought I understood this. Stephen King hates alcoholism. The guy's insanity was a metaphor. I was patting myself on the back because, you see, I'm such a good academic, and I can really understand and interpret this, all that stuff. I thought I had it all down. He's talking to the voices, and I'm wondering, "Yeah, so what? What's going to happen? He's locked in. Is this movie over?" And then the voice says, "Open the door." And a chill went down my spine. There's nothing scary. It's just a door opening.
- 5.38 It's like, "Whoa, I don't know what's going on in this movie. I don't know what's going on. He's not insane. He's actually perceiving something real." This is why horror entities are intercategory. They fall between our concepts. Like a ghost, living but dead, a vampire, the unliving, but has given up all being and is just about consuming. Think about all the horror creatures are creatures that fall between the cracks of our

conceptual grasp on the world. Do you understand? Kant would say, yes, it does fail, but it fails at exactly the point where you lose touch with reality.

- 5.39** Now, you may say, "That's not satisfying. I want it to never fail." Kant really doesn't address that as far as I can tell. The point he wants to make, though, is insofar as reality keeps being there for you, the promise is being fulfilled, and beauty is the experiential celebration of the ongoing fulfillment of that promise. Now, one of the things I could say on behalf of Kant, and Sedivy doesn't say this either, is beauty can give us enough reassurance that we could even face the possibility of horror, that even if there is a momentary breakdown, we can still get through. We will come out on the other side. There's works of literature and art that also work towards that.
- 5.40** The point is, something's going on here in which we are realizing our profound competence to make sense of the world. Now, notice what I would say at this point. Sedivy and Kant do not say it. This is, of course, pointing to beauty's interrelationship with plausibility, because plausibility is making good sense. I could rephrase Kant as beauty is the promise that universal relevance realization, predictive processing relevance realization, will give intelligibility rather than horror. I would further add that beauty is the emergent, enacted, embodied, evolving, existential, plausible promise that predictive processing relevance realization will not fail. Beauty is the celebratory realization of this, where we concentrate not on the products of our cognition, but on the very process itself.
- 5.41** If you remember, Sedivy is influenced by a bunch of people, and one of the people she cites at this point in her argument is that Roger Scruton's book, *Beauty: A Very Short Introduction*, and this is what Scruton says. I'm going to read the quote. "In the experience of beauty, the world comes home to us, and us to the world." That's all that niche construction. "But it comes home in a special way—through its presentation, rather than through its use." We have to be in the being mode. We can't be in the manipulative mode.
- 5.42** This argument from Kant that Sedivy is making use of, and she gives us this beautiful quote from Scruton—see how that sings with everything we're talking about here? The whole framework of the transjectivity, of predictive processing, relevance realization, niche construction, et cetera, et cetera, all of that is in that quote. I want to try and zero in now and make this a little bit more specific in a way that Sedivy and Kant do not. I want to try and point to the imaginal doing exactly this function, and that'll allow me to come back to this issue of whether or not it's completely top-down the way Kant says it is.
- 5.43** I'm going to make use of two bodies of work. They overlap in significant ways. One is the work done by Lakoff and Johnson and other people about conceptual metaphor, and the other is the work around gesture, done a lot by a woman named Susan Goldin-Meadow. Her name was Meadow, I think, or Goldin. Then she married somebody and she got a name that sounds like My Pretty Pony or something like that. But that's her

name. OK, so let's do conceptual metaphor theory. This was started mostly by the book, by Lakoff and Johnson, *Metaphors We Live By*, in 1980. Vervaeke and Kennedy, and Kennedy and Vervaeke also published in the '90s and the early 2000s on conceptual metaphor theory.

- 5.44 OK, so, I want you to get something I'm going to say. I hope you can see the point I'm going to make. I hope you can grasp it, or the French, I hope you can comprehend it. Most importantly, I hope you understand it. But maybe the lecture has been very hard, but we're not very far through the lecture. Do you see what I'm doing? I'm actually enacting what I'm saying and making you realize, oh, everything I'm saying is filled with metaphor, including that sentence filled with metaphor, as if sentences were containers and metaphors were things inside the sentence.
- 5.45 Now, that's very interesting. You can see this pervasively throughout your cognition. What the research, what the argument and the research shows is, these are not just ornaments to our thinking. They are part of the very guts of our way of conceiving the world. This also is the work of Barbara Tversky in her book, *Mind and Motion*. She says what we do is, we take up the machinery in our brain for sensorimotor navigation, and we bring it up into abstract space.
- 5.46 By the way, what does abstract mean? To lift up. You think, what are you talking about? Do you remember when I showed you the search space? We understood problem solving in terms of navigating through a space. None of you went, "Wait." It lands. We've been using top-down and bottom-up, in and out. Conceptual metaphor is a way in which the imaginal is showing up in the bridging between sensorimotor, perceptual engagement, and reflective abstract conception.
- 5.47 I want to make it clear that we're also doing this all day long in a very embodied way. What was that? Well, this is me. This is how embodiment is. It comes up, it goes out. What Goldin-Meadow's research shows is that three things about gesture. Gesture helps you learn faster than when you can't bring gesture. Children will often get the right answer to a math problem in gesture before they can put it in words. If you use gesture, other people will understand you more readily.
- 5.48 One of the things I teach my graduate students when they're learning about teachers, like, use gesture. Have you ever noticed that, even when there's nobody around, you gesture? Have you seen people on their cell phone and they're— If I take you and I have you hold onto a pole, so I'm interfering with your ability to gesture, even in your imagination, your cognitive performance will degrade. Gesture is not orientation. It's part of the guts of your cognition. Gesture is just enacted conceptual metaphor.
- 5.49 OK. We have a problem here. Is it completely top-down? It doesn't seem to be the case. I can't pick just anything and make it a metaphor for understanding. There's some things that—seeing works, getting works, grasping, understanding works, swimming. Does swimming work? No. Breathing? No. No, there seems to be, I can only choose

some things. Lakoff and Johnson go the other way. They're empiricists, radical empiricists. They think it's completely bottom-up. But that can't be right either, because these are very different sensorimotor experiences and patterns. There has to be something above them that guides what I'm drawing from them. Does that make sense?

- 5.50** It can't be that the world is just a blank canvas that I can choose whatever I want from. Kant. That's not right. But it's not that it's just purely bottom-up. Because there has to be something here that guides what I'm drawing from all of those, so that you find them all to mean the same thing, even though the sensorimotor patterns that they came from were very different things. That make sense?
- 5.51** Here, let me show you this a little bit more specifically. This is from the paper in 1996 that I did with John Kennedy. So Lakoff and Johnson make a big deal about argument is war, that we talk about argument as if it's war. "He attacked my position. I defended my position. I undermined their position." When this initially came out, it really, whoa. There's a point there. Now, notice. When I'm talking militarily, I can use other things about the castle. This is also another metaphor, by the way, but that's not problematic right here. "I attacked the castle, I assaulted the castle, I stormed the castle."
- 5.52** Now, notice you don't do that with people's arguments. "I assaulted her argument." What the hell does that mean? Sounds like something violent. "I stormed her argument." We don't say that. Notice when we're talking about attack, in the argument sense, we have things like "criticized, challenged, questioned." Yeah? Near synonyms. That doesn't work for a castle. Militarily, we're going to question the castle. We're going to criticize it. We're going to challenge it. It doesn't work. You see? It's not simply that we map this onto this. We're doing something. There's a top-down, bottom-up interaction, which means it's properly imaginal in nature.
- 5.53** You see, this is why I'm unhappy both with Lakoff and Johnson because they were purely bottom-up, and with Kant because Kant is purely top-down. Is that OK? Now, think about what this means for you, first of all. Notice how, if metaphors can carry insight and beauty, and that's what we do with metaphor, it creates an insight, it creates a new way of thinking about something. In fact, it looks like one of the hallmarks of the upper Paleolithic transition when human beings started to produce all this symbolic art and music and calendars and projectile weapons. It was plausibly about the advent of metaphorical thought because religion emerges at exactly the same time, or at least what we would call religion.
- 5.54** OK. If metaphor can carry insight, metaphor is also the hallmark of poetry, which is how we make language beautiful. Do you see how, if gesture is like dance and conceptual metaphor is like poetry, beauty is running throughout your entire day without you even realizing it. I've taught people in high school how to write poetry. What I had them do was, don't write poetry at first. Just record your conceptual metaphors and gestures throughout the day. Really step back and focus on them, become aware of them, sink

into them, enjoy them. The gestures, make them a little bit more grand, a little more dancy. Make the metaphors a little bit more flowery as they're coming up. Then start writing some poetry. That works. That works.

- 5.55** See, poetry and dance, which we take as actions that often epitomize the presencing of beauty, are continuous with your everyday cognition. That's Kant's point, but I don't think we need the purely top-down or purely bottom-up version of it. Let me give you an alternative that connects nicely with the imaginal. We already got it when I talked about Barbara Tversky's book, *Mind in Motion*. Now, in order to get this to you, I have to talk about another cognitive scientist, Michael Anderson has a book called *After Phrenology* and a lot of work. Other people have picked it up.
- 5.56** Here's the idea. Your brain exaps itself. What does that mean? Let's first talk about biological exaptation. What am I doing with my tongue right now? I'm speaking. Do lots of other organisms have tongues? Yes. Do they talk to you? No. That's scary. OK. So tongues did not originally evolve for speech. Yes? The tongue evolved to move food around in your mouth, highly flexible, and very sensitive to detect poison and lots of sucrose. Highly sensitive, really flexible, and happens to be in the air passage way.
- 5.57** What that means is, evolution—I have to speak about it anthropomorphically because that's how our language works. Evolution doesn't have to design a speaking thing from scratch. What it can do is repurpose the tongue for speech. Does that make sense? That's called exaptation. It's called exaptation. Now, there's something very analogous to that in computer science, or actually computer engineering, circuit reuse. You have a circuit that you designed to do this one thing, and then you can reuse it to do something else in your computer. Circuit reuse, exaptation. You have a biological notion, you have a computer science notion. Does that make sense?
- 5.58** So the idea is, what your brain is doing is taking something that is designed by genetics and by learning to do one thing and then repurpose it for another. You say, "John, give me an example." That's what you want right now, right? I already gave it to you. When I did it, you all went, "Yes, of course." You are bipedal. You walk around on two feet. Now, you realize you're actually not stable. You're always falling. What you're doing is, you're doing a lot of stuff. What do we call this, what I'm doing right now? What am I doing? What am I keeping? I'm keeping my balance.
- 5.59** You have this huge thing in the back of your head, the cerebellum, that's about keeping your balance. It's a huge, powerful machine. What it does is it's about taking all these complex variables, and how they're massively connected to each other, related to each other, and processing it really powerfully and deeply. Then what we do is we take that notion up, we take that balance machinery, and we use it to understand justice. Now, notice, in fact, watch this. I want you, and you're not allowed to say the word over and over to yourself in your head, I want you to think of justice. Hold justice in your mind. Go.

- 5.60 Most people say they picture some kind of balancing of a scale or a person. You go to balance. It's imaginal. Now, what's really interesting about this is the cerebellum seems to have been exapted to do that mapping a lot, taking stuff from the sensorimotor and mapping it up. For a long time, we thought the cerebellum, which is huge, you know you have more neurons in your cerebellum than you do in your cortex? It's a huge machine. We thought, basically, it's about sensorimotor balance. Then there's been a revolution in our understanding of the cerebellum. We now know that the cerebellum has been exapted to do all, to do many instances of what I just did with you. Takes balance and maps it up into justice.
- 5.61 But it does that in really intricate ways and maps it in other ways. So, when people are meditating, their cerebellums are firing like crazy. It's like, what? They're literally not moving, and they're sitting often in a completely stable fashion. It requires minimal effort and monitoring. That's what all that weird posture is. Yet their cerebellums are going crazy. What's going on? Because the cerebellum is taking that capacity to track and find patterns in all of the data that's coming into the brain. Remember how we talked about that, and just even in just walking?
- 5.62 It's taking that and it's mapping it up because what you're trying to do in meditation is you're trying to become aware of everything that's going on all at once within your consciousness. You're trying to get an even, balanced, equanimous, meaning balanced, take on your consciousness. Meditation requires the cerebellum. Do you understand exaptation? I've been proposing, nobody's listening to me, but in addition to the other four Es of 4E cognitive science—that cognition is embodied, embedded, enacted, extended, we'll come back to that—I've been arguing we should add another E, exapted.
- 5.63 See, so what's going on isn't top-down imposition. It's not bottom-up pure reception. It's transjective imaginal exaptation. I'm speaking metaphorically here. It's pregnant with beauty. It's pregnant with beauty. I've taken a very sort of abstract argument from Kant, and I've tried to make it more specific for you, conceptual metaphor, gesture, exaptation, challenging both the top-down and the bottom-up and returning us to what we've been arguing about beauty, how it's imaginal and transjective in nature. Is that OK?
- 5.64 Now, Sedivy doesn't do any of that. She makes a different argument for getting out of that purely top-down framework of Kant. She makes use, Sedivy makes use of Wittgenstein, and she makes use of Wittgenstein to attack Kant's idea about the application of rules, very algorithmic approach. What's Wittgenstein's argument? It's actually an argument that goes back to Aristotle, and there's similar arguments in Brown and other people. I made use of Brown in my thesis. My argument around this, from my thesis in 1997, the naturalistic imperative in cognitive science. Let's do it, though. Let's pick a rule. I'm going to use a moral rule because they're easy to talk about for people.

- 5.65 How many of you try to follow that rule? Be kind. Yeah, it's a marker that you're not a psychopath. If you didn't put up your hand, we're going to have to take you out back and imprison you. OK, so now, the problem with a rule is it doesn't specify its own conditions of application. What does that mean? The way I'm being kind to her, is that the way I'm kind to my son? No, that would be weird. She'd be creeped out and she wouldn't come back. Should I be kind to my son the way I'm kind to her? Oh, but I should be kind to my son the way I'm kind to my romantic partner.
- 5.66 Should I be kind to her the way I'm kind to my romantic partner? That's wrong. What about the same person? How I'm kind to my romantic partner—is that always the same? Well, what if I'm at a funeral for her mother? That's very different than being kind to her when we're shopping together in the supermarket. It's like, oh, no. The problem with this is applying a rule takes massive, massive amount of relevance realization. Then what you'll say is, "I know what I'll do." Sorry, what Kant would say is, "I'll come up with rules for doing relevance realization."
- 5.67 Then what you say is, "Any rule you come up," so this does relevance realization, and any rule that I come up to try and do this is going to fall prey to the same argument. I can't capture rule-following in the rules. Got a paper. They're just finishing up final proofs. It's been accepted for publication. Johannes Jäger is the first author. I'm one of the authors on it. It's about naturalizing relevance realization, and we make the extended argument, much more complex technical version of this and other things, that cognition can't ultimately be computation. It can't be just algorithmic rule application because you can't capture relevance realization in a set of rules in a formal system.
- 5.68 What does Wittgenstein say? Well, you need something other than a rule. What's a rule? A rule is a proposition that you are supposed to make inferences from. A rule is propositional inferential. Yes? Stick with me. This is going to get us to something really important about beauty. What does Wittgenstein say? Well, in addition to knowing that, that's what a proposition is, I know that a cat is an animal. I know that I should be kind. I need to know how to be kind, which is not a rule. It's a skill of relevance realization, judging the appropriateness.
- 5.69 And notice it's even more complex than that because you have to decide which rule to apply as well. My partner wants me to be honest, but my partner wants me to be kind to her. Of course. She'll sometimes ask me, "How does this make me look?" It's like, no matter what I say, I'll be violating an important rule. But which do I prioritize? Here's a rabbit hole we have to avoid, and I fear that, as a society, we're falling into. We're trying to capture judgment in rules. We're hoping we can legislate our way purely into making people behave virtuously. That is doomed to fail. I'm not an anarchist or anything ridiculous like that. I'm just making an argument that you can over-apply the computer metaphor. You can apply it where it does not properly apply.

- 5.70 Notice we have two kinds of knowing here. We've got propositional, knowing that, which is all—that's what Kant is all about. And Sedivy, using Wittgenstein, says, no, that propositional knowing, that is actually dependent on knowing how. They have a name for that. It's called procedural knowing rather than propositional knowing. Is that OK? Now you go, OK, why is that important? Because that gives us a bridge into something, because we've already been talking about how beauty goes beyond the conceptual, the propositional, the inferential. That was vague. Now we can start to zero in on, what do we mean by the non-propositional? What do we mean by that?
- 5.71 Well, we've already got an opening. Oh, what we mean is, in addition to propositional knowing, there's procedural knowing. We start to get some specific content to the idea of ineffability. That allows us to move from Sonia Sedivy's work to the work of Drew Hyland in a really important book called *Plato and the Question of Beauty*. Now we're back to the Platonic origins. Finally. So, the Question of Beauty in Plato. Sorry, I gave you the title the wrong way around. *The Question of Beauty in Plato*, from 2008.
- 5.72 Like I said, Hyland's work is not only important in its own right for helping us make this move we just made. We're going to see that his work also sets up the work of somebody we're going to look at later, the work of Brendan Thomas Sammon, who is directly influenced by Hyland. See, I keep drawing these lines for you because we're making an overall throughline of argumentation and evidence. Hyland argues that Plato presents that beauty is between dianoia and noesis. You're going, "Great. That was really helpful."
- 5.73 First of all, notice this in between. Now, what you want me to do right away is talk about dianoia and noesis. I'm not going to. I'm going to do that in a minute, I promise. What I want to do is point out something which is the between, which we capture right here with the and. That beauty is found there. Why? Because Hyland and Sammon are going to make a great deal out of this between-ness, like I have been doing. Remember I said I've been using this word transjectivity, but I'm going to give you a Greek word that's even more encompassing.
- 5.74 So Plato places a lot of importance on betweenness, which isn't indicated well in standard high school or even undergraduate presentations of Plato. Plato has the theory of the forms, and this is completely missing, which is really sad because it means Plato is being misrepresented. There's a Greek word for this, *metaxu*, betweenness. We're going to need this because Plato is going to argue that this betweenness is really fundamental to reality. For example, and I'll come back to this in more detail, I'm just foreshadowing, human beings are between animals and gods. I go, oh, right. That's important. Does that have consequences for how we should live virtuously? Plato is going to argue, "You bet it does. You bet it does."
- 5.75 A proper recognition, re-cognizing of our *metaxu* nature, that we're between animals and the gods, is essential to being wise and virtuous, to get a sense of why this is going to be a really important idea. Of course, transjectivity is a species of *metaxu*. It's a

betweenness. All right, so let's first go now to the Greek words, *dianoia* and *noesis*. But what is that doing for us? It's pointing us to unpacking non-propositional ways of knowing. We're going to see that in Plato, those non-propositional ways of knowing and the *metaxu* are bound up together in the idea of beauty.

Lecture 6: Beauty and Knowledge

At a glance — Beauty and knowledge — dianoia and discursive reasoning.

- 6.1** All right. So these two Greek words, what does dianoia mean? Dianoia means discursive reasoning, the reasoning you can talk about, you can put it into words. It's propositional, it's conceptual, it's inferential, it's logical. It makes use of the relationship between inference and implication in logic, all that stuff. That's what dianoia means. Now, what does noesis mean? Well, one of the things you should remember is, remember I talked about sizing up. This is Matheson's notion. He actually says that the best word for explaining what he means by sizing up is noesis.
- 6.2** What is this noesis? It's successfully noticing. It's successfully noticing that properly prioritizes and proportions what we're finding salient and how we're sizing things up. We don't have a good word for that, but the Greeks do. Noesis. What do I mean by successful noticing? It's noticing that affords you getting a good grip on a situation or, when necessary, having insight about the situation. We have this metaphor. I have to read the room. That's noesis. I have to read the room. I have to notice, and I have to properly proportion what I'm finding salient, what I'm foregrounding and backgrounding. I'm doing all this in this very flowing manner, and I'm doing it in order to have insight and mindsight, have insight into what you might be thinking. That's noesis.
- 6.3** Now, first of all, let's pause here. It's very interesting that we have this one word, knowing, and other cultures have multiple words. Even in French, you have *savoir* and *connaître*. German has 7,000 words. The Greeks have a set of words. Why? Because there are multiple kinds of knowing. We can miss this important fact about our cognition by thinking that all knowing is propositional knowing. In that missing, we will miss the proper place of beauty. Because beauty, of course, is a profound way of noticing. It's a noticing that has done that. You've properly proportioned things, you've properly prioritized, you're getting insight into what is unique and special about the situation. Beauty is profound noticing.
- 6.4** But if you don't notice noticing, if you speak it and then put it aside and think that all knowing is knowing that—proposition knowing—you miss the kind of knowing that is going on in beauty. All right, let's try and draw this out. Work I've done and work I've done with Christopher Mastropietro and also work done with Dan Chiappe, Chiappe and Vervaeke, very recently, it's greatly influenced by what's called 4E cognitive science. You heard me mention it briefly, and now I'll just go into it a little bit more.
- 6.5** This is the idea that cognition is not fundamentally computation. It's not computation. It's not logical manipulation of propositions in your head like a computer. There's parts of your brain that are working like that, but that's not comprehensively what you are. The idea is that your cognition is inherently transjective in nature. It's much more

proper to say your mind is between you and the world than to say it is within your head. By the way, saying it's within your head is just a metaphor. Aristotle thought it was in your heart. The Egyptians thought it was in your liver. Oh, but brain? Yeah. OK.

- 6.6 Now, what do we mean by the four Es? Cognition is inherently embodied. Your body is central to you being cognitive. You've already seen examples of that. My sensorimotor behavior is indispensable to my cognition. It's embodied. It's also next embedded. Embedded, what do you mean? It's bound into the environment. Niche construction. It's enacted. You do cognition more than you just have cognition. Managing, monitoring, navigating my sensorimotor loop is the primary job of cognition.
- 6.7 It's extended. What does that mean? Well, I don't think just inside my head on my own, monologically. Way before the internet networked computers together to release the power of distributed computation, culture networked people together to release the power of distributed cognition. No one person steers a ship or navigates it. You need a team of people and equipment working together. English. Who made it? Who runs it? Who changes it? Who are you paying royalties to whenever you're using English? Even when you're on your own, all by yourself, you're thinking in English. Other people are there. You're thinking with other people's perspectives that you've internalized. That's how you're rational.
- 6.8 We are participating in cognition because we participate in networks. It is those networks that are actually capable of solving the problem. I need to get to England. I can't do that on my own. I need an entire network, an airline, and air traffic controllers, and governments, and an economy, and currency, and people doing technological engineering. I need all of that so I can go to England. What about what's happening here? Did any of you make this building? Are you generating the electricity? Are you managing the lighting? Is there one person responsible for this series, or a team of people doing different things in a coordinated fashion?
- 6.9 Most of our problem solving is done dialogically with people and with tools, as a network, as a system that we participate in. This is another reason why the monological model of cognition, it's you by yourself in your head, is grotesquely misleading. Of course, that's the model Kant had. That's why I want to put him aside. OK, so drawing on all, and this is a burgeoning area of cognitive science, drawing on all of that, I, with Chris and with Dan, have argued for four kinds of knowing. We call it the four Ps of knowing. I'm going to put it up on the board for you.
- 6.10 I'm going to give you the Greek word. Now, we've got one of these already, *dianoia*. That's discursive reasoning. That's propositional, knowing that. What does it give us? Well, it gives us things that we have in semantic memory. What's semantic memory? Semantic memory is your knowledge of facts. Now, how many of you believe that there are facts? What kind of entity is a fact? What's it made out of? What you're actually talking about is, you're talking about things like cats are mammals. You're storing

propositions that you believe to be true. You store propositions and you have beliefs about them. Is that OK?

- 6.11** This is called semantic memory. All these memories I'm putting up here can be psychologically distinguished from each other, such that you can damage one without damaging the other kinds, or at least significantly damaging them. What you get is beliefs and you have a standard of success, your convinced conviction of truth. This here is how you know it's real. OK. We suffer from propositional tyranny. We think that's it. That's knowing. The Greeks had another word. Techne. We, of course, get technique and technology from that. That's procedural knowing, which we just talked about. That's procedural knowing how.
- 6.12** That's not stored in semantic memory. Knowing how to catch a ball is not stored as a bunch of beliefs. It's stored in procedural memory, which is different. You can do this with a person. What is that thing? I don't know. Sit down and see if you can do anything with it because this is a person who has got some brain damage. They're sitting at a piano and, "I don't know what this is." Then you say, "Just try." Then they start playing the piano beautifully. Their know-how is preserved, even though they don't know what that is. Do you understand?
- 6.13** You've got procedural memory. That's what it's actually called. Procedural memory. It doesn't give you beliefs, it gives you skills. How do you know when it's real? Well, notice we use the same word, but we use it totally differently. My aim is true. What do you mean? What you mean is, you've got a sense of skills that shape your sensorimotor behavior so that you will reliably achieve your goals. That's power. Procedural knowledge gives you power. Technology, power. Your sense of power. I don't mean political power. I mean the power that is the case when you have skills that reliably succeed in making you achieve your goals. OK.
- 6.14** But we have this other term. Noesis. What's this? Noesis is noticing. It's how you're in a situation. It's your situational awareness. It's the perspective you are taking on a particular situation. It is knowing what it is like to be you, here, now, in this state of mind, in this situation. Luckily, we have a Greek word for this because trying to say that all the time would be really cumbersome. This is perspectival, knowing what it is like. It's not stored in semantic memory. It's not stored in procedural memory. Where is it stored?
- 6.15** Let me ask you, how many of you think cats are mammals? Tell me the experience where you first formulated that thought. Tell me your memory of that, please. You don't have it. How many of you remember eating breakfast this morning? What are you doing now? You're reliving it. You're going back and what your state of mind was, what this situation was, what you were noticing, what you were doing, yes? You relive an episode. This is called episodic memory. It doesn't give you belief or skills, it gives you, well, perspectives. What's its sense of realness? Well, this is this presencing. This is truth as realization. That's noesis.

- 6.16** Now, in order to do that, you have to have a bunch of agent-arena relationships and roles ready to go. We talked about this, yes? The Greeks have a word for that. Now, Plato doesn't get that. The word is going to get specialized after Plato, but they have a word for this, gnosis. See, gnosis is a different kind of knowing. It's a knowing by being in an agent-arena coupling. It's how you know relevance realization. It's the way you and the world are fitted together. It's knowing by being with something and it being with you. Your identities are bound up together in a powerful way.
- 6.17** Love is a prototypical powerful version of participatory knowing. Your identity and the other person's identity are bound together, and your knowing of yourself and your knowing of them are equally bound together. Does that make sense? This is why love is its own kind of knowing, as a famous phrase from the Middle Ages put it. OK, so here we have participatory knowing. This is knowing by being with, by coupling. We've got lots of examples of that already. What memory does this give you? It gives you this really weird memory that you don't even realize is a kind of memory. It's yourself. Yourself is how you have been with things, participated, formed your identity, and given identities to things in a coordinated manner, have all these roles, and how all those roles stitch together in some way.
- 6.18** The memory there is yourself. How many of you have a self? I'm actually not saying something like what, but like, what is it? Obviously, what does it give you? It gives you roles, and it gives you identities. What it really does is gives you affordances, affinities. What's the realness for that kind of knowing? The sense of belonging. The sense of belonging, the meaning in life. That's why the fundamental thing you want for yourself to be real is for you to have meaning in life. You want to belong. You want to fit in, as a self, as a person. A person is a self that fits into systems, networks, of ethics and law. That's what a person is.
- 6.19** Belonging, meaning in life. That stands for meaning in life. Now, the important thing is, I already showed you, in Sedivy and Wittgenstein, this is dependent on this, yes? But if I'm going to apply a skill, I have to notice what situation I'm in, don't I? Yes? So this depends on this. In order for me to find things relevant and salient, I have to have lots of ways in which I can come into a situation and be coupled, connected, to the world. Yes? Do you see the dependency relations? This, which is propositional knowing, which we can also put into speech, discursive, is dependent on all of these, and all of these are non-propositional, and the dependency goes deeper and deeper and deeper down. Is that OK?
- 6.20** Now, why does Plato care about non-propositional cognition? Because Plato cares about wisdom and virtue. He cares about you becoming honest. That's an example of a virtue, yes? Or just. Let's do honesty. Is it sufficient to being honest to have certain beliefs? All I have to do to be honest is just believe certain things. No, I have to have a lot of skill, don't I? I have to know how to be honest, not just that I should be honest and honesty is not telling a lie. Remember? I have to know how to apply the rule.

- 6.21** But if I'm going to apply the rule, and if I've got to get the right skills, well, I have to know what the situation is I'm in. Wait, virtue requires beliefs, it requires skills, it requires perspective-taking. What does all of that have to matter? It has to matter to my sense of self. It has to change my character. I have to get new character traits. See, virtue depends on the non-propositional kinds of knowing. See, this is what Plato is doing in the Dialogues. At least this is what a lot of people like Hyland and Roochnik and Gonzales, they're all arguing about.
- 6.22** Socrates will come in and he'll ask for a definition. What is honesty? People try to give a definition, and he destroys it. Most people get really frustrated when they read this. They go, "What's the point of this? I don't know what honesty is." Then what he'll do is, he'll say, "Well, the definitions all fail. Let's compare it to a techne." Like, we know that the shoemaker knows something; they know how to make shoes. Yes. OK, so are we looking for a techne? Everybody thinks, oh, yeah. Honesty is a kind of techne, it's a kind of skill. Then Socrates does his next move. "But wait, that doesn't work, because behind the techne, you need noesis. Even behind that, you need gnosis."
- 6.23** That's what the Dialogues are doing. They're not meant to frustrate you, because when you're reading this—propositional tyranny—you think the point of the Dialogue is, I'm going to get a definition of honesty, and that is not what you get. What you get is call to the realization that honesty requires all this non-propositional kind of knowing. And beauty introduces us to non-propositional kinds of knowing. Do you see what's happening? We're starting to form an argument between the experience of beauty and the cultivation of virtue. We've already seen these arguments in Scarry. But now we're getting the Platonic argument.
- 6.24** Notice that there's connections between noesis, which is this is noticing, and vision. Plato will use visionary metaphors because we talk about noticing as if we're seeing a situation, how we're seeing it. That's what a perspective is, how you're seeing it, even though it's not just seeing. Now, the interesting thing is vision, the word vision and wisdom, have a shared etymological root. That's why there's also associations between wisdom and insight. See, a wise person has tremendously good insight, but they can also bring virtue to bear on that insight.
- 6.25** This now brings us to two of Plato's most famous stories or accounts. One is called the allegory of the cave. That's not a good name for it. It's not an allegory. I think calling it the parable of the cave, analogous to the parables of Jesus of Nazareth, is a better name. You've probably heard of it. If not, you've seen the movie the Matrix, which is just an updated technological version of Plato's cave. There's a bunch of people, they're in a cave, and they are chained so they can only face a wall. Behind them is a fire, and people are walking back and forth carrying items, and they're hearing the echoes of the voices and seeing the shadows. That's TV. Seeing the shadows on the wall, and they think the shadows and the echoes are real.

- 6.26** What happens? Well, one of these people gets free, and he turns. At first, he's blinded by the light of the fire, and then he accommodates. Then he sees the fire, and he realizes. But by the light of the firelight, he sees something beyond the fire. There's a passageway, and he starts to ascend out of the passageway. There's light in the passageway. He has to stop, accommodate, and then he can see further. He moves further, and then he has to stop and accommodate. He goes through this cycle until he comes out and he's in the world, the real world. Then eventually, he can't see. He's blinded. It's too light. It's too bright. But he moves around, he accommodates, and then he can move more, and that keeps looping.
- 6.27** Then eventually, he starts to wonder, what's the source of all of this light and life? He gets a sense of the sun. But he can never, and he realizes it, thankfully, he can never look directly at the sun. Then he's so excited about all of this that he rushes back down into the cave, and he goes so fast that when he gets back into the cave, he's stumbling around in the dark. He tries to tell the people there about the sun and that world, and they think he's insane. And so, they wish to kill him. Of course, that's a parable also for Socrates, who gets killed by the Athenians. It's like, what is this?
- 6.28** Notice that this is putting an emphasis on these, this story. He's not coming up with a definition. What's happening is his vision is changing and he's becoming a different self, a different person. That's what's going on. That's why he can't put it into words. What is it happening for him? He's having one realization after another that is beautiful [gasping]. Sunlight itself and then— What's going on there? Plato has a word for this, anagoge. It means the ascent. But remember, it means both the ascent and the return. It means both going up and coming back down.
- 6.29** What's going on? What happens is, there's a change, and the alignment of his inner psychological processes gets changed, that's accommodation, and that allows him to see more deeply into the world. As he sees more deeply into the world, that challenges him, and he's got to realign his cognitive machinery. Then that enables him to go further. You see what's happening? It's looping like that. He is ultimately seeing more and more deeply into the psyche and more and more deeply into reality in this looping fashion. Is that OK? Does that make sense? See more, think about it this way.
- 6.30** As he gets better at seeing patterns in the world, he gets better at seeing patterns in his psyche. As he organizes his psyche better, he reduces how his psyche is deceiving him, and he can see more clearly into the world, and it keeps looping. See, the anagoge is this loop. Is this making sense? Notice how beauty and anagoge are bound up together in this really tight fashion. So, this is a phenomenon I call reciprocal opening. You open up to the world and then it opens up to you, which affords you opening up to the world, and the world is opened up to you.
- 6.31** Now, if you put that into psychological language between people, you have the work of Aron, that's a last name, not a first name. It's called mutually accelerating disclosure. It doesn't sound as nice as reciprocal opening. What happens in mutually accelerating

disclosure? He and I meet, and I disclose something about myself, and he responds by disclosing something about himself. Now I can see a little bit more deeply into him, and I get a better sense of what I can tell him, what I can disclose to him. So, I disclose more to him. He gets a better sense of how I'm seeing him and how I am. And we do this mutually accelerating disclosure. Does that make sense?

- 6.32** What's that called, by the way? Love. That's how you get somebody to fall in love with you. I don't just mean erotic love. I mean friendship love, familial love. That's love. Notice how everything's coming together. Love, beauty, anagoge. It's all coming together. What's the opposite of reciprocal opening? Well, it would be reciprocal narrowing. It would be, right, that the world starts to lose depth. It starts to lose possibility. I start to lose depth. I start to lose possibility, and in a reciprocally reinforcing fashion. What's that? That's addiction. That's Mark Lewis', a friend of mine, neuroscience, one of the premier thinkers on addiction. That's what addiction is, is reciprocal narrowing.
- 6.33** The world is really crazy, and you're anxious, so I drink the alcohol to deal that. What does that do? It actually makes the world more shallow. What does it do to me? It makes my cognition more shallow. I feel better initially, but the problem is, now my cognition doesn't work as well, and I still have problems. I have to drink more. I have to make the world even more shallow, and I have to become more shallow. This narrows down until there's no other option in the world. There's no future for me, and there's no other way that I can be. I'm completely compelled in a world that has no future. That's addiction. Addiction is the loss of agency.
- 6.34** Reciprocal opening is the enhancement and the maturation of agency. Notice it gives you your two meta-desires. What's a meta-desire? A meta-desire is in addition to whatever satisfies your desire, you want the satisfying thing to have a couple of properties. What are those? When something satisfies my desire X, I don't want it to cause massive internal conflict in me. I want to have peace of mind. There's a strong drive in you, cognitive dissonance. You don't want things to be dissonant from each other.
- 6.35** If I say to you, you're going to have this great sexual experience, but then you're going to be riven and torn by tremendous guilt and anxiety, you're going, "I don't think I want that." Well, once you get a little bit older. Is that the only thing? Well, let's stick with romantic relationships. I'll often ask my students, "How many of you are in satisfying romantic relationships?" Yeah, they put up their hands. OK, those are the people we're going to now continue on with. Romantic relationships are supposed to take the place in our culture of God and history, tradition, religion, everything. "You," sorry, "you're going to do all of this for me. You're going to take the role of God, religion, tradition. You're going to be the entire source of my meaning in life. Yeah." No human being can bear that.

- 6.36** We get the simultaneity of these two facts. What do people think is the greatest source of meaning in life? Romantic relationships. What do people think is their greatest source of suffering? Romantic relationships. All right. I ask the students who are in happy romantic relationships, "How many of you would want to know that your partner was cheating on you, even if that meant the complete destruction of the relationship?" Almost all of them put their hands up. I asked them why. Listen to the language. They're supposed to be all hard-bitten by cynicism and postmodernism. "Because it wouldn't be real." That's what they say without hesitation. It wouldn't be real. In addition to whatever satisfies us, we want what satisfies us to be real.
- 6.37** Now, notice what anagoge is doing. It's aligning my psyche and giving me inner harmony. It's reducing my self-deception so I see more deeply into reality. As I see more deeply into reality, that helps me harmonize my psyche, so I see more deeply into reality. The two meta-desires of being in touch with what's real and having inner peace, inner harmony, are being realized in a coordinated fashion. This is bloody brilliant, by the way. This is why he gets to be Plato, by the way. Typically, you're not taught any of this.
- 6.38** You see what anagoge is doing? It's opening you up. You are becoming at your best, wise, virtuous, and you're also getting more and more in touch with what's real. Reciprocal opening gives you a sense of fulfillment, and it gives you a touchstone, a really deep touchstone, for this is real. Because it's depending on the inexhaustibility of reality, but your capacity to make it intelligible and translate it into non-propositional kinds of knowing.
- 6.39** Now, love is bound up with this. We have another great dialogue by Plato, the Symposium, which is all about love. It's the same story. There's a bunch of people, they all give accounts of love, and they're all important, by the way. Then Socrates is supposed to give his, and he doesn't actually give his opinion. He gives what he was taught by a woman, Diotima. Remember, we talked about that. Diotima describes this anagogic process.
- 6.40** First, you see a beautiful individual. The idea is that, if you're in the right mode, that does all the stuff we're talking about. It makes you a better person. Because of that, you get that capacious mind that Scarry talks about. You start to notice more and more deeply in a more balanced fashion. You start to realize, wait, there's other beautiful people, too. Then that goes back into you and opens you up more. It's not just people that are beautiful. Even parts of the world are beautiful. Landscapes are beautiful. Even virtues are beautiful. You start doing this ascent towards what's the most beautiful?
- 6.41** You're becoming beautified as that happens. You're reciprocally opening in beauty, into love, love and beauty bound together. You're loving the world more, you're loving yourself more, and you're loving how you and the world fit together more and more. This is a really, really powerful set of arguments. Now, in the Symposium, Socrates also makes another point. Love itself is metaxu. Remember the between? Because love is,

part of love is to lack, to not have. You desire something. But part of love is knowing what you should be searching for. Now, sometimes that's not very clear. You got to do a lot of this work to clarify it, to bring wisdom to it.

- 6.42** If you were to ask me my one piece of advice for a good life, it would be this. Learn to love wisely. Learn to love wisely. Everything else is dependent on that. If you don't prioritize that, you will suffer. Because when you're facing your funeral, you won't say, when you're facing your death, you won't say, because you can do this with people—what matters to you, as you're facing your death? Well, I had 17 cars. It doesn't matter. What matters is the love that you've had. It sounds like a Hallmark card. That's why we need Plato so we can get back off the Hallmark card into deep philosophy.
- 6.43** This points to an even deeper theme in Hyland about Plato. We are inherent. Love shows us that we are inherently metaxu. Metaxu is the space of anagoge. We are inherently metaxu. How? Well, I said it already, and it's captured in the title of a book by Hyland, *Finitude and Transcendence in Platonic Dialogues*, from 1995. We are both finite and capable of transcendence, like the cave or like the anagogic ascent to deeper and deeper realizations of beauty within and without. If we only hold on to our finitude, we will fall prey to despair and to servitude.
- 6.44** Imagine if you had a sadistic superego and all you ever thought about was your failures and your faults and how finite you are and how limited. Do you realize how big the universe is and how small you really are? So much time. Oh, this is how much you get. If you really concentrate on that, that really can put you in despair. And despair makes you open to servitude. You will serve anybody who alleviates your despair. What about the opposite? What if I just go for my transcendence? I am godlike. The Greeks had a great word for this, hubris. You get hubris, and then you risk becoming a tyrant. See, when these two things get unglued, you get the tyrants who find the slaves.
- 6.45** We have to hold—this is Plato's great theme. The Greek word for this is tonos. It means like a creative tension—we have to hold finitude and transcendence together. Love, beauty, helps us remember that because love and beauty are both metaxu. They're both about the bridge between the finite and the transcendent. That's been themes throughout. The way love and beauty wrap together is a deep way of realizing, remembering, inhabiting, honoring with our non-propositional kinds of knowing, that we are finite transcendence, holding them together in a creative tension.
- 6.46** Anagoge is afforded by beauty love. I'm going to now keep those two linked together. Beauty love. Anagoge is afforded by that. Anagoge shows us that we are metaxu. It shows us that we are capable of the ascent. But remember how Plato's story ends? And this is why I emphasize it. You don't ascend forever. You see something that is beyond your grasp, and then you return to the cave to tell other people about it because you're finite, you're limited, you need to share with others.

- 6.47 Anagoge realizes our humanity, not as a thought, but as a reality. I would argue that we have to keep this. This is Plato's point. This is at the political point. I don't mean politics like it is now. Zero-sum game, adversarial destruction of opponents that we've mythologized as inherently evil. I'm talking about trying to organize the fact that human beings have to be responsible at the same time to our finitude and our transcendence. Our finitude is, we're just like the animals. Just like the animals, we're subject to disease, decay, disaster. We need compassion.
- 6.48 This is what the left, when it's doing the right job, emphasizes. We're finite. We have to band together to protect each other from the fact that reality is so much more than us. But if it gets isolated from the other side, it becomes dangerous. Well, what's the other side? The other side says, yes, but we're not just animals. We are also like the gods. We are called to nobility. We are called to the cultivation of virtue. We're not just subject to fate. We're called to virtue. We're called to responsibility. We're called to take charge of our maturation. That's the right at its best.
- 6.49 But if it becomes unmoored from the other side, if we lose the creative tonos, the active, ongoing, committed realization of the metaxu, we lose our fundamental humanity. I put it to you that this is one of the problems that's happening in our democracy right now. These two things have lost the polarity, and we have polarization instead, and we are fundamentally swinging between these alternatives in a disastrous manner. This is how Plato is relevant. Plato is not a leftist or a rightist. He is telling you to step back and remember what is at stake in your humanity. Remember that love, beauty, and anagoge are central to it.
- 6.50 Of course, all of this deep connectedness, within and without, in between, gives us enhanced meaning in life. We're getting more virtue, we're getting more meaning in life, we're getting more in contact with reality, we're getting more balanced as a person, we're becoming wiser. Let's remember that most of this is happening non-propositionally, and it's not happening primarily within me, but between me and the world, or even more importantly, between all of us. That's also what democracy was supposed to be about.
- 6.51 It's precisely because I am such a devotee of what democracy should be that I refuse to participate in the current political arena because it misrepresents everything to my mind in a fundamental way. I'm not saying you should do that. I'm explaining to you what my stance is and why it's philosophically—I'm not just being a middling Canadian. "Oh, well, both sides are sort of right." I'm not doing that. I have a developed and sustained philosophical argument that I'm presenting to you, and it comes from Plato, who, by the way, was very critical of democracy. But in a way, I think, that's very helpful to us to more deeply understand it.
- 6.52 OK, so Hyland. Beauty is metaxu between dianoia and noesis. Dianoia is speaking and noesis is silent noticing. This is a great argument made by Rosen in his critique of Heidegger in his book on nihilism. He says nihilism happens when we get either one of

these in isolation. If I'm just speaking, it becomes empty chatter because it's disconnected from the non-propositional knowing. It becomes empty. That's nihilism. But if I just go silent, noetically, that's problematic, too. Why? How are we working together if we can't speak to each other? I get isolated and alone and cut off, not only from each other now, but from all the people who precede me in history. That's my only access to people in history.

- 6.53** You need both together. You need dia-logue, back and forth between silence and speech, between people. Now, this takes us to another theme, a really important theme, that Hyland makes. Hyland says, "Look, I want to talk about all of this. We've been talking about beauty, love, anagoge, and I want to talk about it in a relationship to reason." But he's going to use a different notion of reason. We've been talking about this more extended notion, rational, reasonable. I want you to think about how all of these kinds of knowing contribute to reason.
- 6.54** There's not just the rationality of logic in our propositions. There's also the rationality of knowing how to do something properly. There's also the reasonableness of noesis. Remember, reasonable? Putting things in proper perspective, proportion? There's also rational. The reasonable person has to show up in the right way, take on the right kind of role. There's a rationality of selfhood. The Greeks have a word for this. We don't, of course. You sometimes get this idea that English, I don't know, English is for business, I guess. You get to the bottom line and it's good for that. I don't know. They have a word for this, logos.
- 6.55** It's in the word dialogue, dia, dia, by means of logos, by means of, through, by means of. OK, so logos. Well, it is the origin of, of course, this word, which is about relationships between proposition. But it's not just that. It shows up in "ology," like anthropology, psychology. It also means the study of, the educating in. OK? It also points to what you might call the organizing principle of something. But when I give you the Latin translation of logos, you'll see this meaning, ratio. Ratio. Oh, the organizing principle, the balancing, the proportioning between things. Even of resources, like when you're rationing. And notice that that word is at the center of our word rationality.
- 6.56** What does he say about this? He says logos "is bounded on both sides by non-discursive experience." If you hadn't had that course, you might read that and go, "What's going on there?" What he means is, this logos is in between the suchness and the moreness. See, logos is itself deeply metaxu. Logos is deeply dialogos. It's not monological, it's between. The example in Plato is Socrates. Socrates does question and answer with you and draws you out. He compares himself to a midwife, helping you to give birth to new ideas, or even more importantly, to a new self.
- 6.57** Here's the point. This is how Hyland draws it all together on Plato's behalf. Beauty makes us reinhabit our humanity. This is all around this unifying theme of metaxu. It creates the space for logos. It bridges between dianoia and noesis and preserves us

against nihilism. All of this is taking place within anagoge, the anagoge of love, beauty, fulfillment. This is the Platonic model. You notice, and this is so appropriate to Plato, I can't give you Plato's definition of beauty. There isn't one. It's all of this network of ideas and ways of pointing to non-propositional knowing and transformation and the cultivation of wisdom and virtue. It's all bound up together.

- 6.58** You can't scissor that out. You can't scissor out beauty and say, "Well, what's the definition of beauty?" Because if you're doing that, you haven't been reading the Platonic dialogues, in which there won't be definitions, at least for very, very, very many of them. That tradition, that tradition of Plato, Plotinus, Proclus, Dionysus, Augustine, Aquinas, that's where we started this course, those people and their exalted view of beauty.
- 6.59** The person who picks that up next is Brendan Thomas Sammon. I'll just say Sammon, S-A-M-M-O-N. Two main sources for us. One, a book with this title, *The God Who Is Beauty*. Now, maybe that doesn't sound so strange. How could beauty be god? Oh. He also has a chapter in a book, *The Reawakening of the Between: William Desmond and Reason's Intimacy With Beauty*. The book was from 2013. That chapter is from 2017. Now, obviously, that chapter, *The Reawakening of the Between: William Desmond and Reason's Intimacy With Beauty*, is from a book called *William Desmond and Contemporary Theology*. So who is having a huge influence on Sammon? William Desmond.
- 6.60** Who's William Desmond? William Desmond is a person that also deeply influences David Schindler, and we are moving back towards David Schindler, finally. Desmond himself, and this is completely appropriate, is between philosophy and theology. His thinking prioritizes the metaxu. The between. He has a famous book called *Being and the Between*. His point is that our primary experience, our grounding in being, is metaxu. That's why love and anagoge and beauty turn out to be so relevant. We are not isolated computers in our head. Our primary experience of being is metaxu.
- 6.61** How? What is more familiar to you than existence? Moment by moment, you're never getting away from it. It's there. It's super familiar to you. What is it? What is being? Notice you get this like, well, I've got this non-propositional engagement, and yet when I try to say what it is, it's like [grunting]. We're metaxu. Our most foundational experience, the guts of every moment of experience, is metaxu. We can distract ourselves from this, and we can divert ourselves, and we can pretend, and we get involved in other things. One of the things that philosophy does, Plato, who has a huge influence on Desmond, is call us back to that. To argue that beauty, beauty love, is a way of calling us back to that.
- 6.62** Because love is metaxu, beauty is metaxu, anagoge is metaxu. Desmond calls his work metaxological, which is a difficult word to say. I want to describe it to you. I'm going to give you a long quote. OK, so bear with me. "A tense togetherness of being at a loss." So we have the tense togetherness of being at a loss, "and finding oneself at home with

being." I'm at home. What is being? I don't know. "We must not fail to keep in mind both sides." It's simultaneously our home and the deepest mystery we can confront. "This doubleness is both our plenitude and our poverty." He's alluding to the Symposium where Eros is described as the child of plenitude and poverty. Because in love, we deeply know, that's the plenitude, but we also are deeply lacking.

- 6.63** "The doubleness is both our plenitude and our poverty, our grandeur," transcendence, "and our frailty," our finitude. "Our highest call to nobility, and a perennial reminder of our infirmity." Do you see how all the things we have talked about are coming into this? Of course, beauty is the powerful presencing of all of that. Now, Desmond has bought this whole Platonic argument into recent philosophical and theological work, and he is deservedly famous for doing so.
- 6.64** Sammon picks this up. Let's first look at the chapter. I want you to zero in on the name, The Reawakening. Not the statement, not the definition. The Reawakening. Notice all of that, noesis, gnosis. The Reawakening of the Between: William Desmond and Reason's Intimacy With Beauty. All right, going to go a little bit more longer because I want to try and get finished. I'm on the last two pages. So hang in there. Don't die.
- 6.65** Sammon talks about something that we're now already clear about. He's going to talk about reason. He's talking about reason's intimacy with beauty. And he says, "I don't mean just logic. I mean logos." OK, good. We got that. We know what that is. And then he says, in order to get this, the intimacy between beauty and logos, he's presupposing, as Desmond does, the Neoplatonic tradition, which I keep alluding to and pointing to. The Neoplatonic tradition has its origin in Plato, but it doesn't stay there, or it wouldn't be Neoplatonism. It would just be Platonism.
- 6.66** So, I have to give you a crash course in Neoplatonism. Now, I would like to do a full Peterson Academy course on Neoplatonism, and I'm going to try and capture it in about five minutes, give you enough that you need. When you're at a party, you can talk about this and pretend you know a lot about Neoplatonism. OK. Neoplatonism is the integration, the living integration, of Aristotelian science. Aristotle is considered the greatest scientist of the ancient world. Platonic spirituality. What is Platonic spirituality? Anagoge. That's Platonic spirituality.
- 6.67** You got Aristotelian science, Platonic spirituality, and Stoic ethics. What is Stoicism? Stoicism is the religion philosophy in which you internalize Socrates so you can replace that useless rumination in your head with Socratic dialogos, which is a wonderful thing to do, by the way. Practicing Stoicism does that. We get a light version of that in cognitive behavioral therapy. Directly comes from Stoicism, by the way.
- 6.68** OK, so what's the Aristotelian logic? Here's a bunch of things, and I group them together. Oh, those are cats. Here's a bunch of things. Oh, those are dogs. Here's a bunch of things. Those are snakes. Here's a bunch of things. These are lizards. These are mammals. This is so familiar to you, you forget that somebody came up with this. Now,

it's implicit in a lot of thinking. It's a cross-cultural universal. Every culture does this. What they put in in the categories is different, but we all do this. This is why Aristotle was brilliant. This is how he got to be Aristotle.

- 6.69** Reptiles. Then you notice, oh, but there's other things that I can do the same progression up. I have insects and I have fish. Then all of these come together in animals. But over here, there's all the plants. Then animal living things. Non-living things. Oh, my gosh, that's all over there, too. We have this. Do you see it? We move up and down this to make sense of things. We move up and down this to make sense of things. That's Aristotle.
- 6.70** Notice what's happening. Logos gathers the many into one, and it does this in a recursive, layered manner. The many are being gathered into one, and then these many are being gathered into one, and then these many are being gathered into one. In fact, one of the original meanings of logos is to gather things together so they belong together. Is that OK? Now, here's the question the Neoplatonist, like Plotinus, asks. "What's at the top? What does it max out in?" That's a good question, isn't it?
- 6.71** Well, you've got, well, there's all the living things, and then there's all the things, and then behind all the things, there's being itself. You realize that you're being lifted towards ultimate reality. You notice what Plotinus sees. Plotinus sees, he considered the founder of Neoplatonism. He says, "That's kind of a little bit like also coming out of the cave and looking at the sun." You can't really look at the sun. OK, so we're getting this model that's developing there. We've got this Aristotelian science, this taxonomic science. So much of our science depends on this. It's like habit to us now when we're doing science.
- 6.72** What would be at the very top? It couldn't be anything, any one thing. That's called a category mistake. See, the system is organizing the things. People ask you, "Give me examples of cars," and you say a Cadillac, a Ford, a Mustang. Oh, and by the way, a car. You go, no, you've mistaken. Car is a higher category. It's not a member of that category. That's called a category mistake. At the top of it, you don't have a thing because what is making the whole system work? It's the power of logos. It's the power of one-ing. But it's not a power like a potential. It's a power that's always in action. It's completely actual and completely potential at the same time.
- 6.73** Your brain's going, "What? It's got to be one or the other." Aristotle. Well, Plotinus says, "But what metaxu, what holds the actual and the possible together?" That has to be even more real. At the top is this source of one-ing that's the power action beyond the power action, and it's called the One. But the One is not—and Plotinus says this again and again—it's not a one, like this is one thing. It's not the numerical one. It is the One of one-ing, that's flowing up and down. It's not a thing. The system of relations is based on a principle of one-ing, and the principle of one-ing is not any member in the system.

- 6.74** You have the system of colors, yes? That system of colors does not have a color. It's not like there's red, there's yellow, there's the system of colors, which is itself a color. That's a category mistake. Do you understand? It's not a thing. It's a no-thing. It is a no-thing. But it is not nothing. You have the One, and it's emanating down into all the individual things. Because to be something is to be integrated, to be one. But of course, the later Neoplatonists realize, that purely top-down model doesn't work because it's not only the One coming down, all the things are being drawn together, self-organizing, and emerging upwards towards greater and greater self-organizing systems. Yes?
- 6.75** There's also emergence going up. What is it coming from? It's also coming from a different version of the same power of one-ing. Down here is the One. These two are non-logically identical. They're not logically identical because I can't describe them in a way that will use the same propositions. But they're one, because there can't be two of them, because the principle of one-ing can't be based in two things, because I need a one to hold the two together. The One is above, below, through. I can only gesture this. This, all at once, is the One.
- 6.76** The idea is, this is how reality is actually laid out. This is what's going on in being. It's also what's going on in being known. The reason why this works in science, it allows me for things to be known, is because that's the way being is. You've seen this before. Top-down, bottom-up, completely interpenetrating. What is this? This is the structural process. This is the grammar of cognition itself. Not the content. This is the principles by which your mind works. The bottom-up, top-down, completely interpenetrating. Then Neoplatonists say, "Oh, the grammar of reality and the grammar of the mind are the same."
- 6.77** Now, notice something. The grammar of all of my sentences is the same. It doesn't mean all my sentences are the same. What's going on in my mind and what's going on in the world aren't the same things, but the grammar of my mind, how it works, and the grammar of the world are both at one with each other. They are sharing, or let's use the Greek word, participating, in the same principles. This is deep, deep participatory knowing, because ultimately, you don't just know being, you participate in it. And your deepest knowing is that participation.
- 6.78** This gives you—when you can realize this at one minute, it gives you tremendous connectedness, meaning in life. It affords profound anagoge. In fact, what you want to do is you want to take this Aristotelian model and you want to say, I can do Platonic anagogic practices to realize this. I can contemplate this. I can contemplate this. I can contemplate the flow between them. I can do this in contemplative anagogic practices. This is what Neoplatonism developed. Platonic spirituality says we can use contemplative practices to anagogically enact shared fundamental grammar of mind and reality, to participate in it as profoundly as we can, to be deeply, deeply connected, to experience deep meaning in life, to afford profound anagoge.

- 6.79** Wisdom and virtue experience the deepest reciprocal opening, profound love. All of this is afforded. That's the Platonic spirituality. Then you have, "OK, I have all these contemplative practices, but I have to actually cultivate virtue." You bring in the Stoicism. You say, well, you know what I do? I internalize Socrates, the dialogical, the logos, all of that stuff. Then I organize that and integrate that with my contemplative Platonic practices. They called this *theoria*. That's where we get our word theory from, but it's not about theory. It's about seeing things in a new way, seeing deeper into reality.
- 6.80** You've got Aristotelian science, Platonic spirituality, and Stoic ethics. That's Neoplatonism. What is running through all of this is everything we've been talking about when we've been talking about beauty. Your experience of beauty is a way of participating in that deep shared grammar that deeply connects you to what is most real, according to this argument, and most affords you your realization of your humanity and your virtue and your wisdom and your meaning. That's your crash course on Neoplatonism. Of course, we're now halfway into Sammon's argument, and we're going to pick that up in lecture seven. So, time for questions.
- 6.81** Hi. Where does discernment fits in the four Ps of knowing?
- 6.82** Discernment. You have to remember, there's also relationships between the kinds of knowing. Discernment is basically a noetic function. You're noticing things in the right way, and then you can plug that into either your skills, your *techne*, or into your beliefs. It's discernment.
- 6.83** Hello.
- 6.84** Hi.
- 6.85** I'm trying to word this. OK. At some point, you said that the anagoge provides or fulfills our two basic meta-desires like peace and in touch with reality. Then that peace, that avoiding the cognitive dissonance is that satisfaction that we get. Then that had me thinking earlier, in relation to beauty and art, that if satisfaction is intrinsically or the same can be used the same as pleasure, also assuming that is everything we find beautiful always going to provide pleasure? Is there a moment where that doesn't happen? Because you can assume also talking about the smooth and pornography, that can technically provide pleasure, but it's not.
- 6.86** No, no, no. This is a good question. Excellent question. It's good to see you again. The problem with the word pleasure, it's equivocal. Do you know what equivocation is? Equivocation is when you use two different meanings of the same term and you engage in fallacious reasoning. Here, let's do one, just to be clear about what equivocation is, then we'll come back to the equivocation of pleasure. OK, so nothing is better than long life and happiness. A peanut butter and jelly sandwich is better than nothing. Therefore, peanut butter and jelly sandwich is better than long life and happiness, so

you should eat one and kill yourself. It's a bad argument because I'm trading on two different meanings of the word nothing.

- 6.87** That's equivocation. You don't want to equivocate. The problem about pleasure is we can mean something that gives us satisfaction, and satisfaction can mean meaning. Or we can mean something like what is measured in psychology, which is called subjective well-being, when we feel good inside. That can be a particularly acute sense of goodness, like in an orgasm, or it can just feel like, I'm liking my life right now. Now, those aren't the same. Meaning in life and that sense of inner yum— it's hard to put a word on it—can pull apart.
- 6.88** The prototypical example is having a child. When you have a child, all the things that cause subjective well-being go down. Your finances go down, you're sick all the time, you're not getting enough sleep. For reasons you can't completely understand, you're always wet. The person who claimed to be your greatest partner is angry at you, and you're angry at them, and you don't know why. There's an alarm going off all the time. It's Darwinian design to just freak you out. This is the baby crying. You go, it's a disaster in terms of pleasure in that sense.
- 6.89** But why do people do it? Because you know what goes up? Meaning in life. They feel connected to something that's real, that has an existence beyond them, that they're deeply connected, et cetera, et cetera, all the stuff we've talked about. We have to be very careful. Should a work of art always cause us pleasure in that, mmm, yum? That's the smooth. If you look at the ancient world, it very often doesn't do that. Beauty is often described as shocking. It wakes you up, it awakens you.
- 6.90** It's like when you have a kid and you wake up to, oh, my god. In fact, if they don't say this, they're lying. You get about three months in and you go, "What have I done? I've destroyed my life." Then the child smiles at you—love beauty—and you go [sigh] and you're in. I think art, according to this ancient model, or let's put art aside, beauty, according to this ancient model, a work of art that we consider beautiful isn't necessarily pleasurable. But the argument is, it should be giving you some deep connectedness to your humanity, to what's real, to all of this stuff we've been talking about. I've been arguing that goes into meaning in life in a very powerful way.
- 6.91** When you were describing the One, immediately, I assumed you were going to say God. I was wondering if this description is almost like a secular replacement of the word God, and if a religious interpretation would equate to roughly the same thing.
- 6.92** Yeah. Let's answer that because Neoplatonism is off—it's like Buddhism. It's a philosophy religion. It's like Stoicism, which is a philosophy religion, or Daoism. Plotinus will sometimes call the One God. He'll use that phrase. But he doesn't mean a God like the gods. This is really, really tricky because we tend to think of God, even in the Abrahamic tradition, as a super thing, a being. The point is, no being can be the One. Does that make sense? But people like Augustine, Dionysus, and Aquinas argue, "No,

no, the One is God. You have to properly understand God." One of the reasons why Dionysus calls God beauty is to try and awaken people to this other way of understanding God.

- 6.93** Now, do you have to call it God, or do you have to map it into the Abrahamic God? I don't think so. I mean, there's a huge battle that goes on actually for a while between the Neoplatonists and the Christians. The Neoplatonists lose, and then the Christians absorb Neoplatonism into Christianity. This is a really interesting question. Here's how I can push on it a little bit more. So, I've got to answer this a little bit at length because of God. Here it is. God, good. One of the claims of Neoplatonism is that the one that they're talking about is identical to the thing that's at the top of the cave, the cave, the sun. Plato calls it, says the sun is "the good." We'll come back next time about why is that good? Why is that goodness?
- 6.94** Here's the proposal of the Neoplatonism. The one is also the good. When you integrate goodness, the word God actually comes from good. One, you get the notion of God. But in order to integrate that fundamental truth and that fundamental goodness together, what glues truth and goodness together? We've already talked about it. It's beauty. Beauty. God has to also be profoundly beauty as well as the truth, as well as the good. Now, whether or not that maps on to what people mean by God, I don't know. Could you have a secular version of it? Of course you can. You were just doing it.
- 6.95** But remember, you can't just have this propositionally. You have to do the Platonic anagoge. You have to do the Stoic cultivation of virtue. You have to build this entire ecology of practices, and you can't do it by yourself. No monologue. You have to do it with other people. As soon as you put all this in, the line between secular and religion starts to really blur, and you can't tell, is this secular or religious anymore? That's a good thing. I would argue that's a good thing. How's that?
- 6.96** Great. Thanks.
- 6.97** By the way, we've got to the place where God is beauty, which seemed so strange when the course began.
- 6.98** When it comes to identifying what beauty is, why are we more concerned with the process rather than finding the essence?
- 6.99** Where?
- 6.100** Or why are we more concerned with the process?
- 6.101** Because this is how you find the essence of something. You find all the instances that have it, and you find what they have in common. You can't do that with beautiful things. That was part of the argument I made. If you look at beautiful things, it's variable, it's changing, and it's not intrinsic to the thing. It's like insight, it's like relevance. You can't find it in the things. Again, other than them being relevant, what do all the things you find relevant have in common? Nothing. Does that mean it's just

subjective? No. But it's transjective. In order to do that, you have to look at the process and the universals in the process that set up the universal relation. Did that answer your question?

6.102 Yeah, that's good.

6.103 We talked about the higher way of knowing, and the four Ps, the propositional and the non-propositional. What about the subconscious way of thinking and seeing beauty? Do you think that this is a different process of beauty being quintessential to our humanity?

6.104 This is a good question. Of course, we have to be careful. We don't really have the notion of the unconscious in the ancient world. There's analogues to it in Plotinus, which is really foresightful. And Freud got a lot from Neoplatonism, and Jung, Neoplatonism, Jung and gnosticism, deeply interwoven together. Here's what I wanted to say. I think there are unconscious versions or aspects to all four kinds of knowing. There is a lot of unconscious processing that's going in propositional knowing. Can any of you tell me, do any of you have introspective access of how you are turning the noises that are coming out of my face hole into propositions? Do you know that? You don't. It's unconscious. Chomsky has done all that work.

6.105 What about techne? OK, hold up your finger. Do it. You know how to bend your finger? Bend your finger. What are you doing to bend your finger? It's unconscious. But noesis is about consciousness. Yes, it is. I want you to introspect and tell me how your consciousness arises. Please do it. You don't know. OK. This is a famous Buddhist move or a famous David Hume move. Pick your poison. You have a self, right? Introspect and find me. Point to the experience inside of yourself. Oh, that's myself. What did the Buddha say? Well, you won't find yourself. You'll find a memory, you'll find an image, you'll find an itch, you'll find a desire, but you won't find the self.

6.106 There's an unconscious aspect to participatory knowing. In fact, it's unconscious in this way. I would say that many organisms, like a paramecium, have unconscious participatory knowing. The paramecium is not just like a fire. It's not just self-organizing. Look, a paramecium is an autopoietic thing. It's a living thing. This is part of 4E cog sci. It is self-organized to seek out the conditions that will preserve its existence. There is a way in which it—the language here is—there's a way in which it knows that that molecule is food and knows that that molecule is poison and moves accordingly in a way that is relevant to it.

6.107 Does the paramecium have consciousness? No. So, what you might be then asking is, but what's the relationship between the conscious and the unconscious? I've given you an answer to that. That's the imaginal. One of the things the imaginal does is it bridges the top and the bottom and the in and the out. That was, of course, one of Corbin's points, and that's why he was in such deep dialogue with Jung. The imaginal, especially

when it becomes symbolic, reaches between, is metaxu, the unconscious and consciousness. That's my answer.

- 6.108** To me, it wasn't very clear the difference between the perspectival knowledge and participatory. More specifically, how is the participation not a perspective, the sense of being, of coupling in the self?
- 6.109** It's not a perspective in that perspective does require attention and awareness and consciousness. Remember, there's an unconscious aspect to the emergence of consciousness. You don't know how. But in order to have a perspective, you have to be paying attention and being aware in a certain way. Let me show you the difference. You participate in physics, biology, evolution, gravity. You're participating in all of those things, yes? They're shaping you and what's around you and culture, so that this—what is this? It's a floor, and you can walk on it. You don't have to be noticing that for that fittedness to be there. It's an affordance.
- 6.110** Now, what the perspectival knowing does, as of all the affordances that are available to you, people call this the affordance landscape, you make some of them salient. Salient is when relevance becomes conscious. You make it salient and you go, oh, and I noticed—you're not noticing the walkability of the floor right now because you don't need to solve a problem. But now I need to get over there. Oh, now I notice that affordance, and it becomes salient to me. It goes from being just merely relevant to being something in my consciousness, in my working memory, in my attention. Now I have a perspective that's opened up.
- 6.111** So, like in the example of the breakfast?
- 6.112** That's episodic memory. What are you doing? You're remembering what you were noticing, what you were paying attention to. What was underneath that is there had to be certain affordances. Was your food consumable? Were you especially aware of that? No, you weren't. It was there, and maybe very dimly, but there was a lot that went into making your food a meal. In fact, making that stuff a meal. It's very much in the background. All you remember in episodic memory is what was foregrounded by your perspective. Did that help? Good.
- 6.113** This is hard stuff because you know what we don't do very well in our culture? That's part of the argument. We don't develop a lot of propositions about the non-propositional because we're subject to propositional tyranny. We reduced all of logos to logic, and we reduced all of knowing to propositional knowing. Then we lost the possibility of deep reason, deep meaning, and deep beauty. Look, if the Neoplatonists are right, beauty is the participatory knowing of God. I mean, I hesitate even to say that sentence. I'm depending on the fact that we built all of this. We had to build this really powerful, I think, structure in order to make sense of what they're talking about.
- 6.114** It tells you how far we have fallen from where they were. Now, I'm not a nostalgic person. Put on my gravestone, "Neither nostalgia nor utopia." That's like also neither

right nor left. Because nostalgia is horrible. It leads to people being killed. And utopias have always been a bad idea. They kill people on huge numbers. I'm not nostalgic and I'm not utopic because it gives up the finite transcendence. But I do think we can notice that there's something we have lost. This is why I liked your question so much. What's your name again?

6.115 Parisa.

6.116 Parisa? That's a very pretty name. That's why I liked your question so much because it's like, we don't want to just go back. We can't become Neoplatonists. We can't go back to the Middle Ages. Can I bring this into secularity? Can I bring this into modernity? Can I use it to confront postmodernity, which we'll do when we talk about Schindler? Those are the important questions. This isn't about nostalgia. It's about what can I learn, or let's use another word, what can I exapt from all of this and repurpose for now? That's the key question. We're done.

Lecture 7: Beauty and Transcendence

At a glance — Beauty and transcendence, via Sonia Sedivy's reflections.

- 7.1 The last time we talked about the work that Sonia Sedivy was doing and her reflections on beauty and the way she was making use of Kant and Wittgenstein. We noted that Kant was facing this problem that beauty, and then I'll keep doing these little parentheses, these are Vervaeke things I'm saying, beauty, like relevance, does not seem to be objective, but beauty, like relevance, does not seem to be the same as a purely subjective preference.
- 7.2 Then Kant makes a similar move as I've made for relevance, and other people have made for insight. We talked about that, about don't look for a universal essence in all of the beautiful objects, but you look for a universal process by which you could understand whenever people are experiencing beauty. That would mean beauty is ultimately a transjective relation, that is between an objective process within and an objective process without.
- 7.3 We move to Kant then. We got, OK, great move. Stop trying to find the essence of beautiful things. Look at what's the essence of the process of realizing beauty. Kant then says, OK, well, beauty is the free play between the imagination and the understanding. I argued that's the imaginal. At least I would make a good case for that. It makes us aware of this. Beauty allows us to stand back and become aware of, unlike our normal everyday cognition, it allows us to stand back and become aware of the fact that the tremendous plenitude power of perception can be subsumed by the power of conception at the heart of cognition.
- 7.4 Beauty is, in a sense, this realized promise that reality is intelligible rather than horrific. This promise is universally experienced. You do not find a place where human beings don't experience beauty, and they don't experience this. We can use some of Scarry's language here in a life-giving, life-saving way. She, of course, as I mentioned, quotes Roger Scruton in his little tiny, wonderful little book, *Beauty: A Very Short Introduction*. Those little, very short introductions are generally quite good, by the way. A good place to start. Much better, I would say, than Wikipedia if you had to start somewhere.
- 7.5 But in beauty, the world comes home to us and us to the world, but from the being mode, not from the having mode. That's all about everything we've been talking about, this mutual fitting together, this coming home, this niche construction. There's feeling that the universe is ultimately a cosmic home for us, et cetera. Now, Vervaeke responded to this. Sorry, that's weird. I responded to this, that I disagreed with Kant's purely top-down model of this. I pointed to two things that actually exemplify the imaginal at work in the way that we're talking about here as domesticating—we'll use a better word in a few minutes—domesticating the perceptual for the sake of conception.

- 7.6 We took a look at gesture and conceptual metaphor, and it showed how every moment our cognition is dancing and doing poetry. Therefore, beauty is playing— beauty of the imaginal, even if we don't recognize it as such, is playing a central role in us being the kind of cognitive agents we are. I said, but if we look at gesture and conceptual metaphor, we look very carefully at the phenomena, we get a good evidence that it's neither a purely top-down nor a purely bottom-up measure.
- 7.7 Then we took a look at the work of Michael Anderson, making use of other work by Barbara Tversky, and a lot of people, by the way, in 4E cog sci, now that you know what that is. This notion that our cognition is exaptive, that what we're doing in cognition is we're repurposing things drawn from the sensorimotor domain and exapting them into higher, more abstract thought.
- 7.8 The idea here is that beauty might be new or emergent in that it might be an imaginal reexaptation. It might be like, when somebody's giving us a beautiful metaphor, we're going back down to the sensorimotor and reexapting it up in a new way and getting a new emergent understanding of—and we took a look at a couple of them—justice as balance, for example. I think if we pay very careful attention to a lot of current 4E cog sci, we can give a better interpretation than either Kant's purely top-down or Lakoff and Johnson's purely bottom-up. That's usually the—science usually keeps coming back to that conclusion, I would argue.
- 7.9 Now, Sedivy doesn't do that strategy. She uses the strategy of bringing in Wittgenstein to criticize Kant's idealism, which is a purely top-down, totally mind-generated position. What she does is that Kant's idea about rules actually points us towards something, that propositional inferential use of rules is actually dependent on knowing how to apply the rules. I added knowing how to select which rules, knowing how to modify the rule. The propositional knowing that was dependent on the procedural knowing how. The ability to form beliefs is dependent on your skills.
- 7.10 That got us, opened the door to non-propositional knowing, which, of course, immediately gets us into this topic we've been wrestling with, which is the ineffable, which is an ongoing theme, the ineffable, but it's also an excess of intelligibility. It's not ineffable because it's a blank. It's ineffable because it's so filled with the possibilities of intelligibility. With this introduction of non-propositional knowing, we were able to move into Hyland and go directly into the work he does on Plato.
- 7.11 What we've got is, first of all, the idea that beauty is between dianoia and noesis. Then we did this Platonic notion of metaxu, which then kept going throughout the lecture. For Plato, metaxu is a really crucial idea. I presented to you the proposal that the argument I've made for transjectivity is that transjectivity is a species of it, the way in which we are metaxu. In order to go deeper into the transjectivity and non-propositional knowing, we took a look very quickly at what 4E cog sci is, cognitive science.

- 7.12** Then through that, with the help of other people like my good friends, Dan Chiappe and Christopher Mastropietro, drew out the 4Ps of knowing, as a way of trying to be more explicit and articulate about non-propositional knowing. Now, of course, we started with dianoia, which is the propositional knowing. Each one has its own memory. Each one has its own results, beliefs or skills, and each one has its different sense of realness, different ways in which it's true.
- 7.13** We did dianoia, which is propositional; techne, which is that procedural knowing; and then noesis, which is perspectival knowing; and then gnosis, which is participatory. All the ones other than propositional knowing, of course, are non-propositional. We saw that there was a dependency relation. The propositional depends on the procedural, which depends on the perspectival, which depends on the participatory. That's why, ultimately, this is how it connects back to the 4 Es. You're ultimately participating in your body and you're participating in the way your embodiment is in the world, all of that sort of thing that come out in the 4 Es.
- 7.14** Why is the non-propositional so important to Plato? Because the non-propositional plays a deeply crucial role in virtue. Virtue cannot be captured by beliefs or the application of rules. You need skills, you need perspectives, and you need traits of character, the ways in which you've shaped your identity. You need all of this coordinated in order to engage in the actualization of virtue. Of course, what Plato wants is he doesn't want it just in this situation. He wants that it will transfer broadly to many different domains in your life, and it will affect your psyche in a profound way.
- 7.15** In order to pick that up, we took a look at two of Plato's most famous accounts. The one is the cave from the Republic, and we talked about anagoge and reciprocal opening, and how beauty is the affordance of anagoge, the affordance of reciprocal opening. That reciprocal opening gives us a deep sense of fulfillment. It's a powerful touchstone that we are in contact with what is most real about us and what is most real about the world. Then we took a look at how anagoge shows up in the Symposium. There, the anagoge is specifically powered by the relationship between love and beauty.
- 7.16** Why love? Because reciprocal opening is love. The opposite, reciprocal narrowing is addiction. That's why they look somewhat like each other from the outside because they have the reciprocal thing going on. But if you pay very careful attention, they're radically opposite to each other. In fact, most addicts don't love what they're addicted to. They hate it.
- 7.17** Love and beauty. I want to talk about the fact that love is metaxu. I want to pause a little bit on the review and unpack a little bit here because I need that for what we're going to do. It's a review-plus right now. I'll tell you when we move to the new material, but it's a little bit review-plus. This is to talk a little bit more about love. Of course, this is a wickedly dangerous thing to do because all we typically do is, we either talk dismissively about love or we talk in empty platitudes. Of course, part of what's also

been going on in this whole argument, and Plato has continued to play a crucial role in this, is rehabilitation.

- 7.18** First of all, love is not a feeling. First of all, feelings aren't emotions. You can have a feeling, and it can be the part of many different kinds of emotions. A feeling is a series of sensations in your body in some way. I still love my partner when I'm asleep. I've got no feelings going on, but I still love her. When you say yeah, OK, I get that. Love is an emotion. No, it's not. You see, because I love her, that sometimes makes me sad when I'm not with her. Sometimes makes me happy when I'm with her. Sometimes makes me angry if I think somebody's threatening her.
- 7.19** Do you see? Love isn't an emotion. It is something that brings me into many different emotions according to many different situations. Love is an existential mode. It is fundamentally metaxu. It is the way the agent and the arena are bound together. Now, in love, typically what you're doing, although it can be to something other than a person, is you bind yourself to another person. We talked about that. You get mutual reciprocal opening between two people at the level of participatory knowing. That's love. It's an existential mode.
- 7.20** That's why the Christian Neoplatonists argued that love is actually a virtue. That's the best way of understanding what love is. This is why I propose to you that loving wisely is maybe the single best thing you should strive for if you want your life to be good. We talked about the difference between pleasure and meaning in life around just exactly that issue because you asked an excellent question about that. I am very privileged and lucky to have very good students. A teacher is very much dependent on the quality of their student.
- 7.21** What more did we learn about love? Now, back to the review. Well, we learned that love exemplifies, doesn't speak of, it exemplifies. It demonstrates by participating in our, the deep nature of our humanity. Love is metaxu, and love binds the finite to the transcendent. That is part of our deep humanity. We talked about Drew Hyland's work, again based on Plato, that we have to hold together, tonos, our finitude and our transcendence.
- 7.22** We're like the animals. We're finite. But if we overemphasize that, we can fall into bestiality, despair, servitude. We also can be subject to fate. We need compassion from other people. I argue that's what the left, when it's working properly, should be doing. But we are also called to transcendence, to nobility, to the cultivation of virtue. But if we have just that, we can fall prey to hubris, and we can become tyrannical. We have to hold the best of these together because when they're held together, they mutually correct and counterbalance each other, the left and the right, the finite and the transcendent.
- 7.23** What we get is, we get, there's a deep relationship, therefore, between love and the deep remembrance of and remembering by participating in our finite transcendence.

But that binding of finitude and transcendence together is what beauty is. We see this deep relationship now. Why? When you love something, it becomes beautiful, and when something is beautiful, you come to love it. They're bound together.

7.24 All of this helps us to deeply remember and identify with our humanity. This sounds like a stupid thing to say, and I'm subject as much to the criticism in it as anybody else. Remembering that you're human is a really hard thing to do. We like to default to either one of these poles. I'm a God. I'm just an animal. We do this. Holding the two together so that there's a tonos, so they're mutually correcting each other, is what Plato is trying to call us to. He's saying the love-beauty thing, especially when it's within anagoge, can help us cultivate that tonos deeply.

7.25 So beauty is the affordance of anagoge that realizes our metaxu nature. In beauty and love, we have dianoia, metaxu, noesis, and that also helps keep us from nihilism. Dialogos. We're going to move into the logos in just a second. But we got the idea that dianoia on its own can lead to nihilism, and noesis on its own can lead to nihilism. But if we have the two working together, we avoid nihilism. At least that's Stanley Rosen's argument.

7.26 So Hyland picks up this topic of logos, reason, and he tells us he's not talking about reason as we talk about it now, the way it was reduced in the hands of Descartes and people thereafter, like Kant, where what we're talking about is logic, and we're talking about monologic, logic that is done monologically. Instead, we go back to the notion of logos, which has to do with logic, it does, but it has to do with study. It has to do, I forgot this last time, logos also means word or speech. "En arche en o logos," in the beginning was the word, as the gospel of John begins. They're saying that, John is saying that Jesus is the logos, the ultimate logos of ultimate reality.

7.27 Logos is also organizing principle. That becomes clear when you hear the Latin translation of logos, which is ratio, which is part of our word rationality. We're talking about logos, gathering things together so they belong together, so that we can track the truth in them, so we can study them, so we can put them into speech, so that we can have things organized and intelligible. Logos is this much more encompassing notion, and it takes in much more of what we mean by reason. We should take in much more because we should not have just a propositional notion of what reason is.

7.28 We should include all the kinds of knowing and give up on propositional tyranny because the non-propositional kinds of knowing are carrying a lot of the burden of actually giving us meaning in life and connecting us to reality, to ourselves, to each other, and to the world. Of course, Hyland, like we've seen other people doing, says that logos is bounded on both sides by the non-propositional because of the suchness and the moreness. Beauty helps us remember our humanity, makes the space, the place, for logos, bridges between dianoia and noesis, and powers anagoge. What a great job description for beauty. That's a great thing to be doing. That's why beauty should be deserving of reverence.

- 7.29 Now, that set us up to move to our next important thinker, Brendan Thomas Sammon. He's deeply influenced by William Desmond, *Being in the Between*. Desmond's whole philosophy is about reprioritizing metaxu, that our primary experience, our fundamental grounding experience of being, is metaxu. It is both eminently familiar to us and prominently mysterious to us at the same time. We need training in metaxu if we are going to come to a proper right relationship that realizes being. Of course, remember in anagoge, that's one of our two meta-desires. We want inner peace, but we want that inner peace to be because we are connected to what is most real.
- 7.30 I then moved into the area that caused me the most terror, which is, in order to explain Sammon's work, I was going to give you a crash course in Neoplatonism, which I talked to some of you after that, and it seems to have worked. So I'll thank whatever gods were helpful in that situation. It's a very challenging, daunting thing to do. I consider myself a Zen Neoplatonist. You'll see why Zen in a bit. Neoplatonism is not something that you can easily capture. It is profound, but we need to understand it because all these people that Sammon is talking about that we have been alluding to, like Augustine and Dionysus and Aquinas, are all deeply, deeply Christian Neoplatonists.
- 7.31 OK, so what did we do? We started with the idea that Neoplatonism was a living system and a living integration of Platonic spirituality, Aristotelian science, and Stoic ethics. We started with the Aristotelian science, and we got the idea that, well, what is that? Remember, we did the hierarchy, things that are mammals, and then reptiles and fishes and insects, and we get animals. Over here, we've got other things, plants. Remember, and we got this whole hierarchy and understanding and making sense, this is the Aristotelian model, is moving up and down this hierarchy. That's why taxonomy is at the core of any science. It's so automatic for us that we forget how profound that is.
- 7.32 But then we ask the question, well, what's at the top of that hierarchy? This is Plotinus' question. What's at the top is not a thing, because that would be a category mistake. Whatever it is that's organizing all of the things at all of the levels can't itself be a thing or a level. That's a category mistake. Do you remember that? What is it? Well, it's a non-thing. What's it doing? Well, our language fails here because, see, language is always separating. It's the subject and the predicate of a proposition, and it always is missing what's the metaxu that's holding them together.
- 7.33 But the idea was, OK, what are we talking about throughout all of this is one-ing. I said it's the power, but a power in action because it's deeper than our division between actuality and potentiality, because it holds actuality and potentiality together so that they belong together, they fit together. I almost want to hyphenate it. It's one-ing is a power in action. This is emanating in the Plotinus. It's emanating downward. That one-ing is making, each level is the one-ing being broken up into different, determinate, more specific ones.
- 7.34 Now, Plotinus had a notion of the return, but he tended to emphasize the emanation. Later Neoplatonists, Proclus, or Eriugena, or Eriugena, depending on how people

pronounce the name, emphasize, wait, wait. It's not just down, there's also emergence. Things self-organize and unify into greater and greater unities. You're made up of chemicals that have been integrated into cells, that have been integrated into organs, that have been integrated into a living thing, that integrates into a society, that integrates into a whole country, etc.

- 7.35** There's not only top-down emanation, there is bottom-up emergence. The One is not only at the very top, it's also at the fundamental bottom. It is both the source of emanation and of emergence. This and this, even though they're not things, are non-logically identical because there can't be two of these because this is the principle of one-ing itself. It's a way in which those two things are one. Now, we dichotomize, and we'll talk more about this. We want to split it up. We want to have two worlds, the top and the bottom. But the later Neoplatonists, especially Iamblichus, was very critical of that move in Plotinus.
- 7.36** Now, what was the point I made? We've seen that before, and we've seen that that's the same grammar. Not the same vocabulary—it's the same grammar as cognition, as mind. The grammar of being and the grammar of being known are the same. They're both participating in the same principles. We have a tremendous capacity to deeply participate, to be deeply at one. We get that in flow experiences. Remember? We feel deeply at one. We're not doing something illusory because we're actually working at our best and saying, "This is the best experience I can have."
- 7.37** We get deep connectedness, deep meaning in life. That's the Aristotelian science, revised by the Neoplatonists, and then we bring in the Platonic spirituality. Well, I can use contemplative, not consumptive. I can use contemplative practices to anagogically realize this. I'm participating in it, but instead of it being an unconscious participation, I can bring it into noesis and dianoia. I can do contemplative practices that help me anagogically realize this. Beauty is the imaginal affordance of that contemplative realization. It's what draws you and powers you and does all the things we've talked about in beauty in order to do good anagoge.
- 7.38** Then, of course, that, what is realized in this contemplative anagoge, has to be taken into virtue. How do we do that? Well, that's the Stoic ethics. Stoicism is the religion philosophy of internalizing Socrates. So you transform that inner egoic-centric rumination into an ontocentric Socratic dialogos. That's how all of the three parts of Neoplatonism come together. The Aristotelian science, the Platonic spirituality of anagoge, and the Socratic Stoic cultivation of virtue. This is why Neoplatonism offered a comprehensive, integrated spiritual framework for the ancient world.
- 7.39** That's where we got to. We had some very good questions, totally appropriate questions about, "Is this God?" I gave a complex answer that amounts to, sort of. It depends. If you mean God as the way many people think of God as a super thing, as a super person, then no, because remember, the One can't be a thing. But if, like Dionysus and Augustine— more Dionysus, I would say on this—you say, well, no, what

we have to do is we have to modify what we mean by God. We mean the God who is beauty, as Sammon's book is entitled, then we can call it God.

- 7.40 I want to start with that since it was brought up, God. I had to answer the question, and it was totally appropriate. Now I want to answer the question, and I want to keep answering it in a way that is metaxu, between religion and secularity, being secular, because your question, as I said, was so pertinent and bang on, because as we'll see, this is the question that's at the core of what I call the meaning crisis. What could we mean by God? Well, I take it we mean something like, sorry, an entity. Remember, I use entity and it doesn't mean thing. An entity that is superlatively sacred. There's nothing more sacred than God. Is that OK?
- 7.41 Most people don't find that a problem. That's not what I mean by God. Typically, that's what they mean. We can ask, what do we mean by sacredness? Remember, that's one of the properties of beauty. It makes us aware of sacredness. We're staying on track here. What do we mean when we say something is sacred? I think the work of a fellow Canadian, oh Canada, Schellenberg, is very, very helpful. He describes himself as an atheist, but his atheism is actually not traditional atheism. It's not the atheism, for example, of Christopher Hitchens or Sam Harris. It's a different kind of atheism.
- 7.42 It's an atheism, actually, I would say his position is beyond atheism and theism. A position I advocate for, non-theism. OK, but let's go back to it. He proposes that the sacred is the triple transcendent. Now, he always means the transcendent in this flowing relationship with the imminent. So triple transcendent in most ways. And notice how this should land, I hope, because I've done this with people, with many people's ideas about what they mean by God.
- 7.43 First, transcendence. We're talking about what is ultimately real. Remember, real is a comparative. There has to be an ultimate real, and we can't have multiple ultimate reals because what binds them all together? This is a classic argument by Plotinus and Spinoza. And so, is the One ultimately real? You bet you. That's its job, on its job description. You, you be ultimate reality. Got it. Now, what else do we need? Well, we need two more.
- 7.44 We need that the sacred isn't just ultimate reality. The sacred is the affordance of ultimate, the deepest, most powerful transformation we can go through. It is that in terms of which we can realize enlightenment or salvation or wisdom, et cetera. That's part of the job. It has to be not only ultimately real, it has to be ultimately transformative. Of course, we picked up on that with beauty being life-giving and life-saving. What's the third one? This is the one we've touched on and we're going to push on it again today. The sacred has to be not only ultimately real, ultimate reality, and ultimately transformative. It has to be that which gives us—it's ultimately normative. Normative means telling you what the good is.

- 7.45 It should be that which is the ultimate guide for your life, if I can put it that way. I mean normative guide. I don't mean guiding you to when you're going to the convenience store. It should be the ultimate guide for wisdom, virtue, meaning in life. Now, when I talk to people who are not theists, like Buddhists, they're happy with this. "Yeah, that's what I think sunyata is. I think it's ultimately real. I think if you're in a relationship to it, enlightenment, and this is the guiding, it guides my whole life because I'm a Buddhist." But when I talk to people from the Abrahamic religion, they go, "Yeah, that's what God is. God is ultimately real. My relationship to God is what really saves me and transforms me, and God is the ultimate guide of my life."
- 7.46 Now, you may think, oh, that's problematic. No. In some contexts, it is, like if we want to set up flags and identities. But if we're trying to get a conception that can bridge across many people's claims of sacredness, we need something like this. Now, I think it's pretty clear that the One is this and that it's this. We've got some sense that, via beauty, it is preparing us for justice and good and truth. Yes? We're going to come back to this goodness question. If, by God, you mean the superlatively sacred, and by the superlatively sacred, you mean the triple transcendent, then in that way, not thinking of the entity God as a thing, then you could say the One is God. If that is OK. But you could equally say that the One is sunyata, the One is the Dao, equally. That's the point I'm making.
- 7.47 All right, let's now move back to the specific line of argument in Sammon. Sammon, I don't know how he pronounces his name. I've never heard him speak. I've never actually seen a video of him or anything. We're going back to the intimacy between logos and beauty. We laid all of this out because it makes clear why there's an intimate relationship between logos and beauty. Now, the problem that's faced in the ancient world, and that we share, and I've been already poking at it, is that beauty is both spiritual, it's parts of the intelligible realm, it emanates from above, and beauty is also deeply physical and visible, rather than intelligible, and it emerges from beneath.
- 7.48 OK, so we—beauty is our direct participatory experience of the One, above, below, between, through. And yet when we try to think about it, we get into this dichotomy, and we did it, too. There's the above, the spiritual, the intelligible, only known with the mind, and there's the lower, the physical, the perceptual, emerging from below. Now, the Greeks are in the middle of the Axial revolution, and they tended, as many, as many cultures that are going through the Axial revolution did, for reasons I can't get into right now. If you want to get a deeper argument for that, take a look at my series on Awakening From the Meaning Crisis.
- 7.49 But what they did is, they lost the polarity that was there, and they emphasized the poles. They emphasized the upper world and the lower world. They typically ran into understanding this with what I've called a two-worlds mythology. There are two worlds. There is this world, and then there is the really real world above. The problem with beauty is it seems to belong to both worlds, but these worlds are very different,

and how can they possibly go together? The metaxu nature of beauty, which allows it to function so profoundly, is actually what the Platonists find deeply problematic. I'm not clear that Plato had this problem, but a lot of the Platonists do. I think this problem is in Plotinus.

- 7.50** Now, we have this same problem. It reverberates in two ways. We have a two-worlds mythology as part of our cultural heritage. We have the natural world and the supernatural world. Science is about the natural world, religion is about the supernatural world. These two worlds are very different. They operate according to different principles. You get at this one through reason, you get at that one through faith, and you have all of these dichotomies, and they're running around all over the place. Then you also have a dichotomy within you because you have your soul, which is somehow very different from your body, and how do they possibly interact, and [noise].
- 7.51** It's all of this problem. One of the things we've done to try and alleviate that is we've said, well, what we'll do is, we'll throw away the supernatural world because it's not rational. But the problem is, that doesn't get back what you lost. Now, what do you have? Well, you just have this world in which you now have orphaned beauty and anagoge, transcendence, the plenitude. All of that's gone. That's not going to work either. This is what I mean, by the way. We can't simply go back to a two-worlds mythology, but we're stuck here.
- 7.52** Look, all of our ways of trying to understand things like beauty and wisdom and our capacity for self-transcendence and the fact that we're bound between finitude and transcendence, it's all sown into language that has developed, that's a two-worlds mythology. Then a lot of people in the secular world have said, "We don't have two worlds. We have a uni-verse. We have a universe." There's one way of talking. There's one thing. There's a universe.
- 7.53** That replaced, by the way, the older Greek notion of a cosmos. A universe is a single world. Cosmos, cosmetics, beautiful. Cosmos means a beautiful order in which beauty is a proper part of reality. We have the universe. Beauty becomes a merely subjective thing, and we have all the problems we've already talked about. Here's the issue we face. How do we deeply recover all of these things without the nostalgic error of trying to return to a two-worlds mythology? That's the crux that we're up against here.
- 7.54** Now, why do I bring this up? Because I bring this up because I have an ambivalent attitude towards Sammon's central thesis. So, Sammon argues that Christian Neoplatonism solved the problem that was posed by Greek philosophy, which is, how can beauty be simultaneously spiritual and physical? He says the way Christianity did this was through the incarnation of the logos, Jesus as the Christ. Now, I get this in one sense. I get, wow, yes, you're trying to say that God is, importantly, the metaxu and not just the above. I understand why he's saying that.

- 7.55** The issue I have with that is it still seems to be functioning—it's a solution that is still framed by the two-worlds mythology. And that makes me hesitant. It's not like Christianity is being particularly successful in many ways right now in translating that language into a language that secular people, who live in a universe and not a cosmos, would say, "Yeah, I get that." That's part of the culture wars that are going on right now. I'm not taking a side here on Christianity. Do you understand what I'm doing here? I'm not. I'm not allergic to Christianity, and neither am I just simply acquiescing in it.
- 7.56** It's also not clear to me that this is the only solution within Islam, Sufism. You get Sufism by basically mixing Neoplatonism with Islam. Within Sufism, the names of God serve the same function as the incarnation does in Christianity. How do we know which one of those is better? In a non-self-gratifying way, where do we stand such we can say, "Oh, look, it's clear that that one's better than that one." I don't know where to do that. This argument points to both of them.
- 7.57** Or even more provocatively, what about Zen? Zen argues, "You know what you should do? Instead of trying to solve the two worlds by getting some bridge between them, dissolve that entire mythology. Just dissolve it away." It's not that you've shown how one is reducible to the other because that's still working in the same grammar. You've basically shown that the grammar itself doesn't work. This is like some of the moves that Wittgenstein makes in philosophy. He tries to show that some questions shouldn't be answered; they should be dissolved, because the question has actually framed reality the wrong way.
- 7.58** I'll give you a classic example. What time is it on the sun? You think, oh. So you try to put, oh, yeah, there must be a time that it is on the sun. You think of a guy on the sun looking at his watch and then you realize, wait, time, the measurement of time is relative to where you are on the Earth. It doesn't make any sense, what time is it on the sun? It's no time. But that doesn't mean there's no time happening. What's north of the North Pole? Nothing. You don't understand what North Pole means.
- 7.59** Sometimes what we have to do is, we have to dissolve an inappropriate problem formation. Remember the nine-dot problem? Zen is like that. Smash your framing and make a new framing that doesn't follow the grammar of that framing. I think there's something really powerful to be learned by that. I think there's something very powerful to be learned about all of this by putting the two together. Zen Neoplatonism. Because that would be a really powerful way to unite the East and West, to address this fundamental issue of how can we recover beauty and wisdom and transcendence and a fulfilling meaning in life.
- 7.60** You say, "That's crazy. Wow, that's so weird, John. You're such a weird person." That's true, but it's irrelevant because there's a whole group of famous philosophers that have been doing that since the beginning of the 20th century. This is the Kyoto School. This is people like Nishida, Nishitani, Masao Abe, and others, D.T. Suzuki. This is not such a

crazy proposal. You could see people also reaching from the West towards Zen. That's been going on at least since Thomas Merton, probably before.

7.61 OK, why am I saying all of this? I'm saying all of this because I need to be fair to this author. His main thesis, at least in the book, is this proposal of the Christian incarnation being the solution to the problem of beauty. While I can see it as a solution, I'm not convinced that it is the solution. Now, to return to his argument, and somewhat ironically to me, given that we've just talked about the names of God in Islam and Sufism, he moved to Dionysus, and Dionysus' work on the divine names, the names of God. Then he proceeds to argue that the names are doing this job of bridging between the spiritual and the physical.

7.62 It's like, OK. But all of that now cleaned up, and I don't mean to be derogatory, I'm deeply impressed by this man's work, but once we got a way to connect it to everything we're doing, he then turns to what Dionysus considers to be one of the most important names of God. Now, this is the point. This is why I've been doing all this. Name isn't a label. Name is like the incarnation is for Christianity. It is a way in which the physical and the spiritual, the intelligible and the perceptual, have been brought together. Beauty isn't a label for God. Beauty is a way in which God is God.

7.63 He argues, as we've been arguing, that beauty is metaxu. It's between a transcendent plenitude and imminent determinate objects. We've been doing that all the way through. He even uses the idea that, right, Dionysus is pointing to an inexhaustible plenitude that comes into specific things in perception. This is all familiar to you now. We've been doing this a lot already. A lot. God is the inexhaustible transcendent and that is non-logically identical with the imminent principle of determination, specificity, plenitude, presence, all of that stuff. God, in that sense, is beauty.

7.64 But we already saw that prefigured in Neoplatonism. If we don't feel that that model of the One requires the two-worlds mythology, then we don't have to specially solve the problem. We can just say, "Oh, the One is beauty." Now, he then moves on to something that's extremely helpful, which is Aquinas. Now, Aquinas is a person that, in some ways, really solidified the dichotomy between the supernatural and the natural. Its work is a lot more subtle than that. He's a titanic genius. But many people that followed Aquinas, that's the lesson they took from it, and that's how it's entered into our understanding, our cultural cognitive grammar.

7.65 That's why we have a problem with beauty. We even pretend like there's two beauties, sometimes to try and separate them from it. There's spiritual beauty and there's physical beauty. I haven't met a person in which those two are completely disconnected from each other. All right, so what's Aquinas say? Aquinas really brings out how beauty, metaxu, beauty is between, binds together, bridges between the good and the true. So beauty is the glue between the good and the true. It sounds like a Dr. Seuss saying or something like that.

- 7.66 We've talked about this before. You need those glued together or you can't do science. If you don't experience, that's not even the right word, if you don't realize, participate in, that truth is good in and of itself, you're not going to be a good scientist. One of the things Sammon does is actually go through some of the work about how much beauty has a huge influence on science. We've talked about that a bit already. OK, so what does this mean now? We've been talking about this in and out.
- 7.67 I'm going to try and give you the Platonic, Neoplatonic answer about what the good is. People spend their entire careers on this. Again, I'm very trepidatious. I'm going to give you, I believe what I'm saying, but I want to be appropriately humble, actually, about it. I think that's the right word. But the good is a fullness of being. It sounds weird at first. Well, let's try and talk about this a little bit more. You take a look at the work of David Yaden, some of the work he's done with other people, Newberg and others. What you can do is, what happens when people have mystical, transformative experiences?
- 7.68 One of the things, and I've argued that we even did a correlational study online to provide evidence for this, don't pay attention to the what of the experience, because people report very different "results" from their mystical experiences. Like, literally, Taylor, in one of his books, I think it's Waking Up, I can't remember which one he talks about, he has a whole bunch of reports. One person has a mystical experience and says, "Now I know there's a God." Then right next to it is, "Now I know there's no God." It's like, what do you do with that? You don't pay attention to the product, you pay attention to the process.
- 7.69 What seems to be happening is the most systematic insight. It's an insight that covers everything and the most systemic. It's an insight that includes the whole person. It's the whole of the person involved with all of reality. It's this most systematic and systemic insight possible. It's deeply, deeply transformative of people. People will often use phrases along the line of "the really real" or Real with a capital R. Then here's what you need to know. Now, think about the triple transcendence and guidance, normativity.
- 7.70 This becomes the ultimate guide of their life. They will change their relationships, their career, their self, in order to become closer, more in contact with, more participating in, more conforming with the really real. Why? Because that is the anagogic satisfaction. You get inner integration and you're in touch with what is most real. I've coined a term for this. Try to use it. The Greek word for being is onto, like in ontology, ontos. This really real and the goodness of the really real is ontonormativity. It's not ethical. It's not ethical goodness. It's not about being, doing good in that sense. It's not aesthetic goodness.
- 7.71 This is a deep kind. This is deeper. This is a sort of ur-goodness. It's a fullness of being experienced by a fullness of being. Why the fullness of being? Anagoge. This is what anagoge gets you to. This is the deepest, deepest reciprocal opening, and therefore, we regard it as simultaneously the most real and the most transformative. The things that are simultaneously the most real and the most transformative, that can guide our lives

and fill our lives with the connectedness that gives us meaning in life, that's kind of the ur-normativity for us. That's goodness. So fullness of being, the inexhaustible plenitude, the excess of intelligibility.

- 7.72** This is why many people think the good is—a synonym for the good is the sacred. I'm not proposing that, but you can see why. Because the sacred is most real and most guiding and most transformative. As I keep reminding you, the word good comes, was related to the word God. That's the good. What's the true? Now, here, Aquinas is moving more towards prioritizing propositional knowing, determinate specific content. The good is that which gives you—sorry, the truth is when you have determinate content for cognition. Now, he has a conformative theory, and that's really important. He doesn't have our modern theory, and I want to put that just on record, but he's still ultimately talking more and more about how our thoughts are true.
- 7.73** Here's the argument. This is the plenitude, and this is determinate content. What have we seen argued throughout? What holds them together is beauty. Beauty is how inexhaustible goodness, the plenitude of reality, comes into specific, determinate things. It's also how specific, determinate things are called into a more comprehensive context, a gestalt, that ultimately leads us into mystery and back into the plenitude. We've done this multiple times. This is Aquinas' idea that beauty is the glue between the good and the true.
- 7.74** What's going on here? Well, like I said, beauty is metaxu between the good and the true. That also allows us to find the true good, which we need for science and reason. We also find there's something true about being good. We even have that in our phrase. A lot of ethics is about being true to someone or something. What have we got here? Well, what we've got is what have been called the transcendental, the three things that most reveal being, reality, but not in some merely theoretical way, but in a way that goes into the very guts of our experience. We have the true, the good, the beautiful.
- 7.75** I'm going to do it like this because Aquinas, of course, argues that they all do this to each other. Beauty is the metaxu between the true and the good, but the true is also between the beautiful and the, et cetera, et cetera. They all are interpenetrating. Then, what you do, if you're Thomas Aquinas, which is not a bad thing to be, by the way—but don't see this as just a square. See this as the opening of the mystery. When you have that, and I can only do it with gestures, around this triad, you realize, oh, there's something that holds all of them together and into which they belong in this ultimately mysterious fashion. That's God for Aquinas.
- 7.76** And you can also see why this would be sacred, because, of course, it's most real, it's most normative, it's most transformative. It's powerful. You have every right, philosophically, to disagree with this. You may reject his Catholicism. I'm not a Catholic. What you can't do is dismiss it.

Lecture 8: Beauty and Life

At a glance — Beauty and life — building a new language for beauty.

- 8.1** We, and this is what I've been trying to do with you, we have to build a language that doesn't belong to, isn't specific to Catholicism that will allow us to talk about all of this and connect it up to our best science and our best philosophy. That's what we've been trying to do together here. Because if we're going to address the meaning crisis, we have to reconnect the two worlds, the spiritual and the scientific. As long as we dichotomize them and pit one against the other and prioritize one over the other, we will fall into nihilism. At least that's what I'm arguing.
- 8.2** In the book, Sammon goes very carefully through Plato, then Plotinus, then Proclus, into Dionysius and Aquinas. It's this really careful, my gosh, what an impressive argument. He's a really good writer, too. Very powerful historical argument. He's got this framework that I've laid out for you, and then he uses that framework and he goes all the way through, all the way through. All these people that have said that God is beauty. What does he draw from that? He draws from that really impressive arguments, the characteristics of beauty.
- 8.3** They show up in the last chapter of the book. You read this whole book. It's not a thin book either, by the way, reading it. On the very end, the final chapter is, OK, this is what beauty is. Of course, he's talking about it all the way along. Like I say, he's not giving a definition because you really can't give a definition. But that final chapter is entitled this way, and this chapter wouldn't make sense to you unless I've done all this work with you. The final chapter is entitled Beauty as Between. That's the title. All of these characteristics of beauty are aspects of how it is metaxu. Let's go through them.
- 8.4** Now, he makes a point, and I've already alluded to it, that sets up why he's going through the list, and I think we should pause and take a look at it. He said beauty's proper place is between truth and goodness. Because of the way we've dichotomized everything, we have them separate from each other. We have science that's about the truth, and then we have ethics that is about the good, and we have no idea how they belong together, which is a disaster. That's nihilism, basically. Well, it's true, but who cares? Oh, that's what you should do, but it's not real. Good luck with that. Try to live like a human being. Try to do, actually, do anything of merit.
- 8.5** He says, we've got to get back to having the beauty as the glue that holds them together, the metaxu. Hey, it all rhymes. Keep doing this. OK, so one more comment before we go into the list. Part of it is I'm just trying to be provocative and avoid, I'm slightly putting off delaying gratification. I'm giving you the list. But also, I want to make a point. He's going to give a feature list, and I'm very critical of feature lists. Remember the bird is just feathers and we need the gestalt that holds it together. Well, my students, that's what this course has been. The course has been building a powerful

philosophical framework and cognitive scientific framework to give you the gestalt that will hold this list together.

- 8.6** He's not saying that. That's what I have been arguing. OK, now here's the list. A lot of this is going to be, "I've heard this before." Of course, that's the point. Number one, beauty is transcendent plenitude. OK, I got that. Sort of that intelligible excess that transcends our cognition. Yeah, got that. Combinatorially explosive. Yeah, good. OK. Two, beauty is a principle of determination. Yeah. Discernible clarity. It makes things shine, makes them present, but specifically before us, all of that. Yep, done that, too.
- 8.7** I love this one. Beauty is the good in the process of becoming true. Well, we just did that. That relates to so much of what we've been talking about, too. Notice how relevance plugs you into what's true, but also in a way that's good for you. Four, beauty is the anagogical power that enables intellectual ascension. Enables anagoge, right? That's what we get. Five, beauty is the intelligibility of being prior to it becoming determinate. It's like, what? OK, that was weird. That one was hard. Well, not really. It's an excess of intelligibility. There's the mysterious plenitude, and beauty is plugged into that and is helping us bring it into determinate thought.
- 8.8** There's not that much difference between five and four. Four is more cognitive and five is more ontological. Now, this one we've talked about a bit, but not as much, so I welcome the opportunity to unpack this a bit. Six, beauty is the whole in the part. Now, that's how he puts it. That's good. But here's where I would want Spinoza rather than him. Spinoza says it's not only how the whole is in the part, it's how the part is in every whole. So Spinoza has a way of explaining this, but it's not just an explanation. Yes, and I do want to do a course on Spinoza and Einstein's God.
- 8.9** Spinoza, so you read—have any of you read the Ethics, his most greatest work? You read the Ethics, and it looks like a mathematical proof. There are axioms and theorems and things are proved, and it's like this huge argument. It's not easy. It's like doing math, with words, which is hard. One of the nicest compliments I was ever given was one of my coauthors on the original relevance realization paper. He said to me, because he's a scientist, he says, "John, you somehow think in words what most people need math to do." I like that. That's why I'm attracted to Spinoza. It's not something you'd put on your dating app.
- 8.10** You're reading this, and it's so crunchy, and you go back and forth. It's what Pierre Hadot would call a spiritual exercise. You're doing this tremendous thing. Then this thing happens, and he actually talks about it in the Ethics. You get *scientia intuitiva*, scientific intuition. What does he mean by that? There's a moment when you're reading an argument where you see how, you get it. You see the whole of the argument in each premise, and you see how each premise goes into the whole of the argument. Does that make sense to you? Yes, you get that.

- 8.11** When somebody is giving you a proof or an argument, and you, "I get it. I get where it's going. I get the whole thing." But that doesn't mean you get it. But you see how the part is in the whole, but you also see how the whole is in each part. Is that OK? That's scientia intuitiva. What's astonishing is, you have that moment while you're reading the Ethics, but it happens in terms of what you're reading about, and it's his, it's his theory of ultimate reality and how to love it wisely.
- 8.12** You don't just get some fact. You get this scientia intuitiva in which you feel like you're in the presence of ultimate reality and you feel yourself—he calls it the intellectual love of God, which doesn't mean intellectual in our current way. Language I would use from what we've done, he means the noetic love of God. I would say that's what beauty is. Beauty is not only how the part, how the whole is in the part. See the emphasis on the top-down here? Do you see it? Oh, it's how the whole is in the part. Yeah, it is. But it's also, Spinoza, who's a good non-theist, it's also how the part is in the whole, and how they actually interpenetrate each other completely. That's beauty.
- 8.13** That was a moment of intellectual beauty for me. I was like, "Oh, that's beautiful." Fluency, right? It's brilliant on his part. That moment of scientia intuitiva is intense fluency. What does it make you think about something? It's so beautiful and it's so true. Of course, I'm a father, and I infected my son with this, and now he's a devotee of Spinoza. He's a high school biology teacher who loves Spinoza and tries to actually engage in practices in order to be a good follower of Spinoza. That's how I would modify that. Because again, that purely top-down, that's part of the problem.
- 8.14** But what ultimately makes that possible, number six, is the fact that cognition and being have the same grammar. That's how they can interpenetrate each other in that mutually holographic fashion. Number seven, we haven't talked about very much, but it's very important. Although I've alluded to it in very many ways, especially when I was doing the meta-political argument that I made and other related arguments. This is the seventh feature. Beauty is the community of being. Wouldn't that be great to have on a T-shirt? It would confuse everybody. It sounds what? Beauty is the community of being.
- 8.15** OK, first of all, what would help is to give this a Neoplatonic twist. How I can do that is pointing to you to what the word community comes from. That's how you get the word community, the common unity, the common Oneness. What he means is, beauty is how we participate in the One. Oh, that's powerful. Then of course, by using that language of community, what's he alluding to? He's alluding to the fact that this has cultural and political consequences for us. I tried to explicate what some of those might be.
- 8.16** The cognitive science framework we have built together helps make sense of all of this and thereby comprehend and appreciate the whole Christian Neoplatonic tradition. You remember, I qualified that by saying, I don't think we should be exclusively focused on the Christian Neoplatonic tradition. I think we should pay attention to the Islamic Neoplatonic tradition or the scientific Neoplatonic tradition epitomized by people like

Spinoza and Einstein, or we should pay attention to something that stands outside of but can be in deep dialogue, dialogos, dialogos with Neoplatonism, Zen.

- 8.17** But nevertheless, this is powerful. This is powerful and important, and it's what we need to do what we have been promising to do from the very beginning, which is to turn to the work of D.C. Schindler, who gave us the title of the course, The Primacy of Beauty. It comes from his essay, a book chapter. The book is The Catholicity of Reason. He doesn't mean being Catholic, although he is. He's using Catholic in the ancient, what the word actually means. It means universal. But of course, he's playing with the word Catholic because he wants to talk about the sacredness.
- 8.18** The title of the book chapter, the book is entitled The Catholicity of Reason, the Catholicity of Reason. The book chapter is entitled The Primacy of Beauty, the Centrality of Goodness, and the Ultimacy of Truth. That's from 2013. He's actually also developed that thinking. First of all, I'm going to do this again. Thank you, David. This course would not have existed if I did not read that chapter. Ongoing inspiration from his work. Profoundly important.
- 8.19** I went on to read, and I used it in a course I taught, a more recent book where he develops these ideas that he developed in that book chapter. The book is from 2018, and now this should really start to ring for you, Love and the Postmodern Predicament. Really good book. Catholicity of Reason, thick. Love and the Postmodern Predicament, much thinner. Both are worth reading. But in some ways, I think the second book, while not as philosophically complex as the book chapter, it unpacks it more and gives you a deeper sense of why he's doing what he's doing.
- 8.20** Why is he doing this? It's a way that really resonates with me. In that book, there's three chapters that I'm going to tap into. One is Beauty, the Manifestation of Reality. That shouldn't sound weird to you anymore. Beauty, the Manifestation of Reality. We sort of, oh yes. Now that I have all of this, I know what he means. Beauty and Love, another book chapter. Well, yeah, we've done that. Pretty good. Then the last one is Love and Being. That one we're going to need to slow down on. OK?
- 8.21** Let's start with the primacy of beauty, and we've seen that. Just a quick tour of where we've been and how we laid that out. In Scarry, the primacy of beauty, beauty prepares us for truth and justice. Vervaeke picked up on Scarry's work and how beauty is imaginal, existential, etc, experiential, plausibility, and we have the primacy of plausibility that I argued for. We then went into Sedivy. Beauty binds perception on cognition—excuse me. Beauty binds perception and conception together and makes cognition possible. Also, we talked about the imaginal again there. I talked about the primacy of the imaginal and how it is central to our cognition, and we looked at conceptual metaphor and gesture.
- 8.22** What about in Hyland? Beauty discloses us the primacy of the non-propositional and our finite transcendence, our humanity, and it makes a space-place for logos. That's

pretty primary. That's pretty primacy. Then we're into Sammon. The primacy of beauty shows us our primary grounding experience of being, which is metaxu, is the deep participation in ultimate reality, the One, God, sacredness. It binds transcendence and eminence together. It affords anagoge, the cultivation of wisdom, meaning in life, virtue, the fullness of being.

- 8.23** I worked hard with you to bind this all together with 4E, maybe 6E. The fifth E would be exaptation. The sixth would be emotion because we shouldn't be separating emotion and cognition like we've done culturally. They're not separate. The brain doesn't separate them. They're completely interwoven. Remember, relevance is not cold calculation. It is caring, but it is also the core of intelligence. I worked hard to bind this all together with a 4E, maybe 6E, cognitive science, the 4Ps of knowing, and the framework of predictive processing, the imaginal, and relevance realization, which gives us transjective connectivity.
- 8.24** Now, what does Schindler do? As I said, Schindler is deeply influenced by Desmond. By the way, I think D.C. Schindler has written the greatest book ever written on Plato. It's called Plato's Critique of Impure Reason. It's astonishing. Schindler is influenced by Desmond, who we've seen. He's influenced by Heidegger. Remember the notion of truth as occurrence, aletheia, realization. He's influenced by somebody you haven't heard me talk about very much, von Balthasar, who's a very important theologian who made beauty the central thing within his theology. Of course, as a Catholic, D.C. Schindler is profoundly influenced by Thomas Aquinas.
- 8.25** If you want to see a good thing talking about the relationship between Heidegger, von Balthasar, and beauty, there's a really little thin book by Philip Gonzales from 2009 called Myth as the Revelation of the Beauty of Being. What a great title. Myth as the Revelation of the Beauty of Being in Heidegger and von Balthasar. This is also another thing that we've touched on because we have the imaginal, but myth, and myth, and myth binds the imaginal and the symbolic, and it's bound to ritual. Here's where I could teach another course, but we're just going to keep going.
- 8.26** But take a look at that book if you want to go, how are Heidegger and von Balthasar related to being and beauty? Well, that little book gives you a really good answer. If you're interested in myth, and you should be, if you're taking a course at the Peterson Academy, then that's a good little book to look at. David says something really wonderful. He said, "Beauty is a foretaste of being's good truth." Beauty is a foretaste of being's good truth. This is why he gets to be D.C. Schindler. What a beautiful phrase. I take hours unpacking, and he just, beautiful phrase. It's just really wonderful.
- 8.27** Schindler's point is that this foretaste, that's our experience of primacy, this foretaste is absolutely essential to reason. With the foretaste of the goodness of being, reason's aspirational quest would not be motivated or assured. He notes, with Socrates, that philosophy begins in wonder, and wonder is deeply provoked by beauty. He actually says, wonder is the "subjective correlate to beauty." I'm not quite happy with

subjective, I would say transjective, but hey, between friends, let's just keep going. The fact that it's correlate, I think he really wants to point to the binding of the two together. So I don't think he'd be too upset with me.

- 8.28** So his point is, this is the primacy of beauty. And it continues into the centrality of goodness. Well, how? And he does something, what you've already seen, anagogic fullness of being. And it's completed in truth, the truth of aletheia, the connectedness that makes coherence and correspondence possible and gives us deep participation in realness and makes it possible for us to have determinate thought that we judge to be true. This is how you get the primacy of beauty, the centrality of goodness, and the ultimacy of truth.
- 8.29** Notice that each one is a superlative. They're all the best in different ways that are interconnected. True follower of Aquinas here. He's got the true, the good, and the beautiful. They're all interpenetrating each other. Beauty's, primacy of the beautiful, the centrality of the good, the ultimacy—he's got all of that. And of course, around it is the One. David is deeply influenced by Plato and Neoplatonism. And of course, for D.C. Schindler, the One that is the mysterious gestalt that is not a gestalt, it includes everything, but it doesn't enclose anything.
- 8.30** That, the constant transframing, as I called it, when you put that all together and within it, that's what D.C. Schindler means by the Catholic God. Of course, you're saying, "Well, that's Aquinas." Yes, he's a Catholic. Of course, it's Aquinas. That's the point. Now, you can say, well, you led up to all of that, but you've already said all of that. That's the point. But I want to show what he does with it. David takes all of that and he takes it into the postmodern predicament.
- 8.31** I need to remind you that love is not an emotion. Love is an existential mode. It's the being mode in which we deeply participate in reciprocal opening, that kind of knowing that is deeply connected to meaning in life, that connects us to the mysterious depths of reality within, without, in between. I need to remind you that because he's going to bridge between being and love and beauty.
- 8.32** I need everything that I've argued, and in addition to the work he's doing, to say, like Schindler, I've argued and continue to argue that the response to—stick with me through the list—nihilism, despair, meaninglessness, a tsunami of bullshit, a narcissism epidemic, a loneliness epidemic, disconnection, sense of absurdity, mental health crisis, pseudo-political ideologies that are treated by people in a religious fashion, et cetera, et cetera, et cetera, the meaning crisis— like Schindler, I've argued that the response to that, which he calls the postmodern predicament, isn't going to be any proposition that is the conclusion of an argument or a theory.
- 8.33** It doesn't mean we shouldn't make arguments or do philosophy. I'm not saying that. But like the way Sammon titled his title, Awakening to the Between—that's why I did Awakening From the Meaning Crisis— all of that cannot primarily be addressed by the

conclusion of a propositional argument. Why? Because the reduction of all the kinds of knowing to the propositional, propositional tyranny, is part of the cause of the meaning crisis. You can't play a corrupt game and get to a virtuous conclusion.

- 8.34** We can't— I have to tell you, this is sometimes frustrating to me because people will say, "Give me the answer." I'll say, "You've misunderstood it. It's like you're asking me, what time is it on the sun?" You want a proposition that will tell you the solution to the meaning crisis. I can do a set of propositions that point you, but it can't be properly held there because most of the meaning in life is supported by non-propositional ways of knowing. Beauty, relevance, et cetera. Remember what meaning in life requires? It requires the sense of non-egoic connectedness to something that is most real, to which we feel deeply responsible.
- 8.35** It's a reciprocal opening. That's why flow is so powerful for us. Flow is that reciprocal opening. That's why you get this ongoing sense of discovery. Remember that? We talked about. But what is the comprehensive way, systemically through us and systemically through our life, in which we can engage non-propositional knowing and afford that sense of non-egoic connectedness to that which is deeply real in a process of ongoing reciprocal opening? That's love. That's love as an existential mode.
- 8.36** If I had said that at the beginning of the course, you would have all winced. You should have, too, by the way. But here's the proposal. As a proposition, it doesn't work because you have to put it into practice. You have to let it transform your consciousness and cultivate your character to get it. If you just think you can get it with propositions, it's like only reading the Kama Sutra and never making love. You don't get it. You haven't got it. You've looked at pictures and you've read words and you don't get it. I hope that's not the only thing they clip from this series.
- 8.37** OK, here's what I'm going to tell you, what I think the solution to the meaning crisis is. We have to learn to deeply fall in love with being again, so we're not living in a universe, so we're living in a cosmos. But not in a way that's nostalgic, and certainly not a way that's pseudo-religious, ideologically utopic. That's not going to work. Now, notice, I didn't say you need to fall in love with everything because there's a lot of stuff you're not going to love, and I'm not telling you to love it.
- 8.38** Don't make the category mistake. Don't make the category mistake. I'm talking about falling in love with being, not with a thing or a situation. One of the functions, and I say this respectfully, that God used to do was, God was a way of falling in love with being, as opposed to any being or thing or set of things. In order to fall in love deeply with being, we need to find being, not a being, although it has to show up in some beings. Remember the whole in the part, the part in the whole. We need to find being profoundly beautiful. Cosmos, not universe.
- 8.39** We need to connect this to truth and goodness. It has to be ultimately real and ultimately guiding for us as well. This is how Schindler's work converges with mine. He's

drawing all of this together to make this profound proposal about how we can fall in love with being, and for him, God, again, in a way that is not antithetical or disconnected from the cultivation of our deepest reason, our best science, our most articulated and justified ethics, but is deeply enmeshed, does not split the spiritual and the scientific from each other. Now, David and I disagree a bit about that, about how much, but it's a good disagreement. It's a healthy one.

8.40 This is the argument that he lays out in *Love, in Love and the Postmodern Predicament*. The first central claim he makes, which he argues at length in a chapter, is beauty is the manifestation of being. I'm not going to go into that because—the whole course. The whole course. The whole course. The whole course. OK. Another thing we've already talked about and developed at length, beauty is bound up with love. Beauty causes love, love causes beauty. Chicken and egg, you can't tell where it went, starts, and blah, blah, blah, blah.

8.41 In this two-ness, but togetherness and oneness of beauty in love—sorry for that language, but trying to bend language here— we recognize "this reception of reality's self-disclosure is a kind of a attuning." He does this because he wants you to understand he's trying to, he wants you to bend the word as far as you can metaphorically. "Is a kind of attuning and proportioning of the soul to the real." Again, I'm using romantic love because that's where we've tried to stick all of the sacredness.

8.42 Sorry, like I said, that really frustrates me. It makes people want what they can't have in their romantic relationships. Then they will collapse from that into a purely bestial, self-gratifying attitude towards Eros. OK, so this attuning and proportioning of the soul to the real. When you really love somebody, you really realize them and allow them to realize themselves through you. Of course, there's different kinds of love, and I would like to teach a course on that, but I talk about this also in some of my online stuff. There's eros, there's philia, there's agape.

8.43 But the point he's making is that beauty, love, shapes the soul to the real, which is absolutely necessary for reason, understood as logos, not just as logic. Not excluding logic, but understood as logos. There's another quote. "Contemplation is a knowing," which obviously means there's many kinds of knowing. "Contemplation is a knowing that resembles the beholding of beauty. It is the shape of reason in, indeed, in some sense, as love." This rational, contemplative knowing love allows us to realize and identify with, participate in a profound love for being, for ultimate reality, in a way that isn't abstract and over there, but profoundly here.

8.44 I don't know what's with me and Spinoza today, but anyways, another profound thing, I was reading Spinoza. He's really good for this. You do all this logic and you feel like you're in a logic class, and then he'll just say something that's just incredibly insightful. He said, I'm reading this, "God does not have abstract thoughts." Because he can't. Because God isn't just up there. I said, "Whoa." He said if you really want to love God, participate in God, they can't be purely abstract for you. If truth is just an abstract

thing, if it is not something that you bind your identity to and love, then you are not capacitated for being as reasonable and rational and virtuous as human beings can be, and virtuous as human beings can be. You need that reciprocal opening.

- 8.45** Now, David came up with his own phrase. He called it reciprocal indwelling. That's great. That works, too. You feel that, too, when you love somebody deeply. You dwell in them, and they dwell in you. I'm carrying around my partner, and I don't mean in some creepy fashion, in my head all day long, which is why when you lose somebody you profoundly love, it's such a tear, because it's not like when you lose an object over there. When you lose a person you love, this part of you and a way in which it connects to reality is lost.
- 8.46** It's like a doorway between your soul and the world that gets closed and can't be opened again. You go, "But I need that doorway." That's grief. That's why grief is so much more than just realizing something's no longer true. What happens is, this love gives us a sacredness, a connectedness, which is the antidote to— and I'm going to do one more of these where I break up a word for you to remind you—it's the antidote to the dis-ease of the meaning crisis.
- 8.47** Because remember, what does ease point us towards? Where we started. Fluency. But this isn't like ease, in some trivial sense. Disease is, like it encompasses your whole being. The fluency that is at the core of your agency is not working. There's another way of understanding the meaning crisis. That existential fluency that we profoundly need is not being nurtured and educated by our culture. This is why when I asked you, "Where do you go for wisdom?" "I don't know."
- 8.48** I want to say this charitably. The fact that people turned to the Marvel universe for this—they were initially great movies. The recent stuff has been horrible. If you don't think that's a religious thing for people, go to Comic-Con. Boy, is it religious. They dress up, they have rituals. It's like, oh, wow. I remember when I went there and I was like, "I won't survive this unless I take a purely anthropological attitude to what's going on here. That's the only way I'm going to get through this." I was there with my son and my stepdaughter.
- 8.49** You know it's sacred to them because when people corrupt that mythological universe with political ideology, they rage. They don't go, "Oh, well, I'll turn to channel." No, no. "How dare you? How dare you? You broke my sacred." Again, I like the movies. I'm not a film critic. That's not what I'm doing. But that's not the place where we should be going to get our education into meaning and myth and wisdom and virtue. That should be some very infrequent periodic icing on a much more well-baked cake.
- 8.50** If we can recover, and I've used that word throughout, and I now want to say what I mean by that as well. If we can recover the sense of beauty, so I'm pausing on recover. The problem with the recover is you can just hear it from the having mode. "I got that back. You had it. Now it's mine again. Yay." I want to use it in the way that Tolkien uses

it about fantasy literature, which complements nicely what I just said about the MC universe. Notice it was a universe, by the way. OK.

- 8.51** Now, Tolkien said fantasy, good fantasy, isn't escapism. Now, of course, there's nothing wrong with reading something for escape because sometimes you just need to get away. But he said good fantasy is like the following. You're like an anthropologist. You're in this culture, and so I'm wearing these glasses. The glasses are so automatic and transparent, I'm only dimly aware of them. Is that OK? Now, when I go to the other culture, these glasses don't work. I have to go through deep noetic and participatory transformation, and I have to put on new glasses. Then, now I get it. Now I fit in. Now I belong.
- 8.52** That's the ethnographic process. Anthropologists talk about how demanding and arduous. They often use language that borders on the psychological and the spiritual or the religious, to talk about the transformation they have to go through. By the way, that's why they frequently come to deeply love the culture that they're studying. But that's not the point, right? Now I pretend, I only have one pair, but I've taken off the glasses that I was wearing over there and I put these glasses on, and then I come back and now I can see my culture in ways I couldn't see before. I've recovered my culture.
- 8.53** In fantasy, you go into a good other world, put on other glasses, and then come back to this world and recover it. This is called the recovery theory of fantasy. Good science fiction will do the same. Poetry will do the same thing, too. T. S. Elliott. "We will return to the place from which we left and know it again for the first time." Poetry does the same thing. Good art, I would propose, should allow you to recover reality, not just shock you with the new. We need to recover beauty.
- 8.54** This course has been, I hope in a gentle and fun way, you were in this country, and this course took you over here and gave you new glasses. You can come back now and look at where you are and see it differently in a way that might allow you to recover the universe as a cosmos and live, because that's the only way it can be done, live the solution to the meaning crisis. Central to that is the primacy of beauty. Thank you very much. OK. We're going to do some Q&A.
- 8.55** In the first lecture, we spoke about the having mode and the being mode. I'm wondering what your opinion is, if there is one, on a creation mode or a giving mode. Is it like a metaxis between the having mode and being mode? What does that mean in regards to love and beauty? Especially if we look at language, for example. Let's talk about, because you spoke about pornography at the beginning. We can talk about pornography and then there's having sex, which is a having mode. Then you're being in love, which is a being mode, but then you also make love.
- 8.56** Yeah, and Fromm talks about that, the art of loving and making love. Yes, good point.
- 8.57** What does that all mean in terms of this?

- 8.58** OK. First of all, the making of love is not like the making of a cabinet. You acknowledge that. You're not making—in fact, and I like the word you use, we're actually co-creating together. We're in metaxu, we're participating, we're mutually indwelling, reciprocal opening, all of that stuff.
- 8.59** It's like an offering up to the oneness as well, maybe.
- 8.60** Yes, it is. I mean, properly proportioned in perspective and in participation, you should love the relationship, as well as loving the person to whom you are in relation. And many people will say that. I would say this. I won't cheat on this person, not only because I don't want to hurt her, but this relationship is one of the best I have ever been in in my entire life. It has a beauty that I also have reverence for. You need that, because you need to have something you're committed to, that you share with the person when you're not particularly happy with that person. Both people have to be committed to the beauty of the relationship above and beyond their commitment, not in place of, but above and beyond their commitment to each other.
- 8.61** This is the same kind of, when I was talking about democracy. We have to be committed to the relationship over what we have with respect to the other person. To my mind, that's been lost. The fact that Republicans are more afraid of Democrats and Democrats are more afraid of Republicans than either group is of China or Russia is like, what? That's not a country anymore. That's a country that's only a country geographically. You have to have a commitment to the relationship as a living—and I think as a living entity that is not the same as, but is not also separate from, how you love the other.
- 8.62** I think when we're talking about making love, we're talking about that. I teach a practice called Dialectic into Dialogos, and what happens is, people learn how to communicate dialogically, not just monologically, where I tell, I give you information, and then you give me information, and I give you—and we'll disagree about who's right and who's wrong, the standard shtick. What you do is you get people, and what you do is, you get them to, no, no, no. What you want is, try to make your communication as mutually transformative as possible. Reciprocal opening.
- 8.63** Now, what happens is, first of all, people say, this is—Plato would love this— people say, "I discovered a kind of intimacy I've always been longing for and I didn't know existed." Again, how did they do that? What does that mean? If you didn't know about it, how were you always longing for it? That's the metaxu of love. You got this, they do that, and first they talk about this, and they feel how they're coming fully alive, and then it moves. People start to feel not only intimate to the other person, they start to feel intimate to the logos that is taking on a life of its own.
- 8.64** They start to feel, and they use different names for it, logos, the we space, the spirit, the geist. People that are totally non-religious start to use religious language. Then, then, if they practice it more, you get a third move. It's not only, I'm intimate with you

and we're intimate with the logos, we're intimate through the logos with being. That's the making that's going on in making love. I don't think it's like making a cabinet.

- 8.65** Actually, this came up a lot as a gut thought during the first half of this as well as the second half, this idea you kept coming back to. All these metaxis, like beauty, good, all these things that are obviously very intrinsic and fundamental to the nature of reality or to us, and things like relevance realization, where it's not objective, subjective, it's the essence between them. Then that made me keep thinking of this idea that has come up recently of a collective conscience, and if that could be a supporting argument or supporting proof of there, in fact, being a collective consciousness, because there are these principles that keep guiding metaxis, and it trickled down from there.
- 8.66** Yeah, and that's totally relevant to what I just said about how the logos shows up in dialectic into dialogos. Dialectic is something you practice, dialogo—the logos had to show up on its own or it's not the logos. You can't make it like the way you make a cabinet. It's not a technical product. So, but back to your point. Published three papers with Dan Chiappe, wrestling with this. Now, we picked something that's really, a really good cognitive science challenge. We were talking about how the NASA scientists on Earth manipulate the robot rovers on Mars. Because we thought if there's any place where it's going to be disembodied, disconnected, it's got to be that because there's all the delay. All they're getting, by the way, from Mars is flat black-and-white pictures.
- 8.67** Let me tell you one part just to show you how it connects with everything we're talking about. They don't do this purely propositionally, even though they're scientists. They are scientists. I shouldn't have done that. They are scientists. I don't know why I did that. They look for people who can do this. This will sound weird. They look for people who can be on Mars as the rover. Now, obviously, nobody can do that literally; that would be weird. That would just be insane. But they want people who can, and I'm using this word imaginally, "I'm the rover on Mars."
- 8.68** They do things to make that happen. They'll do things like, of course, they'll identify with the rover. Please remember that. They'll talk about, "We need to go there. We need to do this, or I need to do this. I need to go there." But they do both. But they also do other things. They not only anthropomorphize the rover—this is based on the work of Vertesi and other ethnographers, anthropologists who study these people, really cool— but they'll also technomorphize themselves. There's one where the one scientist, she's sitting on a wheeled chair like this, and she's trying to, how they need to move the rover. She puts her phone in front and she goes, "We need to do this."
- 8.69** These are the cameras on the rover. This is the moving. The rover has four wheels, and she's trying to convey the non-propositional. They loop this. They loop this. Do you see how that's very imaginal? Then they take the photographs and they mark the photographs with colored markers, as a way of triggering this, so that they suddenly can feel like they're on Mars as the rover. Because the people who do that can actually

use the rover well to do the field work on Mars, to study whether or not there was water on Mars.

- 8.70** What they do is, they organize themselves in order to create, to afford, or to create in the sense of not making, to create the logos between them. There is no one person that is doing of this. It is very much the logos of the group that is running the rovers. And Vertesi said the rover becomes like a totem for them. She actually uses that word, a religious term, because somehow the group identity and the rover are identified together, and it makes them say weird stuff. This is like a verbatim. It's not verbatim, but it's very close.
- 8.71** One of them said, "I was in the garden and I was working, and my right wrist got hurt and stuck. And I got to work, and Spirit," that's the name of the rover, by the way, "and the Spirit's right front wheel kept getting stuck. I'm not saying there's magic, but I don't know." They did weird, weird language like this. They laugh and they're nervous because they don't know what to do with the imaginal. They don't know what to do with participatory knowing, that they've bound their identity and they know it as they're knowing themselves. It only comes out in religious and magical language.
- 8.72** This is a very good instance of what you're asking me about, I hope. Is there a collective consciousness there? There's, what we argued in three papers, in three different journals, which is not an easy thing to do, by the way—and two of them were high-impact journals, too. Sorry, I'm bragging. I'll go back to it. OK, so anyways, we argued there's collective intelligence, but there isn't collective consciousness. There's collective, complex, sophisticated relevance realization, but we don't have any evidence for the hallmarks of consciousness.
- 8.73** Other people have come to a convergent conclusion. Remember convergent conclusions and plausibility? They talk about zombie intelligence because a zombie is something that is intelligent but it doesn't have consciousness, or zombie agency. Now, what almost everybody says, and this is part of the extended, by the way, in the 4E extended mind idea, they say, there's no reason in principle why we couldn't connect together and not only have collective intelligence, but collective consciousness.
- 8.74** It's only because the bandwidth of our communication is too shallow, and the speed at which we communicate is too slow, and we can't get what we need in order to have what the brain has in supporting consciousness. I had to give you a long answer because that's a really important question. Now, of course, what happens in Jonathan Pageau, and I talk about this, and we agree and disagree in really fruitful ways, is, he'll say, "Yeah, you're right, it might not be conscious, but—" and he thinks about angels and things, "and maybe it is conscious." We go back and forth on that.
- 8.75** But where we both agree is, yes, but some people can, and this is really dangerous, they can become the voice of the collective intelligence and give it a kind of

consciousness or representation. And those people are very, very troubling. I'm going to use a neutral word. Very, very troubling.

- 8.76** Since I have a background of Sufi theology and Shia theology, in Ismaili Shia, they call the One "al-wujud al-ladhi la yujad," which means the existence that does not exist.
- 8.77** Yes.
- 8.78** In Twelver Shiism, they say that you cannot imagine it because it's not an it. That's not a thing.
- 8.79** Yes, exactly.
- 8.80** The problem is that we are constantly saying it's the most real. This is what that reminded me of Mircea Eliade. The sacred is the real. The holy is the real. They are the most real, but it's not an it, it's not thing.
- 8.81** That's right.
- 8.82** The question is that, I assume, that is one of those questions that should be dissolved, but I'm getting asked a lot.
- 8.83** OK.
- 8.84** So it does exist or not, at the bottom? I don't know if it's the exist and correct terminology, but it does exist or not, then it's not an it.
- 8.85** If I understand you correctly, there's a presupposition in the question, which is to exist is to exist as a thing. This goes back to Aristotle. This is the notion of reality is ultimately grounded in substance. Substance for us means stuff. That's because of Descartes, so forget that. The original meaning is that which lies under. It's translation of the Greek hypostasis. The prototypical example of a substance in the ancient world was a person. Because a substance is something that properties belong to, that is not itself a property. Persons are subjects and owners of actions and properties, but they're not actions or properties. Is that OK?
- 8.86** Aristotle gave us that, and then Descartes changed it. I won't get into that. It's a long thing. James Filler, in his astonishing book, Heidegger, Neoplatonism, and the History of Being: Relation as Ultimate Ground, argues that that's a fundamental mistake. As I've tried to argue here, the One is pure relationality. That's what information is, by the way. Information isn't a thing, it's a pattern. Intelligibility is a relationality. You can read that argument in depth. I think the question is demanding that you agree that the touchstone of realness are substance or individual things, and that's not the touchstone of realness, because what makes it an individual thing is how it's one together but stands out in contrast, exists to stand out from other things.
- 8.87** It's the relationality between the plenitude and the specific presence that makes it. Then you want to ask, oh, but that has to be more real because that makes all the individual things possible. If you're asking me to dissolve the question, that's how I

would do it. I would say, no, you want it exists or not because you're using the model of an object that is present to me or absent to me. That's not what we're talking about here. Ask them if the law, ask them if $E=MC^2$ exists. Does it exist? You better believe it because you can smash a city with $E=MC^2$. That's what the atomic bomb does. Where is $E=MC^2$? Show me. Where is it? Please point it to me. Point where it is.

- 8.88** Where things have specific locations at specific times. $E=MC^2$, only on Tuesdays. Only near Mars. It's everywhere and nowhere. It's every time and no time. But if you don't think it's real, then explain to me the reality of the deaths at Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Even science doesn't think that reality is ultimately made up of things. We're now moving to the proposal that space and time are themselves—the very things that define individual things, space and time, they are themselves emergent out of a more primordial relationality. This is a serious contender right now in physics. That person that's asking you that question is foisting onto you a metaphysics from the 18th century that is moribund and obsolete. That's how I would dissolve that question.
- 8.89** My question has to do with art, or beauty in art. When we speak about a piece of art that is beautiful, from my understanding of this model and how this would happen, is essentially that you find the beauty in the transjective space, in the metaxu between the person beholding the art and the art expressing its beauty, and there's a fittedness where the beautiful is found. If the person leaves and the art is then on its own without anyone to behold it, is that beauty latent in it, waiting to be actualized by someone else who comes to behold it? Or is it just not there until it's perceived again? Or how does that work in this instance?
- 8.90** This is really important. This is also Filler's words. This is a really good question, Patrick, and I hope this doesn't get too technical. I'll try not to make it. You don't want to make the relation between things a property of a thing. Because if, like, see, here's A and B. If the relation between A and B belongs to A, then A doesn't need B in order to have the relation. But that's false. It can't be in B because that's also false. It can't be a property of A or a property of B. It has to be something above and beyond, not reducible to properties of A and properties of B. Does that track? So, it's not right to ask the question of, is beauty a latent property in the work of art?
- 8.91** Now, what I might say is, the work of art has a structural functional organization, your cognition does, and there's a real potential for that relationship to co-emerge between you. If that's what you mean, the answer is yes. But it means it's also equally latent in you or in other people. But I hesitate to talk that way because of what I've just said, because it starts to, I'm not accusing you of anything, but it could shift us towards the idea that it's ultimately a property of a thing again. Is that OK?
- 8.92** First off, I really appreciated your whole lecture. I think that it definitely clicked some ideas in my personal life, and I think that's what helps the most, and at least how I learn. The first lecture, you talked about sameness, sorry, being in between and how that is very helpful for transcendence. But before the second lecture put everything

together for me. But in the process of beauty and all of that, the word that kept coming to my head was deconstruction. That's maybe postmodern language. But to get there, you need to make mistakes. You deconstruct yourself, and you—before you build your puzzle, you got to put things in between and take it out. But I seem to find beauty also in the deconstruction as much as there's construction afterwards.

8.93 Frame-breaking, frame-making, yes.

8.94 I guess I'm just asking for a reassurance, if that is something that I could use as a framework as well, because deconstruction, even in the ways of seeing now in postmodern language, that's very predominant now within the ways of seeing and looking at different cultures and stuff like that. I guess, yeah.

8.95 This is a long thing. I'm supposed to participate in another possible seminar on postmodernism. So deconstruction, Derrida. Derrida is my favorite of the postmodernists. This is one way in which I disagree with my friend Jordan Peterson. I think, and Jonathan Pageau and I both think, there is important value in the postmodernists and that their arguments need to be taken seriously. The meta-modernists, they take postmodernism seriously. But what they say is, yeah, but you can actually deconstruct postmodernism as well. I've done that here. I've gone in and tried to call into question. We started from the beginning.

8.96 Now, about deconstruction itself, I've made this argument, and I've made it at academic conferences, and it was taken well, so that's at least a sign that it's got plausibility. When Derrida's talking about deconstruction, it's based on this thing that he says is not a thing, that's not a concept, which is like so Neoplatonic, wow, *différance*. *Différance* is how, whenever you're on any one representation, you always defer to another representation that's different from it. You defer and differ, and that's how you get meaning. But when I get there, I don't get into full presence because I go through *différance* again.

8.97 What deconstruction is, deconstruction is, by pointing to *différance*, you say that modernism's attempt to fully capture in a formal system, a system of propositions, what something is, gets deconstructed because *différance* rips apart any formal system. That's deconstructionism in a nutshell. It's a brilliant argument, by the way. He's right. *Différance*, what he's calling *différance*, can't be captured by a formal system. Here's two things John Vervaeke says in response to that. You know what *différance* is? It's relevance realization. You know what relevance realization can't be reduced to? Propositional knowing. It can't be captured by a formal system.

8.98 But you don't have to draw the conclusions that Derrida draws. Because Derrida is guilty of semiological reductionism. He talks about *différance*, and then he says it can't belong to the propositional system, but there's nothing but the propositional system. And there you go. You're trapped. You're endlessly deferring, and there's a trace of the trans—all that language. It's like, yes, I can't capture relevance realization, *différance*, in

structuralism. That's why it was originally called post-structuralism, because the flow of *différance*, which is not a thing and is not a concept—boy, talk about Neoplatonism. That's why he likes negative theology so much, because negative theology is Neoplatonic.

8.99 That's why he's so influenced by Levinas, too. Yes, you're right, but you're wrong in thinking that, because I can't capture it in a text, that means it endlessly is beyond us. In one way it is, but in another way it isn't. I just published a paper, first author Johannes Jäger, on how relevance realization cannot be captured by any computational formal system. But when you reframe it that way, when you deconstruct it from its identification with a semiological reductionism, you get all of this course. That's why it's a deep response, I would argue, to deconstructionism.